Session 1

2025-01-26

1 - Road to Greenest

~18:00, 22 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Eguzkilore is camped at a roadside fire, cooking a roe deer he hunted on a spit. The smell carries.
2. Drawn by the cooking smell, the rest of the party arrives in turn:
    - Nuberroca approaches first, hungry; Eguzkilore shares the food.
    - Sinsong arrives next. At some point during the gathering he casts a spell — his bald head glows brightly with the casting. Nuberroca, struck by the light, nicknames him *"Cabezabombilla"* (lightbulb-head) on the spot — the name sticks.
    - Nyx and Amidamaru arrive together — they had crossed paths earlier on the road and were already traveling as a pair.
    - Mialee arrives last, alone.
3. Over the meal, Nuberroca shares his mission: his alpine tribe's elders sent him out to investigate the rise of the undead in the pass. In response, Sinsong gives Nuberroca a vial of holy water, telling him it may help against the undead. Nuberroca pockets it to show the elders later — he doesn't know what it is, but takes Sinsong's word for its use.
4. The group decides to head to Greenest together. Approaching at dusk, they see the town under attack — fires across the rooftops, smoke rising, raiders in the streets. A **blue dragon** is visible in the sky, throwing lightning.
5. The whole party is *awestruck* by the sight of the dragon — its size and majesty, even as it kills.

2 - The looted house

1. The party moves into the town streets, looking to help where they can, and finds a townhouse being looted by a mixed group of kobolds and cultists, some of the cultists wearing Greenest guard livery.
2. Counting roughly half a dozen looters, the party sets up a stealth approach — the plan is to take them before any can call out and bring more raiders down on the street.
3. Sinsong casts a spell to prepare for the rush; his bald head flares with the casting and the light spills out into the street, giving away the party's position before they can move. **Stealth blown.**
4. Nuberroca charges first, sprinting through the doorway before the raiders can rally. Despite the lost stealth, the rest of the party still catches the looters by surprise — the goliath crashing in pins their attention long enough for the others to close.
5. The fight is short. The kobolds break and scatter, picked off by precise arrows as they run. The liveried cultists are cut down at the doorway. The house is cleared in under a minute, the looters dead.

3 - A desperate family

~19:00, 22 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. In the town streets, while trying to help where they can, the party comes upon a family pinned by a kobold pack: a wounded mother holding the kobolds off to buy time, while her badly wounded husband herds their three children toward safety.
2. The mother is overwhelmed and killed before the party can close the distance — the kobolds drag her down while the heroes are still moving in.
3. The party engages, with the priority of keeping the father and the children alive.
4. Eguzkilore and Mialee loose arrows from cover, dropping kobolds before they can reach the children.
5. Nuberroca crashes into the front of the pack, axe swinging. Amidamaru pushes in behind him with his sword, finishing off the kobolds the goliath's charge knocks aside.
6. A kobold breaks through to the father; the badly wounded husband manages to fend it off himself.
7. Nyx rushes to help him and puts herself between the man and the kobold.
8. Sinsong swings his mace to help — and fumbles, the strike landing on Nyx instead of the kobold.
9. The kobolds are swiftly defeated, but the party comes out of it bloodied. The children and the husband huddle around the dead woman, weeping. The party gathers around them, offering what comfort they can while quietly acknowledging that they cannot linger here — the streets are still hostile, and the keep is the only safe place left.
10. The husband composes himself enough to introduce himself as **Cuth**, then echoes the urgency: they must make for the keep without delay. The party falls in with Cuth and the three children and presses on.

4 - River-bank skirmish

1. The most direct route to the keep is clogged with raiders — too many to push through with **Cuth** and his three children in tow. The party detours toward the river, hoping to skirt the worst of the fighting along the bank.
2. The detour brings them in sight of a patrol crossing the river to flank the keep approach: a band of kobolds with two large drakes wading the shallows alongside them.
3. The party tucks Cuth and the three children behind cover and moves to ambush the patrol before it can spot them.
4. Mialee takes an elevated vantage on the river bank and opens with her bow from cover.
5. Eguzkilore looses arrows alongside her, dropping the leading kobolds before they understand they're being shot at.
6. Nuberroca and Amidamaru break for the drakes — the most dangerous threats in the patrol — and meet them in the river itself. Nuberroca splashes into the shallows, water sloshing around his thighs, and brings one drake down in two heavy axe strokes. Amidamaru, more at home in water than on land, slips alongside the second with his sword, working the joints below the waterline, and finishes it as it tries to turn on him.
7. Nyx slips through the bushes along the shoreline, working around the patrol's flank, and drops a kobold from behind as it tries to bring its sling up.
8. With the drakes down and the flank broken, the patrol shatters: most kobolds turn to flee across the river, while two scrabble up the near bank to get at Mialee.
9. Mialee drops one of the climbers before the other reaches her vantage and wounds her at close range.
10. Sinsong moves up the bank and, with a heavy mace strike to the back, drops the kobold pressing Mialee.
11. The remaining kobolds break and run for the far bank, vanishing into the smoke.
12. The party retrieves Cuth and the children from cover and presses on toward the keep, the family in tow.

5 - Inside the keep

~20:00, 22 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party reaches the keep gates with Cuth and his three children. The guards admit them, take charge of the family, and direct the party on to the governor.
2. Before heading inside, one of the heroes looks back from the wall: the raiders have closed a ring around the keep. The way they came in has shut behind them. The party is *locked in*.
3. **Tarbaw Nighthill**, governor of Greenest, receives them in worse shape than the title suggests — a man in his sixties with half his face wrapped in bandages, his right arm in a sling, and his pale blue tunic stained dark down one side. He has clearly had no time for more than the roughest first aid. He thanks the party for the rescue and gets straight to the situation.
4. Tarbaw lays out the situation plainly: the keep is ringed, and they need a way out — for messengers, for any defensive sortie, and for civilians still trying to reach the keep from outside. He mentions one option: an old tunnel under the keep that leads beyond the raider line. It has not been used in years and is reportedly infested with vermin; it has not been cleared.
5. At Tarbaw's call, his castellan steps forward: **Escobert the Red**, a shield dwarf whose tangled mop of bright red hair has earned him his name, an enormous ring of iron and brass keys jangling at his belt — he holds every lock in the keep. Escobert leads the party down to the tunnel entrance and hands them the keys.

6 - The Old Tunnel

1. The tunnel was built generations ago as a covert way to fetch water from the river during sieges — a covered passage running from the keep cellars down to the riverbank. Along its length, three small storage rooms are carved into the wall; at the far end, a collapsed section of stone opens into a small cave the original masons never sealed off.
2. The party descends with **Escobert**'s keys. The air is *dark, thick, and stale*, and the tunnel is alive with vermin: giant rats scurrying underfoot, and spider swarms boiling out of every corner as the lanterns reach them.
3. The party works through the tunnel. Eguzkilore and Mialee pick off the giant rats with arrows from a few paces back; Nuberroca crushes the rest at close range. When the spider swarms boil too close, Amidamaru drives them back with fire from his hand — bolts hissing into the dark, the swarms recoiling rather than pressing. The party clears most of the tunnel this way.
4. The fight is ugly even with the strategy — close work in a confined passage, weapons fouling on each other. Sinsong swings at a rat in the press and clips Mialee in the head with his mace instead.
5. They push into the first of the storage rooms. As the door opens, giant spiders drop from the ceiling — the room is a *long-undisturbed nest*, and the giants pour out in numbers the party did not expect.
6. Sinsong casts Sleep on the lead giant spider. The spell lands; the giant folds where it stands. The rest of the party closes and kills it in melee while it is helpless — a clean victory on the first of them.
7. The fight in the room turns into a brawl. Eguzkilore peppers one of the giants with arrows from the doorway until it is bristling with shafts, slowed and bleeding; Nuberroca cleaves the wounded creature down with his axe. Amidamaru's fire keeps the smaller spiders at bay so the others can work.
8. Another giant spider lands a bite on Nyx, and she goes down under the venom — when the others can next glance her way, she is breathing shallowly but holding, no longer bleeding out.
9. Mialee, still reeling from the earlier mace blow, takes a bite of her own and goes down beside Nyx, bleeding hard, the press of spiders giving no one room to reach her.
10. ***[EPIC]*** The fight bleeds back out into the tunnel. As Sinsong shifts to support the line, a spider swarm boils over him in a rush — fangs and venom finding every gap — and he is *dead before anyone can reach him*.
11. The party breaks for the keep, leaving the storage room behind. Four still on their feet, every one of them heavily wounded — Nuberroca and Amidamaru both a single bad hit from going down themselves:
    - Nuberroca scoops up Sinsong's body and Mialee, one slung over each shoulder — Mialee's bleeding has stopped at some point in the chaos, no one quite sure when.
    - Amidamaru picks up Nyx and falls in behind him.
    - Eguzkilore retreats last, alone, arrows nocked, covering the others as they go.
12. As the party clears the tunnel mouth, the last of the giant spiders withdraw deeper into the dark — both sides disengage. The lanterns' light pulls back; the tunnel goes quiet behind them.

7 - Aftermath

~21:00, 22 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party stumbles back into the keep with their dead and wounded. Sinsong's body is laid out in the hall; the others triage the living — Mialee and Nyx still unconscious, Nuberroca and Amidamaru on their feet but bleeding from a dozen lesser wounds.
2. Bringing Sinsong back becomes the only thing that matters. The party fans out through the keep, asking every guard, healer, and refugee they pass — is there a cleric here, someone with the power to bring a dead man back?
3. They find one. A cleric stationed at the keep hears them out and agrees to perform the rite — for **600 gp**.
4. The party does not have the gold. They argue, plead, empty their pouches in front of him — it isn't even close. After a long look at Sinsong's body and at the exhausted handful still standing over it, the cleric agrees to perform the rite *on credit*.
5. The rite is performed. Sinsong jolts upright with a strangled scream, clawing at his face and arms as if dragging spiders off them, shouting about the dark and the legs and the bites. It takes the party a long minute to bring him back to his senses.
6. With Sinsong breathing again and the wounded patched up, the party finds a quiet corner of the keep and rests for a while. They eat what little they can, see to their wounds, and talk over what just happened — how badly the tunnel went, what they could have done differently, what they need to be sharper at next time. By the end of the hour the change is unmistakable — their hands are steadier than the rest alone could explain, their wounds are closing visibly, and the lessons of the disaster are pressed into them.

Session 2 2025-02-02

1 - Finishing the tunnel

~22:00, 22 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The heroes are at the keep, picking up after the tunnel disaster and Sinsong's resurrection. The night has not let up; the assault is still pressing on Greenest from every side.
2. **Tarbaw** briefs them: civilians are sheltering in the temple of Chauntea; the church is under attack and needs relief. Watching the party still bandaged from the tunnel disaster, he presses three of the keep's last healing potions on them before sending them out.
3. The party returns to the lower tunnel and finishes clearing it of the residual giant rats and stray spiders left from the disastrous spider-nest fight.
4. The tunnel is now fully cleared and rehabilitated as a covert way in and out, beyond the raider line.
5. Sinsong, still recovering, remains at the keep helping the wounded. Eguzkilore takes the battlements, pinning raiders to cover his friends' sortie.
6. The party emerges from the cleared tunnel and runs straight into a small kobold patrol.
7. The fight is short. Nuberroca subdues one kobold *alive* — pinning rather than killing — and questions it on the spot.
8. ***[EPIC]*** The kobold is collaborative but renders barely any useful information. Rather than dispatch it, Nuberroca restrains the kobold and keeps it as a *"pet"*, strapped to his chest like a baby.
9. Approaching the temple, Nyx and Mialee scout ahead in good stealth; Nuberroca trails slightly behind with Amidamaru and the restrained kobold. The goliath's bulk forces him to hang back rather than lead, and even there his heavy footfalls keep threatening to give them away.
10. The two scouts carry the party past further patrols unseen.

2 - Sanctuary rescue

~23:00, 22 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The temple of Chauntea is surrounded by an external wall, already breached at the front by the time the party arrives. From the outside, they can see a loose patrol circling the perimeter — three cultists, ten kobolds, and two ambush drakes, dispersed.
2. The party closes on the wall as soon as the patrol leaves the area. Mialee climbs onto Nuberroca to peer into the temple compound, and from the elevated angle she spots two more enemy groups:
    - At the back door, four cultists and four kobolds — clustered tightly — are trying to burn it down, failing miserably and producing a prodigious smoke cloud that obscures the area.
    - At the front door across the compound, a menacing-looking cultist leader directs two cultists working a battering ram against the temple door, with six kobolds standing guard around them.
3. The rhythmic thuds of the ram already echo through the temple — the party can hear them clearly even before Mialee gets eyes on the front-door group.
4. The party scales the perimeter wall at the rear, falls on the arson detail, and kills them swiftly under cover of the cultists' own smoke. The ram keeps battering the main door.
5. The cuts the cultists landed on Nuberroca start closing with a *blue glow* while Mialee strips the robes off two of the dead cultists — one for herself and a spare for a partner — before pushing in.
6. Inside the temple, the civilians are panicked; calming them takes several minutes, and the heroes succeed only with the help of **Eadyan Falconmoon**, the half-elf priest in charge of the temple. Through the whole dialogue, the front-door ram keeps beating, each strike echoing through the sanctuary — a constant reminder that they are still in danger.
7. As the group is finishing the extraction through the back door, the main door finally gives way in a shower of splinters — the cultist leader's ram team is breaking through. At almost the same moment, outside, the loose patrol has drifted dangerously close to the back door.
8. Mialee creates a magical illusion at the main entry, pulling the attention of both cultist groups back toward the temple's entrance. The party uses the gap to slip out the back of the temple.
9. At the perimeter wall, Amidamaru and Nuberroca lift and steady the civilians across between them, one by one — slow but unobserved. Up close, the kobold strapped to Nuberroca's chest sets off fresh panic in some of the civilians as the goliath hoists them up.
10. Reaching the river with all civilians unharmed, the group heads back along the stream toward the keep.

3 – Ambush in the river

~00:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The way back follows the stream in the dead of night. Frogs croak in the shallows. The only visible lights are the distant fires and a luminous stone Amidamaru gave Nuberroca to keep them from stumbling in the dark.
2. Almost back at the tunnel mouth, the stone gives them away: a cultist patrol — five kobolds and three cultists directed by an acolyte — spots the light and ambushes the party.
3. The opening is brutal: kobolds fire their slings from cover along the bank while cultists rush in from concealed positions among the trees. The party is caught flat-footed.
4. Panic takes the civilians — some plunge into the shallows, others crash into the underbrush along the bank. **Eadyan** tries to hold them together, but the chaos outruns him; within breaths, **half the group is lost in the dark**.
5. Nuberroca answers with a counter-charge, axe up, the cloth-strapped kobold on his chest squealing as the goliath crashes into the lead cultists. Nyx moves closer to the goliath, shooting arrows as she goes.
6. The patrol's first blows land hard on the charging goliath, but a *blue glow* runs across each fresh cut and closes it partway.
7. The barbarian's charge halts when the acolyte commands him to retreat. With his *body betraying him*, the goliath falls back, leaving Nyx exposed.
8. In Nuberroca's absence the patrol surges around Nyx — kobolds and cultists pile on the small ranger, landing hits before she can give ground.
9. Nyx drops the lead kobold with a precise thrust of her shortsword, but the rest keep coming; she holds, bloodied and pressed.
10. Amidamaru intervenes to save Nyx, wading in beside her. He cuts down two kobolds in the surge before a cultist drives a spear into him and drops him.
11. Nuberroca recovers his senses, downing the acolyte with a precise axe throw as an act of revenge.
12. Hidden along the bank, Mialee picks her moment and subdues one of the remaining cultists with a clean knockout. With the acolyte dead and one of theirs taken, the rest of the patrol breaks for the trees.
13. Nuberroca hurls a hand-axe after one of the fleeing cultists; the throw buries itself between the shoulder blades and drops him short of the treeline.
14. With the fight done, the goliath turns to Amidamaru — the artificer's bleeding has stopped at some point in the chaos, breath shallow but holding.
15. Sizing up Amidamaru's deadweight, the goliath decides he can't carry both the artificer and the kobold strapped to his chest. He rips the bundled kobold off and hurls it up into the high branches of a nearby tree — out of reach, out of earshot, unable to alert anyone.
16. Only as he stoops to lift Amidamaru does the goliath see the obvious: the stream will carry the weight for him. He ties a rope around the artificer and drags him through the shallows, the current bearing what his shoulders no longer have to — the kobold-throw, in hindsight, unnecessary.
17. The party rounds up the scattered civilians, returning to the keep with the rescued people, the captured cultist, and the dragged Amidamaru.

4 – Recovery at the keep

1. Inside the keep the air is loud with the night's wounded — soldiers and townsfolk alike. **Eadyan** and the rescued civilians are taken in; healers move to those who need them most.
2. Sinsong, helping at the keep tonight rather than in the field, meets the party as they bring the cultist in and takes the prisoner's robe — disguise material for whatever the night still has.
3. The cultist is then handed to **Escobert the Red**, who sets to interrogation in one of the cellars below the great hall.
4. The party finds a quiet corner and takes a short rest. This one is *unusually restorative*: aches fade faster than they should, lesser cuts close on their own, and old wounds feel lighter by the end of the hour. The party comes out of it cleaner than anticipated.
5. Once rested, they take the time to restock and reset. Keep quartermasters refill ammunition; Nuberroca gets a fresh pair of hand-axes; the smiths patch dented armour and re-edge chipped weapons; the party tends to the wounds the night left them.
6. Refreshed and rearmed, the party climbs to the keep's battlements to find Tarbaw and learn what the night still wants of them.

5 - Dragon attack

~01:30, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party reaches **Tarbaw** at the parapet, mid-conversation about the night's run of missions, when one of the watch guards shouts the warning — *the dragon is coming* — his voice fraying with terror as he points to the sky.
2. The blue dragon arrives fast, opening from above with a *lightning breath* that sweeps the rooftop in a single arc, leaving a scorched line in the stone and the remains of a guard smoldering.
3. The dragon dives in for its first close pass, sweeping through the battlements: it lashes with its claws, snatches one guard from the parapet and devours him without slowing, raking Tarbaw in passing — face cuts re-opened, blood pouring.
4. By the end of that first pass two of the keep's guards are dead and several more wounded; the parapet is slick with blood.
5. Mialee, frightened beyond reason, presses herself behind cover and runs down the stairs, choosing her safety over the fight.
6. Nuberroca answers with axe and rage, charging into the open to challenge the dragon directly. Nyx and Amidamaru engage from the parapet with everything they have, slowly overcoming their fears.
7. Challenged, the dragon pulls back to range. Most of its attacks come at distance now — the lightning breath sweeping the rooftop again and again.
8. Between passes the party keeps firing on it: Amidamaru looses arrow after arrow, Nuberroca hurls hand-axes when its arcs bring it within reach, and the keep guards work their crossbows from the wall. Most of the volley shatters against the dragon's powerful scales — arrows snapping, bolts skittering off into the dark, hand-axes chiming like struck anvils.
9. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx, sighting between the dragon's passes, threads a longbow shot into one of its eyes — a *precise arrow* that scores where the scales don't shield. The dragon pulls higher with a roar of rage, blood streaking the side of its head.
10. On the next close pass, the dragon dives in to rake Nuberroca's flank with its claws before pulling up; the goliath's retaliating axe-stroke opens a cut along its foreleg as it banks away.
11. After a lightning discharge that only wounds one guard, the dragon dives in again, snatching another guard from the parapet — a snapping bite, and the man is gone.
12. On its next pass, the dragon slashes Nuberroca again and lifts a guard off the wall, hurling him over the parapet — the man falls to his death on the ground far below.
13. With the parapet near-empty around them and another claw-rake bearing in, the surviving party retreats off the rooftop into the stairwell down to the keep — the doorway narrow enough to deny the dragon's bulk.
14. The dragon presses against the stair opening from above, forcing a foreleg through, claws raking blindly for the heroes as they crouch below the threshold.
15. Nuberroca, axe braced under the lintel, lands a clean stroke on the reaching claw — not deep, but enough to draw blood and sting.
16. ***[EPIC]*** Bleeding from the eye-shot, the foreleg cut, and now the wound on its claw, the dragon pulls its leg back out of the stairwell, looks down at the heroes saying *"esperaba a un grupo de héroes, no me han pagado para esto"*, and turns away from the village.
17. The party watches it vanish into the night, the keep still standing.
18. They climb back up onto the rooftop and turn to the wreckage — wounded guards strewn across the parapet, the dead among them, and Tarbaw unconscious in his own blood — and set to tending whoever can still be saved.
19. As the party works through the parapet's wounded, Tarbaw recovers quickly — by the time they lift him clear, his bleeding has stopped and his eyes are flickering open.

Session 3

2025-02-09

1 - Rooftop briefing

~02:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party is on the rooftop of the Greenest keep after the dragon's retreat. **Tarbaw Nighthill** is in poor shape from the dragon attack: the half-tended cuts on his face have torn open and are weeping blood through hastily wrapped bandages, his arm hangs in a hastily re-tied sling, and he sways on his feet, visibly fighting to stay upright as he speaks. Every sentence comes shorter than the last.
2. A keep guard arrives with a low-voiced report: cultists are burning the mill, Greenest's main grain stockpile and bakery. Guards will need 15–20 minutes to muster a force. Tarbaw asks the party if they can move faster.
3. Mialee voices the strategic case: *"si esta gente pierde el molino, se va a morir la mitad del pueblo de hambre."* Nuberroca asks for healing supplies before they go; Tarbaw replies that he already gave them three healing potions and that the rest are needed for the wounded from the dragon attack.
4. The party decides to leave by the rehabilitated lower tunnel rather than the front gate, which is less secure. Sinsong and Eguzkilore each put on a cultist robe as disguise.

2 - Approach to the mill

1. Party leaves through the tunnel and works southwest along the river toward the mill. It is the dead of night; some fires elsewhere in town are dying.
2. From cover, the party spots another armed group moving among the houses to the west; they choose to skirt them rather than engage and press on toward the mill.
3. Mialee notices the smoke from the mill is *white*, not the dark colour expected from burning grain or wood. Nyx seconds the observation a moment later. The party files it as suspicious and presses on.
4. Sinsong casts Guidance on Mialee so she can sneak ahead and scout. Mialee creeps in close enough to identify the patrol's composition without being seen: a guard drake, several kobolds, and one leading cultist.
5. As the rest of the party closes in, the drake catches their scent and moves toward them.
6. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx opens with a longbow shot, a critical hit that drops the guard drake in a single arrow. The patrol's dangerous element is gone before the rest can react.
7. Mialee stealthily attacks from cover, killing a kobold in a single hit.
8. Eguzkilore looses an arrow that ends another kobold.
9. Sinsong casts Fire Bolt, ending a distracted kobold before he can react.
10. Amidamaru casts Fire Bolt at the leading cultist, a direct hit that kills him outright.
11. The surviving kobolds break and flee.

3 - The mill ambush

1. From behind a nearby tree, Sinsong uses his magical hand to open the front door while the rest of the party holds ready in case anyone shoots from inside. Nothing happens.
2. Through the open door they see the ground floor: scattered grain sacks, the millstone still grinding, and a pulley system rising to a second level. The mill looks empty; the smoke is coming from upstairs.
3. Eguzkilore enters first; Mia, Nyx, and Amidamaru follow him in quickly, spreading across the ground floor. Sinsong and Nuberroca stay by the doorway.
4. With the party committed inside, the ambush is revealed: a volley of spears and arrows comes down from concealed attackers in the rafters. Two of the throws crit on Eguzkilore, dropping him unconscious. Nyx is hit and badly hurt.
5. Immediately after, ten cultists drop from the rafters into melee, five wearing keep-guard livery.
6. A livery cultist drives a spear under Nyx's armpit, a heavy hit, but she holds.
7. One of the cultists in keep-guard livery steals Eguzkilore's short sword off his unconscious body.
8. Amidamaru casts a cone of flame from his mouth that engulfs four cultists, being careful to spare Nyx from the conflagration. Three cultists die outright in the fire.
9. Mialee shoots from behind a crate, fails the attack, and retreats to safety outdoors.
10. Nuberroca rages forward and engages two livery cultists at the doorway, missing with both attacks. As the cultists land their hits, a *blue glow* runs across each cut and closes it partway.
11. Nyx stabilizes Eguzkilore and downs a healing potion to recover. She's back in fighting shape.
12. Sinsong tries to cast Fire Bolt at one of the cultists, but the spell fumbles, fizzling and sparking in his hand without ever leaving.
13. Recovering quickly from his disappointment, Sinsong leans into his cultist robe disguise: he hugs Amidamaru as if *"arresting"* him, selling the moment to the nearby ambushers. The deception lands hard, and none of the nearby cultists break through it.
14. A livery cultist hits Nyx with his spear, dropping her unconscious. Amidamaru, unaware of his downed friend, attacks the cultist beside him with knives.
15. Sinsong uses his magic to stabilize the halfling.

16. Mid-fight, one of the surviving cultists in keep-guard livery shouts in frustration: *"Mondath no nos dijo que eran tan peligrosos."*
17. Nuberroca finishes a large cultist with a critical Hand Axe blow, sending him flying into the wall.
18. The livery cultist who stole Eguzkilore's short sword breaks for the door and escapes outside the mill. Nuberroca hurls a hand-axe after him at a long distance; the throw hits but does not kill, and the axe lodges in his back as he flees with both the stolen sword and the axe still embedded.
19. Eguzkilore stays down for the rest of the fight, breathing only thanks to Nyx's earlier stabilization, never regaining consciousness on his own.
20. With the last cultist down, the mill falls quiet. The fight inside took just a few minutes.

4 – Looting the cultists

1. The *"fire"* upstairs was a montage: wet straw smoldering, deliberately smoking. The mill itself was never seriously burning. The cultists set the smoke to lure responders into the rafter ambush.
2. Nuberroca claims a piece of green cotton from a cultist's bundle and ties it on as a scarf, praising it as soft as a newborn's skin — he keeps it through the rest of the night.
3. The goliath pockets what he calls a fly in a jar, prizing the unfamiliar curio. Sinsong corrects him — it is a firefly — and Nyx makes the connection out loud, calling it a *lightbulb-head bug*.
4. Nuberroca seizes the framing and presents the jar to Sinsong: *"¡Es un bicho Cabezabombilla como tú!"*
5. The scavenging barbarian scoops up other oddments — sugar from a pouch, a live chicken for the eggs, a dried piece of guano he abandons on sight. Sinsong tries to redirect him to a cow, but the cows are already gone, dead in the streets.
6. A livery cultist's pouch contains a whistle. Nuberroca hands it to Sinsong as a gag, telling him to blow it whenever he wants attention. Sinsong blows it theatrically while discreetly tapping unconscious Eguzkilore with his Healing Staff. His bald head glows from the casting and Eguzkilore wakes; Sinsong sells the whole thing as the whistle's doing.
7. Beyond a few low-quality weapons, the bodies yield two gold bracelets and several art objects worth keeping; Nuberroca also peels a small unfamiliar insignia off one of the corpses and pockets it.
8. Eguzkilore checks the second floor: flour bags and grain sacks, plus the millstone's clutch, which they disengage to stop the grinding.
9. With the mill secured in the hands of the recently arrived guards, the party heads back to the keep through the tunnel.

5 – Keep under attack

~03:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The lower tunnel is unusually silent. Combat noise from deeper in the keep reveals enemies have entered through another route.
2. Party emerges into the keep's inner courtyard: the sally port gate has been breached. Cultists, kobolds, and drakes are fighting the guards across the courtyard; six attackers head for the heroes on sight.
3. Sinsong removes the cultist robe and elbows Eguzkilore to do the same before joining the fight.
4. Sinsong takes cover behind the well; Mia crouches behind a wagon. Nuberroca, ignoring cover entirely, charges straight in.
5. Eguzkilore drops a cultist with a clean longbow shot to the eye.
6. Sinsong casts Fire Bolt repeatedly from behind the well, ducking after each cast. One cultist's shield deflects the first bolt entirely.
7. Mialee hides and shoots each round; she remains effectively undetected through the entire fight.
8. Nuberroca grapples a livery cultist and **throws him head-first down the well**, the cultist's head bouncing audibly off the stone walls all the way down.
9. As cultists land hits on Nuberroca during the courtyard melee, a *blue glow* runs across each cut and closes the wound.
10. Two livery cultists trip over each other trying to flank Nuberroca and are hacked down. The remaining cultists try to escape; only one makes it through the sally port, the rest fall.
11. Among the felled, one kobold lies stunned but breathing. Nyx calls to keep it alive. Nuberroca binds and gags it on the spot and stows it against a courtyard wall for later questioning.

6 - The sally port room

1. Mialee splits off to scout the sally port room, vanishing from the group's sight; from the other side of the door the rest of the party hears the unmistakable rhythm of a four-volley salvo — the cultists inside the room overwhelm her in a brutal assault, leaving her unconscious on the chamber floor.
2. Sinsong opens the chamber door from afar using Mage Hand while Nyx, Eguzkilore, and Nuberroca ready weapons.
3. Through the open door the party gets its first look inside: a small chamber holding two cultist acolytes, several kobolds, and another large drake — with Mialee's unconscious body on the floor in the middle of them.
4. Nuberroca, seeing the unconscious little Mia on the floor, charges in Raging with a hand-axe.
5. An acolyte casts Command on Nuberroca; Nuberroca shrugs it off. The other acolyte buffs himself with a defensive ward.
6. Nyx, briefly dissuaded by the acolyte's defensive ward, shakes it off and lands a chest-shot on the caster, dropping him.
7. Sinsong casts Spare the Dying on Mialee from across the room, stabilizing her.
8. The lead acolyte Commands Nuberroca to disarm; the goliath drops his weapons. The drake and a kobold attack together; the kobold critically wounds the barbarian, dropping him unconscious.
9. Sinsong tries to throw a Fire Bolt at a nearby enemy; the spell fizzles in his hand and he ducks back.
10. Unable to cast more Commands, the acolyte falls back on Sacred Flame and starts sweeping the room turn after turn — Sinsong takes the first flare and resists, his bald head briefly glowing; Eguzkilore weathers the next without yielding.
11. Sinsong moves close to Nuberroca and uses his magic to stabilize him.
12. The drake rounds on Sinsong, connecting a bite that drops him *beside Nuberroca*.
13. Eguzkilore takes another Sacred Flame, then digs deep and pushes through the worst of the damage, staying on his feet. Nyx flanks the drake and stabs it until it stops moving.
14. Eguzkilore reaches Sinsong and patches the worst of his wounds, stabilizing the cleric.
15. Amidamaru kills the last kobold with a Fire Bolt.
16. The acolyte tries Sacred Flame again, aimed at Nyx; it fizzles harmlessly. With his colleague dead, the kobolds gone, and the rest of the party closing on him, he turns and flees out the broken sally port.
17. With the raiders repelled, the heroes focus on healing their wounded: Mialee, Nuberroca, and Sinsong are unconscious but stable; the rest of the party is heavily wounded.

7 - Sally port repair

~04:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Nyx rummages Nuberroca's pack, finds his unused healing potions among the plethora of items collected, and force-feeds one to him and one to Sinsong; both revive instantly, feeling much better.
2. Sinsong stands up and blows the whistle theatrically while discreetly tapping Mialee with his Healing Staff, his bald head glowing as Mialee wakes. The whistle gag holds.
3. Mia wakes recounting a nightmare, disoriented; the trauma from the sally-port room sits heavy on her without being named aloud.
4. Nuberroca crouches over the bound courtyard kobold and presses it for intel. Through fear and broken Common, the only useful thing it gives up: a *"dragon woman"* gave their orders — raid Greenest and the surrounding villages and take as much loot as they can carry. The kobold's untreated wounds catch up with it, and it bleeds out where it sits before they can press it further.
5. Amidamaru repairs the sally port door using his Artificer tools to put the broken structure back together over ~10 minutes, while Eguzkilore arranges a barricade of furniture as backup.
6. The keep guards confirm the assault is breaking. Most attackers are leaving Greenest. The party tries to sleep, but soldiers are still mopping up the last attackers across town and another wave cannot be ruled out, so they simply rest a bit.
7. During the short rest the party studies a recovered cult map. They see Greenest clearly labeled, with several other locations also highlighted; most notably an X southeast of Greenest.
8. The hour proves *unexpectedly restorative*. The party comes out healed and refreshed, ready to continue their adventure.

8 - The challenge

~05:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. A large, hooded figure (~7 ft) stands at the gate with 10 kobolds and three civilian prisoners: a woman and two boys, knives at their throats. The figure's voice is deep and dragonborn.
2. The figure addresses the keep:
   "Defensores de Greenest, esta ha sido una noche exitosa y me siento generoso. ¿Veis estos tres vergonzosos e inútiles prisioneros? No los necesitamos, así que acepto devolvéroslos. Mandadnos a vuestro mejor guerrero a luchar contra mí y podréis tener a estos tres en respuesta."
3. The three prisoners are recognised as the family of a keep guard: his sister and two nephews, taken from the town during the assault and held hostage.
4. The guard is **Sergeant Markguth**, who steps forward at the wall when he sees them, recognising his family.
5. **Tarbaw**, beside Nuberroca, quietly notes that none of his soldiers would stand a chance and asks whether one of the party would go in their place.
6. Nyx asks if the figure is acting in good faith, and the figure swears on his honour.
7. Nuberroca accepts the challenge and asks the figure what becomes of the prisoners.
8. The figure responds with his terms, declaring his word worth more than their lives, and lays out the duel: whoever dies, the prisoners go free; the outcome of the combat does not matter to him, only the fun of the fight.
9. Nuberroca requests healing before stepping out. A guard hands him one of the last full healing potions. Sinsong runs the whistle gag, blowing it theatrically while tapping Nuberroca with the Healing Staff. The potion goes down with unusual force, the brew turns more potent than usual. Nuberroca steps out reinvigorated.
10. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca removes the green cotton scarf, folds it carefully, sets it on the ground, then stomps once and announces:
    "Soy Nuberroca Quebrantacielos, guardián del paso sagrado y escudo del árbol del mundo. No lucho por gloria ni oro, sino por el deber. Si buscas desafiarme, que los espíritus de la montaña sean testigos de tu destino."
11. The figure pulls back its hood and cloak: a blue dragonborn with greatsword, lance and the build of a champion. He responds:
    *"Yo soy **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath**, y estoy aquí para grabar mi nombre en la historia de este pueblo."*
12. On Langdedrosa's signal, the two boys are released; they run to the keep gate and are taken inside. The mother remains in kobold custody, knife at throat.

9 - The duel

1. Both fighters stand 50 feet apart on either side of the open gate. Mialee, Sinsong, Eguzkilore, Nyx, and the keep watchers line the wall, weapons sheathed by **Langdedrosa**'s terms.
2. Nuberroca opens by hurling a hand-axe; the throw goes wide at the distance. Langdedrosa surges forward and hurls his lance at the barbarian, hitting hard.
3. Nuberroca lets the fury take him. He closes and attacks twice with two hand-axes; both land cleanly. The *blue glow* flares again across his older cuts.
4. Langdedrosa plants his greatsword in the ground and exhales a lightning breath in a line. Nuberroca dives aside and catches the brunt at a glancing angle, but the lightning still takes a heavy toll.
5. Nuberroca closes again, pushes through with hand-axes, both hit. Langdedrosa is visibly bloodied and stops smiling.
6. Langdedrosa raises his greatsword and swings four times in the same breath. The first hits Nuberroca and leaves him *barely standing*. The second misses. The third misses. The fourth lands cleanly. Nuberroca falls unconscious.
7. Langdedrosa stalks forward, plunges his greatsword into Nuberroca's abdomen and twists. He withdraws and turns to leave; Nuberroca is unconscious, his life slowly fading away.
8. Sinsong, near the wall, raises his hands to cast Fire Bolt at the retreating Langdedrosa. Eguzkilore and the others restrain Sinsong physically, warning that any retaliation would mean Nuberroca died for nothing; Sinsong relents and instead runs to cast Spare the Dying on the unconscious goliath, keeping him alive on the ground.
9. Langdedrosa keeps his word. As he withdraws, he walks into his own kobold ranks, frees the woman from her captor, and disappears with the rest of his force into the night.

10 – Aftermath

1. The raiding army is leaving, victorious; the assault is over.
2. Nuberroca, stabilized by the party cleric, is back on his feet shortly after.
3. **Tarbaw** offers the party two more healing potions and 60 gp total, 10 for each of them, for the night's defence and for rescuing the guard's family.
4. The party shows Tarbaw the items they recovered from the raiders: two gold bracelets and several art objects. They identify these as belongings of Greenest townsfolk and return them to the keep for the families. Nuberroca leads this, framing it as paying back their humble hosts before they leave.
5. Tarbaw praises the party's honourable acts: defending Greenest and returning the recovered townsfolk goods rather than keeping them.
6. The party pools their gold to clear Sinsong's resurrection debt. The cleric forgives 100 gp as a token of gratitude; the guards contribute another 100 gp; the party covers the remaining 400 gp with their combined funds.
7. Nuberroca produces the cultist insignia he pocketed back at the mill. The party recognises it through general lore: it is the symbol of **Tiamat**, the five-headed dragon goddess. The raiders are confirmed to be the *Cult of the Dragon*.
8. The party retires to the barracks to rest, sleeping until well past the morning.

Session 4

2025-02-16

1 - Briefing at the keep

~14:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. After roughly ten hours of sleep, the party is awake at the Greenest keep in the early afternoon. The town is in the daylight clean-up: surviving guards bandaged and overworked, dead bodies being gathered to be cremated that night to avoid disease. The party's purses are empty.
2. **Tarbaw Nighthill** and **Escobert the Red** gather the party in a side room. The castellan reports the captured cultist did not survive his interrogation — Escobert's knuckles are bloodied and split. One of the party murmurs that Escobert's hand clearly slipped.
3. Tarbaw lays out what the keep needs: motivations of the raiders, leaders, numbers, and plans, so the next likely target can be warned. As a bonus, recover any of the looted treasure if possible. He offers **200 gp per head** if the party can bring back this intel.
4. The party is hailed as the heroes of Greenest; soldiers salute them in the corridors. Mialee asks Eguzkilore in a side conversation whether they should show Tarbaw the cult map; the party agrees, and Eguzkilore produces it.
5. Tarbaw studies the map. The X marked south of Greenfields corresponds to a hilly area roughly 12 miles south, about four hours' march. The terrain transitions from rolling farmland into rougher hills with caves, sparse herd-pasture and no settled villages. A plausible cult hideout.
6. The party discusses tactics: not an assault, a *reconnaissance*. Approach, observe numbers and disposition, withdraw with intel.
7. Mialee broaches the leadership question. Nyx assumes Langdedrosa Cyanwrath is the leader; Tarbaw corrects her — survivors describe a human who was directing operations, and Langdedrosa is too exposed to be the actual head.
8. Nyx then asks whether Langdedrosa might in fact be the *"Mujer Dragón"* the kobolds had named the night before. Tarbaw corrects the conflation: Langdedrosa is male, and a Half-Dragon rather than a true dragon.
9. Sinsong asks whether any of the keep guards could come along. Tarbaw answers carefully: the keep cannot spare anyone, but the guards are free citizens — the party can try recruiting one from the wounded. Tarbaw walks them to the infirmary.

2 - Recruiting help

1. The infirmary is full of wounded guards in varying states. Sinsong announces, half in earnest and half theatrical, that he wants to hire a guard for the mission. Nuberroca quips that the more dying, the cheaper.
2. ***[EPIC]*** Sinsong delivers a recruitment speech to the room: *"Si alguien está dispuesto a venir con nosotros a una lucha que desde luego marcará el futuro de Greenest y de la gente que vive en ella, no descansando desde una cama sino luchando espada contra espada, que levante la mano si es que le queda."* The speech lands on the room because the party's reputation precedes them; even **Tarbaw** quietly acknowledges that no one in the keep is in shape to come.
3. One badly wounded guard half-rises and says he would go, but only if the party can guarantee his family's wellbeing should he not return. He names a figure: roughly fifty gold pieces. The party's pockets are empty — between the six of them, two platinum and five gold, which the guard cannot accept.
4. Sinsong improvises: he tries to pawn his own mace as a sanctified relic of the heroes of Greenest — the guard appreciates the gesture but says a mace cannot feed his children.
5. The party pivots: is there a wounded guard with no family attached? Someone with nothing to lose. Mialee suggests, only half-joking, taking an unconscious one and not waking him until they are far down the road.
6. Sinsong walks back through the cots and finds an unconscious guard with no family. He casts Healing Word on him — barely enough to wake him. The man stirs, dazed, head ringing. Sinsong's bald head glows during the cast; the man notices but is too weakened to ask about it.
7. Nyx pulls a bottle from her own kit, opens it, and starts pouring drinks for the surrounding wounded while the guard wakes — *"tomad, tomad, que tenéis que recuperaros."*
8. The man names himself **Miguel**. The party explains the mission and asks him to come along. Miguel is reluctant — he is barely standing, the keep needs him, the wounded need him — but agrees in the end on one condition: he comes as a guide and lookout, not as a fighter, and the party does not put him in harm's way. The party accepts.
9. Miguel tells them he needs a moment to ready himself and will catch up at the gate.

3 - A monk's apprentice

1. As the party readies to depart, a young half-elf approaches, limping. He introduces himself as **Nesim Waladra**, the apprentice of a monk named **Leosin Erlanthar**. Leosin and his companions have been investigating the *Cult of the Dragon* for months — the cult's activity has increased dramatically — and were tracking the raiders into the area when they were intercepted last night outside Greenest.
2. The apprentice and the others escaped; Leosin did not return. They cannot tell whether he was killed, captured, or chose to infiltrate. The latter would not surprise them — Leosin is reckless that way.
3. He shows the party Leosin's pendant: a leather cord with a silver fitting in the shape of a silver dragon. Nesim names the symbol as Bahamut, the dragon god; Mialee recognizes it — counterpart to the Tiamat insignia the party already carries. The leather is torn at the back — not removed by Leosin, *ripped from him*.
4. The apprentice tells them the Cult of the Dragon is enormous — several thousand, possibly hundreds of thousands, of members across the Sword Coast. He cannot guess at numbers locally. One of their fellow monks has already departed to Berdusk seeking reinforcements; help, if it comes, is days away.
5. He asks the party to look for Leosin and bring him, or any news, back. Leosin is described as a half-elf with no particular distinguishing features, his only distinctive carry being his now-broken staff and the pendant the apprentice still holds.
6. The party agrees and Nesim leaves, limping, towards the infirmary.

4 - Tracking the raiders

~14:30, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party leaves Greenest with Miguel as guide, headed south. Outside town the trail is plain: a wide swath of trampled grass through cultivated fields, the path of several hundred attackers retreating toward their hideout.
2. Nyx and Mialee read the prints — booted humans, clawed kobold feet, and a third set of larger four-legged tracks: the drakes seen in the assault on Greenest, used here as pack beasts.
3. Crucially, both inbound and return prints are visible, and the drakes' return prints are noticeably deeper than the inbound ones — laden coming back, with looted goods. No cart wheels: everything they took, they put on the drakes.
4. The estimated raider strength is not 100, nor 200, it's closer to **400 or half a thousand**, possibly more.
5. The terrain turns slowly — first farmland, then scattered low knolls, then progressively steeper hills. The party advances cautiously, watching for stragglers, ambushes, or rearguards.

5 - The stragglers fire

~16:30, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Roughly two hours into the trek, a thin column of smoke catches the party's eye, rising between rocks ahead — a small cooking fire, not a signal fire.
2. Mia and Nyx scout in close. Eguzkilore and Nuberroca close in covered by the rocks, but unable to see the cultists. Miguel hides with the party's gear at the rear.
3. From cover Mialee makes out the camp: four human cultists eating rabbit they have cooked, weapons stacked together against a single rock. Apart from them, around ten kobolds eating their own scraps, *ostracized* — taking insults from the humans and visibly enduring them rather than answering. The kobolds wear their weapons on their belts; the humans do not.
4. Nyx sends Eguzkilore a Message cantrip describing what they see and asking for his read. Eguzkilore likes the idea of stealing the swords — disarmed, the cultists might even turn the blame on the kobolds and start a fight.
5. The party regroups and the scouts brief them in cover. Mialee proposes attacking, but only after stealing the four swords first. Nyx remains uneasy — they are five against fourteen at best, and yesterday smaller groups gave them serious trouble.
6. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee creeps in. With the cultists' backs turned and arguing about the cook's handling of the rabbit, she slips behind their rock. Once in position, she casts Minor Illusion behind the cultists — the rustle of something snake-like in the brush. The nearest cultist startles, the rest crane around to look, and Mialee uses the diversion to lift all four swords cleanly off the rock and slip back to cover.
7. With the swords secure, Nyx whispers across to Mia asking if any cultist is watching her direction; the answer is no, they are still focused on the rabbit. Nyx Messages Nuberroca, identifying herself and giving the green light to attack. Hearing the disembodied voice in his head, Nuberroca panics briefly and asks Eguzkilore if he heard it too — Eguzkilore tells him it is in his head and to move.

6 - A swift ambush

1. Nyx fires from cover; the arrow strikes hard but the cultist holds, dropping his food in shock. One of the others jokes that what hurts him most is losing the food.
2. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca leaps from the rocks above with a war-cry, reaching the cultist and landing an axe-blow that takes a cultist's head off cleanly, then a second slash that splits another cultist *almost in half*. Pieces of cultist and pieces of cooked rabbit land together on the camp.
3. Eguzkilore runs down behind Nuberroca, takes cover behind a tree, and ends another cultist with a longbow shot.
4. Two winged kobolds break from the camp into the air; the rest of the kobolds dive into cover behind rocks and start hurling stones with slings. The kobolds' positioning behind the rocks is good enough that the party's return arrows mostly clatter off stone.
5. A winged kobold dives over Nuberroca and drops a stone from above; the throw lands hard, catching the goliath in the head for a severe hit.
6. The kobolds' stone volleys keep landing brutally one after the other. Mialee takes a stone in the kidney from one of them, badly wounded.
7. Mia uses her action to drink a healing potion, then ducks fully out of sight behind her rock.
8. A faint *blue glow* flickers along the gash above Nuberroca's brow; the cut closes enough for him to wipe the blood out of his eye and keep moving.
9. The rogue asks the party to keep the last cultist alive. Nuberroca gets the message. He moves up, grapples the surviving cultist, and clocks him into unconsciousness with a single open-handed blow rather than the axe, then carries the limp body back tucked under one arm.
10. Nyx fires on the wounded winged kobold; the arrow clips its wing, dropping it grounded but alive. It slips off into the rocks.
11. The other winged kobold flies away over the cliffs to the north, taking a final volley from Eguzkilore that misses. Several of the ground kobolds break and flee in the same direction — at least six retreating uphill. The remaining few are killed.
12. Eguzkilore tracks the wounded winged kobold by its blood trail; it dies a few yards on. He searches the body and finds a stone pendant on a cord around its neck — mundane junk, but he keeps it. He returns to the party and gives it to Nuberroca as a gift after Nuberroca shares the rum bottle he has just looted from a cultist's pouch.
13. Nuberroca takes a swig from the rum, beams, and offers the bottle to Eguzkilore: *"esto está increíble, es como el azúcar ese, está buenísimo esto."* The elf takes a small sip, only enough to be polite. They are still standing among the bodies of the cultists when the toast happens.

7 - Interrogation

1. The captured cultist is bound with Eguzkilore's rope. Nuberroca pees on him in lieu of water to wake him; Mialee searches him while he is out. He carries a bell, a hooded lantern, leather armor — nothing of obvious value.
2. The cultist comes to. Mialee tries to lead the interrogation but botches her opening — Nuberroca steps in, then breaks one of the cultist's fingers when threats fail. The cultist gasps but does not yield.
3. Mialee dangles ten gold pieces in front of him. The cultist refuses with *"el destino solo lo decide Tiamat. Estoy preparado para morir."*
4. Nuberroca cycles through tactics — *"¿quieres que te vuelva a orinar en la boca?"*, then he begins fileting one of the dead cultists in front of him as additional intimidation. The prisoner responds with cult dogma: *"el mundo debe ser dirigido por los mejores, que son los dragones"*.
5. Asked whether he knows **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath**, the cultist answers only that his lips are sealed.
6. Nuberroca raises the axe over the prisoner's neck and gives the rest of the party one last chance to call it off. Eguzkilore, audibly, bounces the call back to Nuberroca and tells him to decide for himself. Mialee hesitates, then proposes **Miguel** take the prisoner back to Greenest so **Escobert** can try with proper tools — better than executing a defenseless man.
7. Eguzkilore searches the prisoner one last time and confirms he carries no hidden blades. Miguel agrees to escort the prisoner back; the party hands him the rope and tells him to keep his spear at the prisoner's back. The guard leaves north toward Greenest with the bound cultist.
8. Nuberroca grumbles aloud that he does not understand letting a defeated combatant survive to be enslaved, but the party moves on. The path ahead is plain even without Miguel as guide.

8 - The defile pass

~18:00, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. About one and a half hours further south, the party enters a narrowing defile: large rocks, the path serpentining between cliffs. Most of the surrounding hills are sheer and unscalable; only a few ridges, eroded enough for a person to climb, give access overhead.
2. The footprints in the dust grow distinctly fresher. Eguzkilore notes there are no horse tracks — only the drakes seen earlier — meaning whatever defenders are ahead, no cavalry has reinforced them.
3. Roughly half an hour from the X marked on the map, the party is well into the rocky stretch when stones begin to rumble overhead. Several boulders come down on them: Nuberroca and Nyx are surprised and get slammed; Mialee and Eguzkilore dodge the worst but still take a glancing hit.
4. A *soft blue glow* ripples briefly along the bruise the boulder left on Nuberroca's ribs; the worst of the ache eases before he can plant his feet.
5. From the ridges above, the party makes out the ambush party of cultists in matching black leather livery — different from yesterday's mob — plus two acolytes and one veteran clearly better-armored and better-armed than the rest. The veteran trains his crossbow on Nuberroca, marking the goliath as his target.
6. The party is exhausted from the camp fight, outnumbered, in the lower ground, and freshly wounded. Mialee is the first to call it — they can still flee — and Eguzkilore agrees: get out before the rest commit. Nuberroca scoops Mialee and Nyx, one under each arm, and dashes back the way they came. Eguzkilore dashes after them.
7. The veteran above raises his heavy crossbow and looses at the retreating barbarian — the bolt buries itself in the dirt at his feet. Spears and javelins fall short at that range.
8. As the party flees, an alarm-call goes up from the defile — a horn note. One cultist breaks south at a sprint along the path toward the cult camp ahead. *Whoever is at the X knows the party exists now.*
9. About a mile back from the defile, in country open enough to choose a hide and rough enough to break their tracks in, the party stops. They erase their trail and go to ground in cover.
10. Half an hour later, no pursuit reaches them. The party debates options — wait until nightfall to push back in under cover of dark, or pull all the way back to Greenest.

Session 5

2025-03-02

1 - The mountain detour

~18:30, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party takes a short rest in cover. Sinsong leans on Guidance liberally to help Nyx scout an alternate route south.
2. The valley floor where the ambush waits is the only easy road. Eguzkilore argues that the cultists will hold the chokepoint with at least a couple of lookouts even after the rest move on, and Mialee agrees the original ambushers have probably repositioned. The party climbs up over the rocky shoulder of the hill rather than push through the defile again.
3. Nyx leads them along a narrow goat-track up the slope, the rest in single file behind her. The going is slow and the night is closing in.
4. Eguzkilore's foot rolls on a loose stone partway up; the rock skitters down the slope and starts a small avalanche of pebbles, loud enough to carry. Voices begin reacting from below.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Sinsong scrambles into his cultist robe. Nyx ducks into cover. Amidamaru shapes a magical illusion of a *forest deer* on the slope ahead of them, complete enough that the species and even the season's coat are convincing — the illusion startles when the cultist voices approach and bounds off into the brush. Two cultists below point at the retreating deer, exchange a few words and turn back.
6. Another hour of climb across the ridge takes them past the worst of the rough country. As they crest, they finally have line of sight on the cult camp ahead.
7. The path dies at a small ravine. To press on means a careful climb down; to detour around it means more time in the shadows with three of them blind in the dark. Eguzkilore points out that night-blind movement compounds; they take the descent.
8. Nuberroca goes down first, then turns to catch the rest. Nyx loses footing partway down and clings until the goliath reaches up and steadies her. The descent costs them time but nobody is hurt.
9. Amidamaru and Nyx are still hauling themselves over the worst of the climb when Mialee and Nuberroca have already cleared it. Between Nuberroca's reach and Sinsong's casting, the group makes it down without injury, though it costs them a full hour and dawn is far off.

2 - Through the gate

1. The camp sits in a horseshoe of high hills, two terraces wrapped around a lower bowl. A makeshift gate parapet at the entrance holds two crossbowmen behind cover and four guards on the path itself. A handful of stunted watchtowers and a single proper tower at the bowl's heart break the skyline. Tents and torch-fires are scattered across the floor.
2. Stragglers from the Greenest raid are still trickling in past the gate — wounded, laden, slow. The watch barely glances at them.
3. The heroes measure the gate against themselves: six of them against several hundred. Even Nuberroca, who would rather charge, is talked down. Mialee lays out three options — observe from outside the bowl; bluff in through the gate as cultists; or sneak in unseen.
4. Two of them are already dressed in cultists' robes from the previous day's loot; only Sinsong and Eguzkilore can pass unchallenged. Nuberroca and Amidamaru are too distinctive to disguise — they would draw eyes the moment they reached the gate. The party splits.
5. Sinsong walks in calmly through the gate; Eguzkilore follows a few paces behind. Amidamaru lays a Guidance on Sinsong before he goes, telling him with a hand on the shoulder that his charisma will carry him through. The cultists at the gate barely look at them; the gate-stragglers are constant and disorganised.
6. The first ring of the camp is a triage zone — rough cots, makeshift tents, walking wounded. Most of the wounds are *superficial*; the keep's defenders did not score deeply.
7. Past the triage they catch sight of giant lizards being led inwards: the drakes used as pack beasts, hauling looted goods deeper into the camp. They drift along behind a group, keeping the lizards at the comfortable middle distance.
8. They reach a tier of more permanent structures — bone-and-hide shelters daubed with crude five-headed dragon symbols, and a stunted tower around which kobolds cluster. The kobolds keep their distance from the human cultists; the human cultists return the courtesy.
9. A ranked cultist stops them. *"¿Quién era el dragonclaw a cargo de vuestra operación?"* Sinsong stalls — he is bad with names — and improvises that they have to go back outside, that they forgot a piece of plunder on the road and his idiot companion is going to pay for leaving it. Eguzkilore catches up just in time, plays along, smacks Sinsong in the back of the head to sell the bit, and hauls him out.
10. The cultist lets them go. They walk back to the gate at the same unhurried pace they came in at and slip back out into the dark.

3 – On the high plateau

1. The other four trace the camp's outer wall along the high plateau, climbing the steeper escarpment to the ridge that overlooks the bowl. The ascent is rough — Mialee and Nuberroca top it cleanly; Nyx and Amidamaru both struggle with the night-blind climb until Nuberroca reaches down and hauls them up. The whole climb costs them about an hour.
2. From the ridge they can see the bowl in full. The high terrace runs along the rim; the bowl interior is dotted with cooking fires and the mobile lights of inner patrols. There is *no patrol at all* on the high plateau — whether by lazy oversight or by design, they cannot tell.
3. Nyx works a rough sketch of the camp into a scrap of parchment by torchlight, ink from her own kit, a quill cobbled together from one of Mialee's arrow-flights.
4. Searching for tracks on the high terrace, Nyx finds nothing suspicious — no kobold, no drake, no human. Only animal sign. The cultists either do not patrol up here, or they prefer not to be seen doing so.
5. Nyx Messages Sinsong to check whether they got through cleanly. Sinsong answers that they came out without a problem at all — the cultists swallowed the story whole, smooth as anything. Mialee proposes the two halves rejoin by the inside group circling around to the high plateau.
6. Sinsong and Eguzkilore work their way around to where the climb starts; following the rest of the party's tracks through the dark, the two of them only need an hour to cover what the first group spent two on. They rejoin near the rim of the camp.
7. The party is exhausted and intends a long rest. The high terrace has a generous supply of small caves; many are half-buried by old rockfall and brush, more than enough cover for a halfling-led party to disappear into.
8. Before sleeping Nyx prepares a fistful of magical berries — the party's emergency food and healing — and presses one into each companion's hand.
9. They sleep the rest of the night with no disturbance, waking up refreshed.

4 – The morning camp

~08:00, 24 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. They wake to the bowl in full daylight. The trickle of stragglers at the gate has all but stopped; the wounded are mostly back on their feet, bandaged but functional. Four small parties of hunters — three or four men each, armed with traps and crossbows — leave the gate and disperse out into the surrounding country to forage. The party guesses the camp itself has stripped the local game, and they have not seen any animal sign worth mentioning on the trail in.
2. Sinsong sets a magical sensor floating out and downwards over the camp, granting them a bird's-eye sweep without exposing themselves on the rim.
3. Through the sensor they pick out the *prisoner detail* — eight wretches in chains being broken into two groups of four, set to cleaning latrines. Mialee asks whether any of them might be a half-elf monk, but the sensor cannot tell from above.
4. Cultists in heavy packs are streaming inward toward the camp's east end and coming back without their loads. The route ends at a heavily-guarded cave at the far east of the bowl. Whatever the cult is gathering, the cave is where it is gathering it.

5 – Finding Leosin

1. Working closer along the rim, the party spots a man tied to a stake against the bowl wall — bloodied, malnourished, slumped. From his bearing and his clothes Mialee makes him for a monk.
2. Nyx sends a mental message asking whether he is Leosin, telling him to stay calm — they are friends, sent by his apprentice, and he can answer her in his mind if he prefers. The man's head lifts as if hearing a voice from nowhere. He answers that his name is **Leosin Erlanthar**; he does not know whether he is the one they are looking for.
3. Asked how long he has been there, Leosin says since the start of the assault on Greenest — about two days. Asked how he was caught, he answers without flinching: he let himself be captured; he needed to *infiltrate*. Nyx asks dryly whether it has been working out for him; he says he has gathered a great deal already, and that he has his own ways out.
4. The party offers help anyway. Leosin accepts the offer of a free hand: if they can untie him without drawing attention, he will manage the rest.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee, from cover on the rim, conjures her invisible arcane hand and walks it down the cliff and across the camp floor, arriving at the stake without a single cultist seeing her. The hand picks loose the knots one by one. Leosin nearly stumbles when the cord goes slack and recovers, miming bound shoulders so cleanly that nothing in his posture gives him away.
6. Sinsong, from the rim, calls a quiet healing on the monk. The effect *runs noticeably further than the spell ought to carry* — Leosin's worst cuts close, the slump leaves his shoulders, and the bruise and hunger of two days lift off him in a single beat.
7. Eguzkilore, who has watched the whole rescue, asks Nyx to ask Leosin whether they should set a meeting place outside the camp; before Leosin can answer, the monk takes one careful look around for inattentive cultists and slips into a tent. He is gone before the question lands.
8. The party decides to create a distraction to help the monk escape. Mialee proposes a fire on the rim itself, drawing eyes up and away from the prisoner stakes.
9. Nuberroca asks Sinsong whether he can burn one of the tents. The dwarf, after gauging the distance, agrees it is just within range; he hurls a bolt of fire down at the cluster of inner tents at the eastern end. The tent ignites; black smoke rises immediately. Nuberroca claps Sinsong on the shoulder — well done, about time.
10. Below, a horn-call goes up from the central tower. The fire spreads along the canvas. Cultists run to put it out; others look upward to find the source. Two of them notice the party silhouetted on the rim and start pointing.
11. One of the cultists begins to climb the cliff face — a slow scramble. Sinsong, watching him come up, levels another bolt of flame and drops the man before he reaches the top.

6 – Four from the tent

1. The horn brings out the camp's leadership. Out of the largest tent — a permanent-looking structure ringed by drake-handlers — emerge **four figures**. Eguzkilore takes a moment to place the first; the party recognises him from Greenest: **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath**, the blue half-dragon.
2. Beside Langdedrosa stands a much larger figure: a *black half-dragon*, female by build, clearly senior to the rest.
3. The third is a tall human in red robes, his head shaved and tattooed in a style none of the party recognises — visibly a *mage*, clearly not from this region.
4. The fourth is another human, robed half as a soldier and half as a scholar, also reading as a caster.
5. The red-robed mage looks up at the rim, makes a small gesture, and a sword of *pale blue light* blooms into existence beside Sinsong on the cliff edge. Before Sinsong can react it cuts him cleanly across the side. Nuberroca lunges to grab it, but his hand passes through the blade as through smoke.
6. Nuberroca points Sinsong toward the central tent — just within his range — but Sinsong commits the cast against the red mage instead, and a bolt of fire goes back down the rim. The mage scarcely shifts, makes another small gesture, and the worst of the heat passes him by. The conjured sword stays beside Sinsong, swinging at him.
7. *Why don't we just leave*, Nyx says, and that decides it. The party breaks east along the high plateau, away from the climbable face of the cliff and toward open country.
8. The veteran guards ringing the central tent loose three bolts upward at the rim. All three break against the rocks — the party's height advantage on the cliff defeats the angle.
9. The conjured sword paces Sinsong as he runs; it is faster than a man's walk but slower than a sprint. Nuberroca scoops Sinsong under one arm and Dashes east, taking the goliath's full stride at speed; the sword cannot keep up and dissolves several breaths behind them. The gash the sword left along Sinsong's side has stopped bleeding by the time they reach broken country.
10. About a mile back from the rim, the party drops into broken country and Nyx erases their trail behind them — quartering a path, doubling back over rock, picking the line a halfling raised on tracker's craft can pick.

7 - The wounded deer

1. The party reviews what they have. **Tarbaw** asked for four things: the cult's motivations, leaders, numbers, and plans. They have the first three. The motivation they can guess at — *gathering treasure for the glory of Tiamat* — but their plan is unknown.
2. Amidamaru and Eguzkilore both vote to fall back to Greenest. Nuberroca wants to lay an ambush and start wearing the camp down patrol by patrol — pick them off and string the bodies up in the surrounding woods to break their morale. Mialee tells him that would just bring the whole camp out in force. The vote falls on returning. They begin to walk west.
3. Half a mile on, a wounded deer crashes through the brush ahead of them and collapses on the rocks. The deer is fresh-bleeding and broken; whatever scared it is close behind.
4. Eguzkilore draws his bow and crouches behind cover; the rest take whatever shelter they can find on the broken ground. Amidamaru works himself into a fissure. Mialee notches an arrow and waits.
5. Two drakes burst through the brush on the deer's tail, the four hunters trailing behind them. The drakes are faster than their handlers and reach the open ground first. Mialee's arrow hits the lead drake before any of the hunters has registered the party.
6. Eguzkilore puts a second shot on the same drake. Nuberroca, hidden behind a tree on the high ground, swings his greataxe at the closest drake and misses badly — the axe buries itself in the trunk and refuses to come free. The lead drake's first snap catches him in the side as he hauls at the haft; a *blue glow* runs across the bite and closes it partway. He spends the next round wrestling the weapon out of the wood.
7. The hunters have crossbows out before the drakes are halfway across the open ground. They take cover behind whatever they can find — a tree, a rock, the carcass of one of their own drakes once Mialee drops it. The shooting is steady and hard.
8. The drakes converge on Nuberroca, who is the largest threat in sight. They take him at the tree, biting and tail-whipping; a *blue glow* runs across each fresh tear as it opens, but the damage outpaces it and the goliath drops unconscious in seconds. Eguzkilore breaks cover, crosses the open and stabilises Nuberroca on the ground.
9. Sinsong calls down a blessing on three of his companions and pours a healing potion on Nuberroca — the goliath sits up still bleeding but conscious.
10. Two of the hunters close to knife range against the party at the tree line while the other two hold the rocks with their crossbows. Amidamaru flanks one of the knife-fighters from behind and lays in two daggers between the ribs; the man takes the hits but stays upright. Mialee's follow-up sneak shot punches through and drops him dead in the dust.
11. The second knife-fighter shifts to Eguzkilore and lands a critical strike that nearly puts him down — the gash along his ribs *mends to a slow ooze* before he can press a hand to it. Before the man can finish the job, Amidamaru circles in behind him and lays in two more daggers, this time held flat for non-lethal blows; the hunter crumples unconscious, breathing but barely. The party will keep this one for questioning.
12. The drake's bite-and-tail-whip catches Eguzkilore in the open and drops him; Sinsong moves up and stabilises him swiftly.
13. Mialee hits the second drake; Nyx turns her Hunter's Mark onto it. Between the two of them the drake falls dead off the rock.
14. The two crossbow hunters at the rocks fire one last volley at Amidamaru — both miss — and break for the broken country behind their position. Mialee's sneak shot wings the trailing one in mid-retreat and leaves him reeling but on his feet. He hesitates a beat, then breaks into a sprint.
15. Nuberroca's first lunge after the runner falls short by a few yards. The goliath *dissolves into cloud* and reappears beside the runner a single step later, bringing the greataxe down. The man does not get back up. The fourth hunter slips away into the broken country before anyone can catch him.
16. With the field clear, Amidamaru darts to Eguzkilore and presses one of Nyx's berries between his lips; the elf opens his eyes, alive but barely. Total tally: two drakes dead, two hunters dead, one alive and bound, one escaped into the country. The party catches the deer, dresses it for travel and saves the meat.

8 - The interrogation

1. The bound hunter wakes feet-up against the rock-face, four armed strangers around him and a deer being butchered nearby. Nyx tries the gentle line first: *"buenos días, majo. Has tenido mala suerte. Queremos que nos digas un par de cositas y te dejamos ir."* The cultist's reply is cold — he will never tell them anything.
2. Nuberroca steps in still slick with the last hunter's blood, the greataxe across his shoulder, and Nyx says, *"mira, este es mi amigo. Si no nos dices lo que queremos saber, va a hacer lo suyo."* The cultist breaks.
3. He names his commander first — **Rezmir**, a black half-dragon, female, the chief of this camp. He confirms **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** when Nuberroca asks for him by name: a blue half-dragon, rigid honour — not someone you would want to anger.
4. Pressed on the line of command, the cultist offers a third name on his own — **Frulam Mondath**. Langdedrosa, he says, is Frulam's right hand; Frulam in turn answers to Rezmir.
5. Asked about the red-robed mage, the cultist says he does not know the man. Nyx watches him as he says it and judges he is *lying* — there is something about the red-robed figure he is hiding.
6. Asked for numbers, the cultist puffs himself up — *"somos legión. Somos más de los que podréis jamás derrotar y somos más de los que podréis contar. Y cada día somos más."* — and lands on five thousand. Pressed harder he concedes that this camp itself is fewer than that, and that he and the dead hunters were not even formal members of the cult, just hired scouts feeding the camp.
7. Asked the cult's purpose, he gives the line they have heard before — the glory of Tiamat. Asked why Greenest, he says it was the largest city closest to the camp and the raid has been an absolute success. Asked the next target, he claims that is above his rank.
8. Asked where the cult was before Greenest, the cultist refuses. He offers a deal: release him, let him reach a safe distance, and he will shout the answer back across the rocks.
9. Sinsong refuses outright — let him go and he will run straight to the camp. Mialee laughs; Eguzkilore stays out of it. Nyx insists she gave the man her word and will not break it. Nuberroca defers to her — little one, what is your call. She nods. Nuberroca lifts the man bodily, walks him to a clear stretch of rock, and puts him down gently.
10. The cultist runs. Sinsong reaches with the staff for a non-lethal blow as the man passes; the strike misses. The hunter Dashes a hundred and twenty feet across open ground, turns, cups his hands to his mouth and shouts back — *from the east!*
11. Sinsong's bolt of fire travels the full hundred and twenty feet and catches him. The hunter falls and does not get up. Mialee says, flat, that what he just did was *wrong*. Sinsong shrugs — they are capable of tracking us.

9 - Back to Greenest

~11:00, 24 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party gathers what gear they need. Forty rations of butchered venison go on Nuberroca's back; the goliath gives Sinsong ten and keeps the rest, complaining about the weight more than the pain.
2. Nyx takes the hunters' arrows — the half that survived the volleys — back into her quiver. Eguzkilore takes a few. Nuberroca tries to claim a crossbow and is talked out of it. He keeps four hand-axes off the dead drakes' handlers and a small leather pouch of mundane junk.
3. Nyx covers their tracks again on the way out, then leads them north along the rim and west around the bowl, keeping the cult camp well off their north shoulder. They cross the foothills back into farmland by mid-morning.
4. They reach Greenest at about half past three. The town is still in its post-assault state — fewer wounded out in the streets, the cremations long since done, the soldiers visibly less ragged.

10 – Report and reward

~15:30, 24 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party stops at the keep's modest armoury before reporting in. Nuberroca trades one of his old hand-axes back, claims a proper shield and accepts that an old pickaxe sells for a single piece of gold. Eguzkilore replenishes arrows.
2. Three healing potions sit on the keep's small market table at fifty gold a piece — a discounted hero's price. Amidamaru sets aside ten gold for incense; he intends to bind a familiar soon. The rest of the purchases wait on **Tarbaw**'s reward.
3. Tarbaw receives them in the side room. Mialee opens the report — camp twelve miles south, rough strength two hundred to three hundred, a handful of leaders. Nyx fills in: Langdedrosa Cyanwrath, Rezmir the black half-dragon as chief, a red-robed mage they could not name and Frulam Mondath named under interrogation. Cultists of Tiamat. Treasure piled up at a heavily-guarded cave at the camp's east end. Eight prisoners cleaning latrines; Leosin Erlanthar found and freed; his fate after that unknown.
4. Asked the cult's intent, Nyx repeats the line she has been given: glory to Tiamat. Greenest as the largest city closest to the camp and a confirmed successful raid. She offers her own guess that the line is what the rank-and-file believe and that the leaders may want something else; she also offers her guess at the next target — based on the cultist's last shout, eastward in origin and possibly westward in plan, with Candlekeep and Baldur's Gate as the obvious large-city candidates. Tarbaw does not commit to a route but says he will warn the city watch.
5. Tarbaw counts out **two hundred pieces of gold for each of them** out of the keep coffers. Mialee sets aside a hundred of hers and pushes it back across the table — for the town. Nuberroca produces twenty rations of venison and adds them to the same pile. The governor praises their honour.
6. The party splits the remaining potions: one to Amidamaru, one to Sinsong, one to Nyx. Amidamaru sits in the keep's outer yard with the incense and works the binding ritual. An hour later, a small owl familiar perches on his shell.

Session 6

2025-03-09

1 - Evening at the keep

~17:00, 24 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Back at the keep after the camp recon, the party debriefs again with **Tarbaw** in the common room. Sinsong asks whether the captured cultist Miguel brought back from the southern excursion has talked.
2. Tarbaw answers heavily — neither prisoner survived the interrogation. **Escobert** worked both of them; one yielded the camp's location before dying, the other gave nothing. Tarbaw says drily that Escobert is *exceptionally good at extracting information*.
3. Tarbaw remarks that with both prisoners dead the cult's most valuable witness is **Leosin Erlanthar**, and the party did not bring him back. Nyx answers flatly that they lost sight of him; Mialee adds that the monk did not come on his own. Tarbaw waves it off — they have done enough already.
4. Amidamaru asks whether the town has anyone left to rescue. Tarbaw confirms several prisoners were taken to the camp; the party admits they did spot the eight at the latrines but were detected and forced to flee.
5. The party settles in. Mialee asks after a pearl in town — Tarbaw shakes his head, the looters cleaned out anything of value. Nyx orders a drink; Sinsong joins her. The party spends the next two hours drinking in the keep's common room.
6. Sinsong asks Tarbaw before bed what the keep needs of them tomorrow. Tarbaw answers that recovery is the priority — the guards are still tending the wounded; help with that is welcome.
7. The party calls an early night and retreats to the barracks, sleeping soundly until the next morning.

2 - Morning briefing

~08:00, 25 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party comes down to the keep's hall and finds **Nesim Waladra** waiting for them with another figure. The second man wears traveller's robes and a monk's bearing; the party recognises him from the valley. It is **Leosin Erlanthar**.
2. Leosin greets them. He looks bruised and gaunt but visibly recovered; the cuts from the stake are scarred over. He thanks them for their help with a wry remark that they *could have helped a bit more*, but the healing on the rim was what mattered.
3. Asked how he escaped, Leosin says the distraction fire drew the cultists toward the eastern tents and the prisoner stakes; the middle of the bowl emptied long enough for him to slip into the tents, knock out two guards along the way, and climb out by the north face.
4. Amidamaru gives him medical advice to help the morning's recovery. Sinsong approaches, shakes his hand, and wishes him a swift recovery — the monk's colour comes up, reinvigorated.
5. Leosin admits why he is really here. He must travel north to Elturel to report to his order; he cannot stay. He asks the party to return to the camp and bring back what they can on the heavily-guarded cave at the east end — the cult are calling it a *hatchery*, and that word alone is what he most wants verified. He offers them a reward: **one hundred and fifty gold pieces per head**.
6. Asked what the cave might hold, Leosin spreads his hands — kobolds, dragons, something else; that is what he wants the party to find out. Asked whether he saw treasure carried out, he confirms steady movement of cultists and pack-drakes hauling crates into it. They are using it as a stockpile at the least.
7. Nyx asks Leosin about his order. He answers that he is just a monk — his order is secular rather than religious; he works in concert with the Council of Lords and the Order of the Gauntlet, gathering intelligence to head off further raids like Greenest. He is from Berdusk; Elturel is one stop on his northward route.
8. If the party arrives at Elturel and Leosin has already moved on, they should ask for **Ontharr Frume** of the Order of the Gauntlet.
9. Leosin recommends a proper rest before they go back to the valley. The party agrees and spends the morning resupplying — rations, arrows, rope. Sinsong complains about the weight of all the gear he is carrying; Eguzkilore leaves most of his pack in a chest at the keep.
10. They set out before noon, retracing their route south at an easy pace. First open ground, then the foothills. At the chokepoint where the defile ambush hit them two days earlier they slow to a crawl — and find it *empty*, no scouts, no signs of fresh movement.
11. After four hours walking, they finally approach the bowl. The lower gate that bristled with crossbowmen on the previous run is *unmanned*.

3 – The camp emptied out

~13:30, 25 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. From the rim they take in the change. The kobolds' shanty quarter at the camp's lower end is *burned to the ground* — the lean-tos torched along their entire run, only the central tower and the better-built shelters still standing. There is no smoke now; the burn is hours old.
2. A circuit of the perimeter shows what happened. Many small parties have broken from the camp through the main gate, each then turning off in a different direction once clear. The heavier-loaded tracks — including a few cart-trails — all bear **west**. The lighter parties scatter every which way.
3. Sinsong puts on the cultist robe again and the party walks in. Four armed humans at a small tent on the upper terrace see them coming; the men are sitting at their bows and traps, calm. One looks up, points casually at the cave, and tells Sinsong — without bothering to lower his voice — that *the friend in the bushes does not need to hide; they are not staying*. The four mount waiting horses and gallop off.
4. With the camp clear the party works the tents room by room. The hunters' shelter holds bedrolls for sixteen and nothing of value. The robed cultists' tents have been stripped down to broken pottery and household scraps. The well-decorated central tent — where **Rezmir** and the others had emerged the day before — is empty too.
5. The household debris is worthless to the party but useful to the people of Greenest. Nuberroca packs about seventy-five kilos of plates, cutlery, and pots into an improvised bundle to carry on the way out, complaining as he does so about losing his stealth. Nyx sweeps the central tent for anything of value and finds ten gold pieces scattered between bedding.
6. With the camp checked, they turn for the eastern cave.

4 – The cave mouth

~14:30, 25 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Sinsong listens at the entrance — running water, the natural acoustics of a deep cave, nothing else. Nuberroca crouches to read the prints at the threshold: drake tracks, days fresh, plus human boot-prints layered over them. Past the threshold the dark is broken by a *soft purple light* from further in.
2. The dwarf casts magical light on a small plate from the tent loot and gives it to Amidamaru for illumination. Amidamaru, who lived three decades underground, returns it with a polite thanks.
3. Mialee scouts first, stepping past a column at the bend. Two attackers waiting in cover behind the column move on her in one motion — coordinated, fast, each striking twice. Before the rest can react **Mialee is on the ground, bleeding out**.
4. Nyx hears her cries from the bend. Nuberroca, seeing Mia drop, *rages* — he had not meant to, but the small one going down decides it for him. He feels the surge run through him, increasing his vitality, and pushes a portion of it across to Eguzkilore.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca closes and brings his greataxe down on the first attacker — a clean swing, the man dead before he can lift his weapon again. Eguzkilore's bow drops the second.
6. Sinsong reaches Mia, stabilises her with his magic, then closes her worst wound with a healing — the elf opens her eyes, alive and on her feet again. Mialee, light-headed, finds a *vial of green liquid* on the body next to her and pockets it.
7. The cleric lays a magical bond on Amidamaru, Mialee, and Nuberroca — they feel their skills honed for the combat.

5 – The fungi chamber

1. Past the column the cave opens into a wider hall lit purple. Stone stairs lead down into it. Nuberroca takes the lead; partway down one of the treads sinks under him and the staircase *folds flat into a ramp* — he tumbles to the floor in a heap of plates and gear.
2. He picks himself up to find the chamber's floor carpeted with fungi. Several are knee-high; *four are taller than a person*, glowing softly purple, swaying without wind.
3. Nyx asks whether any of them are edible. Nuberroca, who has seen mountain fungi like them, answers that these are *dangerous* — to eat, and worse to touch.
4. The large fungi prove him right at once. They lurch toward him in the same swaying motion; on contact they secrete a putrid slick that eats at his skin. The first strike opens his arm; a faint blue glow runs across the wound and closes it partially. The second slick gets past the heal, the substance visibly melting through his hide where it touches.
5. Mialee shoots from cover. Eguzkilore puts another arrow in the damaged fungus. Nyx marks the wounded fungus and lands a third arrow.
6. Amidamaru, on the steps above, throws a bolt of fire down at the wounded fungus. The shot burns it badly but the thing holds together; the others keep coming.
7. The fungi keep grinding at Nuberroca, the rot biting deep. He drops the closest one with a greataxe sweep, then the next, then the third. The last falls to a combined volley from the steps.
8. Nuberroca turns to Sinsong with a gash along one arm still bleeding the brown slick of the rot. Sinsong sighs at him, calls down a healing, and the wound closes. Nuberroca claps the dwarf on the shoulder and tells him that in his tribe, when someone saves your life *you become blood brothers* — and Sinsong is now his blood brother. Sinsong submits to it with a flat look, mutters about needing to be more careful, and turns away — at which Nuberroca, grinning, adds, *"Gracias, me encanta cómo te luce la calva cuando me curas."*
9. From the chamber they spot a corridor behind them, with a side passage to the left and a broader chamber at the end. Eguzkilore sees barrels stacked at the back.
10. The party sweeps the broken-down storeroom on the right. Sinsong digs through abandoned chests and turns up sixteen gold pieces — nothing else of value, only smashed pottery and ash.
11. On the floor of the same room they find a cultist — sprawled, *blackout drunk*. Nuberroca disarms him, ties him with rope, then slaps him hard enough to draw a groan and nothing more. The bundle of plates and the unconscious cultist together would weigh over a hundred and eighty kilos, so the barbarian leaves the cultist there.

6 – The corridor fight

1. The party leaves the storeroom toward the passage at the middle of the corridor. It narrows to a doorway; the chamber beyond is shadowed and silent.
2. ***[EPIC]*** Combat opens before Nuberroca clears the threshold. A cultist runs into the doorway; Nyx's first shot punches through his face and *drops him on the spot*. The body falls and the doorway is briefly clear.
3. More cultists pile in behind him. Two press up to the door at speed; a third hangs back beside two crossbow guards along the far wall. The cultists try to crowd the doorway against Amidamaru — the tortle plants himself in the gap, dodging and shouting back into the corridor for the others to stay clear and to leave one of the cultists alive for questioning.
4. Sinsong, behind Amidamaru, conjures a sword of *pale spirit-light* beside the doorway and it cuts the first cultist in a hard arc.
5. Amidamaru, seeing three cultists line up cleanly behind the second wave, lifts the alchemical mask at his throat and fans a cone of fire down the corridor. Two of the three duck in time behind their cover; the third takes the full burst and goes down moments later.
6. From a side chamber a robed woman strides out, calm. Mialee names her aloud — **Frulam Mondath**. With a small gesture she conjures a sword of pale spirit-light beside her, and sends it skimming forward toward the doorway; the blade tracks Nyx first along the corridor wall.
7. On her next beat Frulam fixes on Amidamaru in the gap and speaks a simple command: *"Tortuga, al suelo."* Amidamaru's knees fold under him before he can argue. The conjured blade pares him from above as he tries to recover, and Amidamaru cannot rise without making it worse.
8. Mialee shoots out of cover and lands a hit on Frulam, but the priestess manages to keep her concentration on the sword.
9. Nyx's second arrow finds another cultist in the chest. Eguzkilore's bow tracks the line — patient shots, mostly into the crossbow guards behind the cover at the far wall.
10. Frulam turns from Amidamaru to Nuberroca, who has just shouldered into the doorway; she lets the spirit-sword over Amidamaru dissolve and speaks a holding-word. Nuberroca freezes in place, *paralysed*, the rage still on him but his limbs locked.

11. Sinsong, seeing his opening, throws a sleep-spell at Frulam — it clips her: for a beat she stands frozen, unable to act, but does not go down. The effect is enough to break her concentration and Nuberroca can move again. Two berserkers push into the corridor behind her.
12. Amidamaru fans an acid spray down a thirty-foot lane — half the chamber catches some of it; one berserker takes the full hit, the other and Frulam herself manage to avoid the worst of it.
13. The priestess, recovered from the stupor thanks to the acid spray, drives her halberd into Nuberroca and leaves the goliath with *only a sliver of life*.
14. The combat reshapes in a single beat. Two more barbarian berserkers in cult colours push in from the back chamber — axes already swinging — and behind them comes **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** himself.
15. ***[EPIC]*** Langdedrosa pushes through into the corridor and stands between the party and Frulam, shielding her. He fixes Nuberroca across the doorway and speaks in a voice the goliath knows: *"Tú. Veo que sobreviviste a tus heridas, no seré tan generoso esta vez."*
16. Sinsong throws another sleep-spell, catching Frulam and one of the berserkers — both fold where they stand.
17. A barbarian swings on Amidamaru, but a flash of light covers the tortle and the axe slides aside, doing no damage.
18. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee breaks cover for a clean shot at one of the new arrivals. The arrow strikes home and the berserker bends his knee, visibly wounded.
19. Langdedrosa stoops over Frulam and shakes her awake; Nuberroca, with a swift cleave of his axe, finishes off the wounded berserker.
20. Another berserker badly hits Amidamaru — the axe should have killed him outright, but a wash of *pale blue light* moves across his shell where the steel bit, preventing some of the damage. The tortle drops to a sliver and stays upright, then disengages and runs back down the corridor.
21. Frulam, now awake, fires off another spirit-sword and sends it at Sinsong. The conjured blade catches him cleanly — a *critical strike to the chest*. The dwarf is hurled into the wall by the impact, his old neck tattoo flaring; he slides down the stones bleeding but standing.
22. Enraged, Frulam calls a beam of light down on the dwarf, finally dropping him. The sleeping berserker awakens.
23. Mialee shoots Frulam — the arrow barely grazes her but the hit is enough to break her concentration. The spirit-sword over Sinsong dissolves.
24. Langdedrosa, hemmed in, opens his jaws and breathes lightning down the corridor — a *clean white line* straight through the doorway. Nuberroca half-evades behind the entrance; Eguzkilore is in the open and takes the full force, gear smoking; Sinsong, lying flat, is missed by inches. The line leaves everyone in the corridor *barely standing* — Nuberroca and Eguzkilore staggered, Sinsong still out, Mialee and Nyx down to a sliver.
25. The line breaks. Nuberroca disengages and pulls back out of the doorway. Eguzkilore moves up to where Sinsong lies, hauls the dwarf over his shoulder, and starts the run back the way they came. Nyx covers their retreat from the far end of the corridor with her bow.

Session 7

2025-03-16

1 - Lightning returns

~15:00, 25 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The corridor fight continues. **Frulam Mondath** stands in the chamber beyond with **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** and berserkers behind her, while at the doorway Nuberroca is still in his battle-fury with a sliver of life left in him. At the back of the corridor Eguzkilore carries the unconscious Sinsong, who is still bleeding out, and Amidamaru — having pulled back from the line — has turned back into the tunnel.
2. Nuberroca dissolves into a wisp of cloud and reforms at the back of the corridor, reaches for his pouch of bandages to staunch Sinsong's bleeding, then realises he can pour a healing potion directly down the dwarf's throat instead. The potion brings Sinsong back to consciousness, still in Eguzkilore's arms.
3. Nyx steps back from the doorway, murmurs some strange words, and pulls a tangle of vines up from the corridor stones — wide enough to take in all the cult fighters at the front. Every one of them tears clear as the creepers reach, but the floor is now a wrestling mat of green underfoot, and the cultists will have difficulty moving.
4. With three cultists pressing forward and the rest of the party at his back, Amidamaru plants himself in the corridor mouth, braced for any blow that comes: the tortle cannot run without leaving everyone else exposed.
5. **Frulam conjures a spectral blade beside her**; the blade pares at Mialee and misses, and the priestess advances toward the doorway.
6. Mialee leans out and looses an arrow at Frulam, then slips back along the wall — the priestess does not see her go.
7. Langdedrosa, lightning gathered in his throat once more, fixes the corridor again and advances towards the heroes.
8. The half-dragon breathes a clean white line down the passage, catching everyone in the corridor in single file. Sinsong, shielded by the rocks, avoids the direct hit; the rest of the party all twist clear of the worst, but the line still rakes them — Nuberroca and Mialee (still hidden along the wall) weather it, while **Eguzkilore, Nyx, Amidamaru and Sinsong all collapse to the stones, unconscious**.
9. From the chamber beyond, Mia hears a low roar: *"No sé dónde estás, pero te buscaré y te cazaré."*
10. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore, lying on his back bleeding out, fights death off with a sudden surge; his eyes flutter open and he pushes himself up. Between the unconscious Sinsong and the unconscious Nyx beside him he picks Nyx — smaller and easier to carry — gathers the halfling under one arm, and sprints for the cave mouth.

2 - Hauling the wounded

1. Turning to cover the retreat, Eguzkilore digs deep for a second burst of effort and looses a bow shot at the nearest pursuing kobold — the arrow goes wide — and patches himself up moments later by sheer force of will.
2. The cultists push down the corridor regardless. The tangle of vines still bites: a berserker forces through the green and only just clears the corridor; **Frulam Mondath** follows hard on his heels.
3. Inside the cave Nuberroca moves to recover the unconscious Sinsong, dropping the bundle of plates and household debris he had hauled out of the camp earlier that afternoon to lighten his load before lifting the cleric.
4. He considers the cave wall — could a goliath swing collapse the corridor on top of the cult? Nuberroca judges the task too far beyond him and lets it go.
5. The goliath throws a hand axe at the nearest kobold instead: the axe takes the creature in the chest and drops it on the stone. A second axe from his other hand clips another kobold — the blow lands but the creature stays standing.
6. Behind him a berserker reaches the unconscious **Amidamaru** in the corridor and pins him to the stone. The tortle is held in place, not finished.
7. From her hiding spot Mialee fires twice at a kobold and both shots go wide; she slips back along the wall, lost from sight again.
8. Langdedrosa sprints the length of the corridor in one motion, his eyes on Nuberroca: *"tú eres mío."*
9. At the doorway two kobolds catch Eguzkilore as he runs through with Nyx in his arms — both blows land, one with crushing force. The borrowed vitality Nuberroca had poured into the elf moments before holds him on his feet where the hit should have dropped him.
10. In Nuberroca's arms Sinsong stirs back to consciousness. The goliath presses a finger to the dwarf's lips and tells him *"tranquilo, Cabezabombilla"*; on contact the bald head *flares with a soft glow*.
11. Sinsong, half-awake, weaves a protective binding on the goliath who is carrying him — a tether that shares part of Nuberroca's wounds with the dwarf.
12. Nuberroca looks **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** in the eye across the corridor and answers him with the line the half-dragon left him with the day before: *"Acabaré contigo, pero no hoy. Todavía no soy lo suficientemente fuerte."*
13. The goliath then grips the pendant at his throat, invokes the world tree — *"ayúdanos, gran árbol del mundo"* — and burns the last of his resolve so the wisp of cloud takes Sinsong with him.

14. He lands further down the corridor and brings his greataxe down on a kobold in a wild, open swing, cleaving the creature apart in a single stroke. At the same moment a surge of borrowed vitality pours across the corridor from Nuberroca into Eguzkilore at the doorway.
15. As they push into the entrance cave, **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** emerges from the corridor mouth behind them — visibly furious, lightning crackling at his throat once more. The half-dragon is winding up a second breath but has not yet released it.
16. From Nuberroca's shoulder Sinsong whispers a word of healing over Nyx; the halfling, still in Eguzkilore's arms, comes awake at the doorway.
17. They flee in earnest. Nuberroca catches a parting blow on his way out — his battle-fury blunting it, a faint blue glow knitting the gash half-closed as he moves — then sprints through the cave mouth with Sinsong over his shoulder.
18. Outside the cave the five still on their feet are clear of the corridor. Still pinned by the berserker, **Amidamaru is left behind**.

3 - Fog cloud and flight

1. The party debates direction between the tents as it moves. Eguzkilore argues for breaking out through the camp's main exit; Sinsong calls for north; the group commits to north and falls in behind him.
2. The cave's kobold guards stagger out into the daylight, blink at the sun, and turn straight back inside — but the berserkers and **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** push out after the party, closing to about sixty feet behind.
3. Nyx turns mid-stride, fixes her will on the casting, and drops a fog cloud between them and the pursuers. The berserkers run straight into the wall of vapour and lose the trail — the cloud buys the party the gap they need. Through the murk they hear voices searching in tongues they do not understand.
4. The party threads behind the abandoned tents toward the rim instead of through the gate, the white cliff-face above them visible from the camp.
5. With the chase broken for the moment Sinsong calls them in close and binds three of the party in a shared blessing — a steady channel that lends each a small magical hand for the next ten minutes.
6. After a while the party watches from cover as the berserkers come back through the fog, glance about, and turn back toward the cave. **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** and the two berserkers retreat — Amidamaru still inside — and the party is loose in the bowl with nobody on their trail.

4 - Rest and return

1. The group debates whether to rest or push back in at once. Eguzkilore worries the longer they wait the worse Amidamaru's odds; Sinsong wants to wait until dawn; Nyx points out the kobolds will not change their habits whether the party rests or not.
2. They settle on leaving the bowl entirely. Mialee remembers caves in the slope above the camp from the rim recon two days back; the party climbs up out of the valley basin and finds a hide that keeps the cave entrance in view.
3. Nyx uses her last spell of the day to conjure berries for the party's rations; Sinsong sits down to keep copying the spell — the new scroll work he had started in Greenest.
4. **Watches are split.** Eguzkilore takes the first four hours; Mia takes the second four. The other four sleep eight hours straight.
5. Sinsong, after the watch is set, says aloud what he wants everyone to remember: *"me gustaría que apreciaseis que os he salvado a todos."* Mialee answers him: *"un minuto de silencio por los que no han podido salir de la cueva."*
6. The long rest passes without incident. The party wakes after the eight hours; the camp below them is still dark — Nyx wondering aloud whether the kobolds keep an inverted cycle and might be the ones asleep now.
7. After some arguments about the approach, the party settles on a plan: Nyx and Mialee will move ahead as a stealthy vanguard, while Sinsong, Eguzkilore and Nuberroca follow some distance behind in case they are needed.
8. They cross the camp under cover of the tents. The cave entrance is empty — no Langdedrosa, no Frulam, no guards.
9. Nyx sends a magical message in the direction they last saw Amidamaru — *"Amidamaru, are you there?"* After a long beat the answer comes back: he is in the room where they captured the drunkard; he is hurt but only a little; he is unarmed and stripped of his gear. Three kobolds are around him; he does not know where Langdedrosa or Frulam are.

5 - The cave skirmish

~00:00, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Some kobolds at the entrance spot them as they advance. Eguzkilore readies a bow shot at the kobold he can see; Mialee drops the first kobold with a single arrow, then steadies her aim for a measured follow-up. Sinsong steps out and hurls a bolt of fire at a second kobold across the chamber, dropping it noisily on the stone.
2. Nyx readies a shot for the first enemy in range, and Nuberroca readies a swing for any attacker that closes on him. The cave is dim, and the corridor turns create blind spots.
3. A kobold creeps into Nyx's line of sight; she lands a clean shot and drops it dead at her feet. Mialee conjures an illusory double of Nyx at a column further forward as a decoy for the kobolds to track, and Sinsong's second bolt of fire punches straight through its centre and into the kobold past it; the illusion shimmers and reforms behind the bolt.
4. A berserker rounds the column from the bend and fumbles into Nuberroca's space, axe still in hand — and trips flat before he can swing. Nuberroca lifts his greataxe over the sprawled man and brings it down with crushing force, splitting the berserker's axe in half and leaving him trembling on the stone, still alive. Mialee notes the barbarian has been disarmed.
5. The downed berserker hauls himself up, slashes at Nuberroca with what is left of his weapon in a reckless lunge, then shouts the party's positions back into the cave — three on the right, two on the left, spread out.
6. Moments later they clear the first wave. As the tripped berserker tries to break away, Nuberroca's axe catches him mid-pivot and drops him. Eguzkilore and Nyx pick off the last kobolds at the bend while Sinsong refreshes the shared blessing over three of the party. Sounds of fresh reinforcements coming down the passage carry from the dark. The five push to the next column and reform behind it; Mialee slips into hiding, leaving her illusory double of Nyx still standing at the original angle as a static decoy. Nuberroca scoops a fallen crossbow off the stone and readies a shot for whatever comes next.
7. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee repositions around the column to flank — and the move takes her right past **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath**, hidden behind it. She had been moving unseen until that step, but it puts her squarely in his line of sight; the half-dragon steps out and catches her twice in the same beat with the sword. She had not searched the chamber and never saw him coming.
8. The party throws everything at Langdedrosa at once. Mialee slips back, repositions, and snaps off a bow shot of her own — the arrow lands, but the column blunts the shot. Sinsong conjures a sword of pale spirit-light beside the half-dragon; he cannot see Langdedrosa directly, but the blade strikes on his behalf and lands a clean opening hit. Sinsong follows with a bolt of fire that bites through the column's cover with searing force. The half-dragon is visibly bloodied before he can counter-attack.
9. Langdedrosa's lightning breath catches the back of the chamber; Mialee, Nyx and Sinsong ride out the worst of it. Sinsong, struck hard, lets his focus slip — the spirit-blade dissolves in the air.
10. Nyx fires back from cover and her arrow finds him — a clean, hard shot — *"Toma, hijo de puta."* The half-dragon is visibly down to a sliver. Mialee uncaps a healing potion and drinks it all down, the brew settling in deep, then ducks behind a column.
11. Langdedrosa's breath gathers again at his throat. He squares up and lines a second white line down the chamber, voice carrying ahead of it: *"no vais a salir ni uno con vida de aquí."* **Eguzkilore** is caught full, **Nuberroca** partially — a wash of pale blue light running over the scorched line on the goliath's side as the worst of the breath bleeds off; two kobolds in the path of the breath drop dead.

6 - Cyanwrath falls

1. With Eguzkilore reeling from the breath and Nuberroca bleeding from his own share of it, a fresh berserker steps out from behind the columns and drives his blade into the goliath's back — a faint blue glow chasing the steel and pulling the wound shut behind it. The kobolds press in around Nuberroca; only his rage is keeping him on his feet.
2. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca calls **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** out by name: *"Langdedrosa, ¿así es como pelea un guerrero, escondiéndose detrás de rayos y atacando a los caídos? Si tienes honor, deja de jugar con presas fáciles y enfréntate a un verdadero titán. Ven a por mí, demuestra que no eres un lagarto cobarde."* The goliath dissolves into a cloud and reforms at the half-dragon's flank, bringing the greataxe down twice from behind. Both blows land squarely, and the half-dragon visibly buckles under them.
3. Eguzkilore tries to follow up with a shot, drawing on his last reserves of clarity and grit to stay upright at the wall. Mialee ducks back into cover behind the column.
4. Sinsong steps forward and calls a beam of celestial light down on Langdedrosa — but with companions in the way the beam cannot be aimed safely. It catches Eguzkilore in the side as the elf is gripping his scimitar, mid-swing at Langdedrosa, leaving him visibly wrecked and staring back at the cleric.

5. **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** recovers and rounds on Nuberroca with a sneer: *"¿Cómo puedes atreverte a retarme a un duelo cuando sois cinco atacándome a mi?"* He lines another lightning breath squarely on the goliath against the wall and lets it go; the breath rakes him, but a flicker of pale blue runs over the worst of the burn before it can sink in.
6. Nyx, with the bow at full reach, fires the killing shot. The arrow takes Langdedrosa as he stands and he goes down on one knee, then to the stone. He looks across at Nuberroca and answers him — *"no eres más que un maldito cobarde que necesita de muchos compañeros para abatirme"* — and falls. Nuberroca answers back as the half-dragon hits the stone: *"Muere bastardo rodeado de tus kobolds, perro."*
7. With the half-dragon down, Eguzkilore turns to the remaining berserker — the one that had been hitting Nuberroca from behind — and tries to talk him out of the fight: *"esta no es tu guerra, márchate y no te haremos nada."* The words land well and the berserker visibly hesitates, but the kobolds are still shooting and Nyx is hitting him from a distance; he ultimately decides to keep fighting, drives Eguzkilore down to a knee, and is then cut down by the elf himself seconds later.
8. **Langdedrosa is alive.** Sinsong reaches the half-dragon where he fell and finds him still breathing — unconscious, but his pulse holds where many others would have stopped. Nuberroca produces his rope and binds him fast before he can recover.
9. **The party loots the bodies.** Langdedrosa carried a spear, a longsword and a handful of curios — a glowing worm, a ball of grease, a piece of tree bark — plus a small purse of silver and copper. Nuberroca remarks on the glowing worm and the dwarf's bald head together. Mialee pulls a ring off one of the cult bodies, and Nuberroca claims a map off one of the kobolds.
10. Amidamaru, hearing Nyx's voice up the passage, **pulls free of his bindings**, finds his gear back in the cell, cuts past two kobolds with his claws on the way out, and meets the halfling in the corridor with word that his stretch is clear and the party can move through. Nyx hugs him in the dark; Sinsong checks him over for damage.
11. With **Amidamaru recovered** and the cave quiet, Nuberroca turns back to the half-dragon — but when he checks for breath there is none. **Langdedrosa has died** where he lay, the wounds too deep for recovery.

Session 8

2025-03-23

1 - Past the barracks

~00:30, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Leaving **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath**'s corpse behind in the columned chamber where he fell, the party crosses back to the barracks where they fought **Frulam Mondath** the day before.
2. From the corridor at the back of the barracks they catch the sound of something coming up. Eguzkilore readies an arrow on his bow, waiting on whatever clears the corridor mouth.
3. A *guard drake* bursts from the corridor and charges Eguzkilore. The elf's held arrow drives into the creature, but the drake covers the distance anyway and reaches him in melee.
4. Now with the drake at sword's reach, Eguzkilore lets the bow fall and draws his scimitar, then brings the blade down on the creature in one full swing — the cut runs as deep as the steel can carry.
5. Nuberroca charges in, weaving through the others to get to the drake — a few paces shy of the cleaner flanking angle, but he engages from where he can with **Langdedrosa**'s greatsword. The blow lands cleanly.
6. Nyx steps to a fresh angle between two of the room's beds and lines a clean bow shot into the drake.
7. The drake turns on Nuberroca with a bite and a tail-strike — both fail utterly; from across the chamber Sinsong answers with a *bolt of fire* at the drake.
8. Nuberroca, swinging recklessly, brings the greatsword up and down in a single arc and severs the drake's head clean from its body.
9. Nyx listens for what else is in the cave. Beyond the constant water-drip and cave noise, she picks out the soft beat of *wings* from the corridor the party came down — faint but distinct, larger than a bat.

2 - Frulam's quarters

1. The party advances cautiously into the chamber beyond the doorway. Nyx slips into the room with stealth; Eguzkilore moves up with her; Sinsong follows behind. Nuberroca, badly hurt from the previous fight, hangs back and asks aloud to be patched up.
2. Past the doorway lie two adjoining chambers, both *elegantly appointed* by the standards of the cult camp. The main room holds a writing table laid with several notes and a map, and a bookshelf along the wall. The bedroom beyond has a large bed and two chests — the clothing scattered around the bed reads as a woman's. Both rooms are empty of cultists.
3. Sinsong, scanning the floor, gets fixated on a small *yellow rug* tucked along the wall that does not match any of the other rug-and-furniture pairings in the chamber.
4. Sinsong steps onto the yellow rug to take a closer look. The rug gives way under his weight; he plunges through a concealed hole in the floor. At the last moment he catches hold of a rope hanging in the shaft and stops his fall.
5. Sinsong drags himself back up the rope into the chamber. He tells the others what he saw at the bottom of the shaft: a *gigantic statue*, an altar before it, and at least one drake with kobolds around it. Based on his mental map, he thinks the chamber down there can also be reached around from another way.
6. Nyx investigates the bookshelf and pulls out a *book on dragons* the cultists had been keeping. She slips it into her pack to read in her own time. After that, the halfling gathers up the loose notes from the table and pockets the map as well.
7. While the others search, Sinsong asks Nuberroca to push the drake's corpse to block the corridor, then Nuberroca shoves the bookshelf across the bedroom door as a rough barricade. From across the room Nyx watches *winged kobolds* pour out of the shaft and mutters in resignation — *"la barricada más inútil del mundo"*.

3 - The winged kobolds

1. A kobold throws a net at Eguzkilore while he stands over the hole. The throw catches him *cleanly* — he is tangled in the netting, unable to move.
2. A second kobold flutters over the elf and hurls a rock straight at the restrained Eguzkilore. The stone lands hard.
3. Another stone catches the elf archer square in the head; **Eguzkilore collapses unconscious, still tangled in the net**. Another rock follows — Sinsong is the target this time; the throw goes wide.
4. Nyx steps to the kobold pressing through the shaft and runs it through with her sword; it falls dead at her feet.
5. Sinsong calls a *spectral sword* into the air at his side, and the blade strikes the kobold pressing next to him from a flanking angle. He then crosses to Eguzkilore, lays a hand on him and steadies the elf's bleeding with a magic word, before falling back behind the writing table into cover.
6. Three kobolds press in around Nyx, two flanking her for a coordinated strike — one strike gets through and lands hard, drawing blood. She strikes the kobold on her right, killing it. Another disengages and slips towards the shaft; Nyx hacks it as it goes, but the kobold survives the hit and disappears through the hole.
7. Sinsong sends the *spectral sword* across at the last kobold pressing Nyx — the blade strikes home and obliterates the creature. He then crosses to Eguzkilore and casts a healing spell on the elf — barely enough to bring him back, but the elf cracks his eyes open.
8. Nuberroca plants himself with one foot either side of the shaft and *rips the net* off Eguzkilore with his bare hands. He hauls the elf up: *"venǵa, Eǵuzkilore, espabila, que todavía queda trabajo por hacer"*.
9. Nyx, remembering she had not done it the day before, hands one of her *maǵical berries* to each of them — one bite is enough to revive a teammate at the *threshold of life*.
10. Nyx asks aloud whether they should block the trapdoor or go down to the lower chamber; Sinsong suggests they barricade it. Nuberroca drops the heavy table over the shaft mouth to seal it for the moment.
11. The barbarian moves to the two chests in the corner: he checks the first for traps and opens it — empty. Nyx tries the second herself and finds only **women's clothing**. Eguzkilore walks the kobold bodies on the floor and pockets the meagre valuables they have.

4 - Down the rope

1. With the upper room cleared and the trapdoor barricade shoved aside, Sinsong sends his *spectral sword* down the shaft and swings it blindly in the dark — the sword has no senses of its own and finds nothing. The shaft is a *thirty feet* drop.
2. Sinsong lowers himself down the rope and ends his descent at about ten feet above the floor, where a drake below jumps to snap at him — *both bites fail*. He tries to climb back up, but Nuberroca, who has come down behind him into the shaft mouth, is jammed shoulder-to-shoulder across the tunnel above him — Sinsong cannot climb past the goliath.
3. Nyx descends the rope until she reaches Nuberroca, lets go of it, and steps up onto the goliath's shoulders so her hands are free for the bow. From that unstable perch she draws on the drake, the shot harder for the footing.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx's arrow threads the narrow gap between Nuberroca's shoulder and the wall of the shaft. Exactly as the drake lifts a claw at Sinsong below, the arrow drives into the drake's paw — the kind of shot nobody quite expects to land.
5. Sinsong slips past the drake's reach, repositions on the floor, and the spectral sword strikes the drake from a flanking angle.
6. With the shaft below clear, Nuberroca drops the rest of the way to the floor, takes up the flanking position, and brings the greatsword down on the drake. Nyx comes off the rope behind him and her arrow lands too.
7. Sinsong sends the *spectral sword* in again and follows with a *bolt of fire* for a small burn. The drake answers with one last bite at Nuberroca and slips wide. Nuberroca grips Sinsong's shoulder and a measure of his fury passes through, hardening him against the next blow; then he brings the greatsword down on the drake between them — the killing blow. The tunnel to the chamber is clear.

5 - Tiamat's chamber

1. With the drake down, the four take in the room properly. Three of the four walls and the floor are *tooled smooth* and run with damp. Bas-relief *dragons* are carved across the smooth walls, their tails knotting around one another in long looping patterns; the ceiling is left in its raw cave form.
2. The chamber's centrepiece is a vast statue of a *five-headed dragon*, each head a different make, the creature climbing out of an erupting volcano; smaller dragons in the carving fly around its flanks. Sinsong, with the right schooling, recognises **Tiamat** at once.
3. A small *wooden chest*, well-made and decorated, sits on the floor in the corner of the chamber, in front of the statue.
4. Sinsong, looking longer at the walls than the others, notices something off about the dragon carvings — there are *more black dragons than any other breed*, perhaps one in three. Nyx wonders aloud what elemental type they are but nobody at the table has the lore, so she tries to find the info on her new book.
5. Sinsong sends the *spectral sword* across to strike the chest. The blow drives the chest a hand's-breadth sideways, and the statue takes a small chip in the same arc. *Click.*
6. From the chamber rises a long *hissing* — like *the tongue of a serpent, but a hundred at once* — and then, from the mouths of every black dragon carved into the walls, a pale liquid spits out, *eating the stone wherever it touches*. The whole chamber is sprayed with it.
7. As the acid pours, the party throws themselves clear. Nuberroca's instincts pull him out faster than the others, and the party fares well — only a brief burn on each of them, and they shake the worst of it off. The burn breaks Sinsong's hold on the *spectral sword*, however, and the blade dissolves into the air.
8. The acrid *vapour* created is the worse half of the trap. They hold their breath against it and ride it out — Eguzkilore catches the worst of the cloud. After a brief, agonising moment, the acid disperses.
9. Nyx's *dragon book* is ruined by the spray, as the halfling was checking it when the trap triggered. Half its pages are eaten away. She tucks what is left back into her pack.
10. Nuberroca checks the chest for traps and decides the lock has some sort of *spring* mechanism more elaborate than a chest of this kind warrants. He sets his shield, takes the scimitar, and brings the pommel down hard on the lock. The lock breaks — but nothing further fires.
11. Nyx focuses past the cave-noise and catches two distinct sounds: *kobolds* down one corridor, *drakes* down another. She points each direction out for the others.

6 - The hatchery

1. From the *darkness* to the east a single *kobold* emerges, lifts the key off a hook on the wall and turns it in a *barred iron gate* on the right side of the chamber. Beyond the bars Nyx makes out shapes that look like *eggs* — larger than a halfling.
2. As the kobold turns the key in the gate, two *drakes* answer it with a long roar from the deeper passage. Another kobold follows on its heels.
3. Eguzkilore advances and puts an arrow into the first drake. Sinsong's bolt of fire takes a kobold cleanly across the floor.
4. Nuberroca plants himself in the corridor mouth and brings the greatsword down with full force on one of the kobolds — the blow lands true and deep.
5. The drakes shift to pin Nuberroca from two sides. The first drake catches him with a bite and a tail-strike; a *blue glow* runs across each fresh cut and closes it partway. Nuberroca is still badly hurt, but his fury holds the worst of it back.
6. From the bend, Nyx puts a *clean hard arrow* into the first drake and drops it dead — the arrow is left lodged in its head. Nuberroca lets out a clearly audible breath.
7. The second drake repositions to flank Nuberroca and presses again — bite and tail. The blows land, but his fury holds.
8. Sinsong, from cover, hurls a *bolt of fire* at the surviving drake — a long, roaring stream that arcs past Nuberroca's cheek and tears clean into the creature. *"Os he vuelto a salvar"*.
9. Nuberroca brings the greatsword down on the wounded drake. The east passage is clear.
10. Nyx walks the bodies afterward and recovers two of her arrows from the kobolds. Eguzkilore recovers one of his own. Sinsong gathers the four of them in close and weaves a *bonded blessing* over them.

7 – Behind the iron gate

1. The party walks up to the *iron gate* the kobold had opened. The key is hanging on a hook nearby. Through the bars Nyx makes out three *eggs*, roughly a metre tall each, in straw, and *blood-stains* on the floor that *do not look fresh*. The chamber beyond stretches out past the reach of their light.
2. Nyx asks the group whether they want to go in and investigate. Eguzkilore wants in; Nuberroca cautions them to enter with care, in stealth and in the shadows.
3. Eguzkilore eases through the gate and down the few steps into the egg chamber, treading carefully so as not to make a sound.
4. Sinsong calls for action: he raises a *bolt of fire* at one of the eggs and the **straw under it catches**. The egg itself stays intact in the flame.
5. Nuberroca strides over to the burning egg and brings the greatsword down two-handed. The shell splits and a *half-formed dragon hatchling* crawls out, manages a single rasping attempt at breath, and *dies* on the floor. He looks at the others, tears a small wing from the body and tries to *cook it over the burning straw*.
6. Nyx, watching the goliath cook a half-formed dragon, walks back to the iron gate and quietly takes the key off the hook on the wall, slipping it into her pocket. In case something goes wrong, she explains, they can run out and close the gate. Nuberroca approves.
7. Eguzkilore drifts over to join Nuberroca and asks if there is anything else worth taking off the hatchling — a scale, a claw. There is not. He sits down with the goliath and the two of them set about cooking a slice of half-formed dragon over the burning straw.
8. While the two cook, Nyx puts the question to the group plainly: should they *destroy* the remaining eggs so they cannot grow up and cause harm later, or leave them? Nuberroca floats *taking one with them* instead.

8 – The living column

1. To the east of the chamber one of the cave columns *begins to move*. A long *tentacle* unfurls from it, snakes across the floor to the broken egg, hooks the dead hatchling and drags it back — *"comida"*.
2. The party reads it for what it is — **a Roper** — a column-shaped predator, frankly large and, at least for the moment, only interested in eating.
3. Eguzkilore breaks for the gate at a dash, calling for Nyx to ready the key. Sinsong, behind cover, lobs another *bolt of fire* at a different egg as bait — the straw beneath it catches too.
4. Nuberroca cracks open the recently ignited egg with the greatsword; another half-formed hatchling, like the first, fails its first breath and dies on the floor. He gestures at the Roper and points to the body — *"comida"*.
5. The Roper crawls slowly toward the gate, hooks the second hatchling on a tentacle and eats it on the move.
6. Sinsong slips outside the gate, swings it shut behind him, and through the bars hurls a final *bolt of fire* at the Roper. The creature shudders under the flame; from its bulk dozens of fresh tentacles boil up, *writhing*.
7. Tentacles whip out across the chamber. The first volley mostly fails, but a second wave catches Nuberroca cleanly — and where it touches, tiny *needles* drive into the skin and *drain the strength* out of him. Later strikes catch Eguzkilore as well and pull him hard against the iron gate; the gate strains but holds.
8. The Roper *climbs the ceiling* and crosses through the gap above the iron gate, stretching its body over the bars. From the new vantage it reaches tentacles to both sides — biting Nuberroca on the way through, a heavy blow, even with his fury blunting the worst of it. A *blue glow* flickers across the bite as it opens, but the wound outpaces it. The goliath is staying upright on fury alone. Another tentacle grapples Nyx.
9. Nuberroca *dissolves into a wisp of cloud* out of the monster's grip and reforms behind Nyx. He plants himself and tears the tentacle off her by main strength.
10. Nyx hurls the last two *rations* in her pack at the Roper as bait. A clean, vicious tentacle catches Nyx in the same moment, but the Roper's hunger overrides the rest of its attacks — it drags the food in with two tentacles and eats them in two bites.
11. Eguzkilore cuts free of the tentacle that has him and moves toward the shrine's chamber, but the path is jammed with Sinsong at the doorway and he can advance no further.

9 - A CHANCE TO SCAPE

1. ***[EPIC]*** Sinsong, with the situation about to get past the party, *weaves a binding of sleep* over the Roper. The creature's tentacles slacken; it slumps where it stands — stupor deep enough to hold for a while, as long as no one strikes it.
2. With the Roper slumped from Sinsong's binding, Eguzkilore breaks past him and dashes the rest of the way out.
3. Nuberroca takes the moment Sinsong's *sleep* has bought and crosses back to the wooden chest. The thing is heavy — *sixty pounds* — but he gathers it under one arm and falls back toward the rope, his stride halved by the load.
4. Nyx still has the key in her pocket, but the gate was already shut from when Sinsong slipped out, and with the Roper slumped across the gap on the ceiling, locking it would change nothing. She turns away from the bars and falls in with the rest of the retreat.
5. The four of them work their way back to the shaft and start the climb up — Nyx leads, Eguzkilore and Sinsong behind her, Nuberroca with the chest. The Roper, behind them, stays where it slumped.

Session 9

2025-04-06

1 - The cave mouth

~01:00, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. At the cave's outer chamber, Amidamaru and Mialee face *three kobolds* who just jumped on them from deeper in the cave.
2. Below, the party who descended into the Tiamat-statue chamber haul themselves up the shaft — Nuberroca carrying the heavy wooden chest from the shrine up with him, *slow* under its weight — leaving the Roper *asleep* behind.
3. Nyx, remembering that the monster's bulk *deforms* enough to squeeze through narrow places, asks Nuberroca to help her tip the chamber's *bookshelf* across the shaft mouth. Between the two of them, the heavy shelf goes down and the hole is sealed.
4. Eguzkilore plants himself between the two doorways and *holds his shot for whatever moves first*.
5. Mialee opens with a clean arrow at the kobold closing on Amidamaru, the kobold drops and she hides back.
6. With the shelf in place, and unaware of her friends' struggle, Nyx walks across to Frulam Mondath's abandoned bed and lies down on it for a moment.
7. The remaining kobolds swarm Amidamaru — three blows in quick succession, the third lands hard. **Amidamaru collapses unconscious** at the cave mouth.
8. Nuberroca, hearing nothing from the bedroom, returns down the corridor. Eguzkilore is jammed in the doorway as a stopper — Nuberroca breaks into a run and squeezes past him through the narrow gap.
9. Mialee, from cover, threads another shot into a second kobold — the creature's eyes are on the downed tortle, not on her, and the arrow finds a vital spot. The third kobold remains.
10. Nuberroca, arriving at the scene, *hurls his greataxe* at the surviving kobold — the throw goes wide. *The kobold flinches as the spinning blade whirls over its head and embeds itself in a stone column behind it*. The stone cracks, but the kobold lives.
11. Mialee crosses to where Amidamaru is bleeding out and presses one of Nyx's *berries* into his mouth. The tortle comes back at the *threshold of life*. From cover behind a rock, Nyx threads a perfect shot into the last kobold and the chamber is silent again.

2 - The watch-cave

1. Nuberroca demands a long rest — *non-negotiable*. Amidamaru, *tortured during his captivity*, has not slept and presses for the same. Nyx is mostly fresh and offers to keep watch. They pull back to the small cave on the white cliffs — the one they had used to surveil the hideout the day before.
2. On the way out, Nuberroca pauses by the body of **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** that the party left behind a few hours ago. He confirms the half-dragon is dead, then dislodges the greataxe and **decapitates him**. He fastens the head to his belt by a strap, *hanging visible*.
3. Inside the watch-cave, Nyx prepares a fresh batch of *berries* — ten in all, one for each teammate and five for herself. She tells Nuberroca that one berry sustains a person for the day and *heals a little*.
4. While the others bed down, Nyx asks Amidamaru what the cultists *wanted* from him during his captivity. He prefers not to discuss what they did to him, but volunteers that they wanted to know about **Leosin** *the monk*, *what we had done* with him and *where he was*. Nyx files the thread away — they will have to go looking for him once they are out of here.
5. As the last task before the watches begin, Mialee turns to the **wooden chest** Nuberroca had carried out — its lock already broken open by the goliath's scimitar pommel in the shrine chamber. Even so, the party stays cautious of whatever else the cult might have layered into it: Nuberroca sets the chest deep in the cave and steps well away, and from a safe distance Mialee conjures an unseen hand of force and works the lid open through it. A small *click* as the lid gives — nothing further.
6. The chest holds *pearls*, several *gems* of various sizes, a *fine ring* that takes no magical aura under Mialee's touch, a *broken-diamond fragment*, and a *necklace*, also non-magical. Mialee thinks the lot may belong to families in Greenest — they could return them.

3 - First light

~09:30, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The night watches pass without incident — eight hours of rest, no one approaching the cave. As the sun rises, a great flock of bats — *thousands, probably tens of thousands* — pours into the cave.
2. By full morning the party debates next steps. Nyx wants to push *north* into the cave system, but leaving the last dragon egg intact would be a problem. Eguzkilore and Mia report seeing no movement out of the cave through the night.
3. The party approaches the outer entrance and finds the whole place *strewn* with loose coins, scraps of cloth — *the kobolds' loincloths* — and assorted small junk. The Roper has *escaped*: Nyx reads the spread as the creature crawling out to feast on what was left of the kobold corpses.
4. Mialee, who never met the Roper, asks what they are about to face. Nyx describes it: *column-shaped*, *tentacled*, *massive*; it had hooked her by the chest yesterday before someone — Nuberroca, or maybe Eguzkilore — tore the tentacle off. *"Tortuga, cuidado, que como te coja el Roper..."*.

4 - Gold on the floor

~10:00, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Amidamaru — drawn by the *gold scattered on the floor* — strides ahead of the rest, scooping the most valuable pieces into his pack.
2. As he rounds one of the cave columns, *tentacles unfurl from it* — what he took for a pillar is the Roper itself, its bulk indistinguishable from the stone columns around it. In a single beat its tentacles snake out and seize *both* Amidamaru and Nuberroca — two tentacles each. *Sticky, needled* — pulling them in.
3. Nyx raises a binding of *coloured light* over the creature — its outline lights up across the cave, making the creature easier to target.
4. Amidamaru, gripped by the tentacles around his shell, throws his hands out in a *cone of fire* — straight at the Roper and the tentacles holding them. The creature twists away from the worst of the flare, protecting its body from most of the searing heat.
5. Eguzkilore advances and lines a shot at the lit-up creature, missing badly despite the clear angle. Nuberroca, restrained, brings the greatsword down on the tentacle around Amidamaru — the blow lands cleanly, but the tentacle holds.
6. The Roper draws its bound captives in 25 feet at a single pull, bites Nuberroca when close enough, and lashes fresh tentacles around Nyx and Eguzkilore as well — *the needles drive in and the strength runs out of them*.
7. Eguzkilore, still tangled, threads a perfect shot into the creature; the Roper *bleeds slightly*, but stays standing. The body is too large to feel a single arrow.
8. ***[EPIC]*** Amidamaru fires a second *cone of fire* across the Roper. The creature cannot twist clear this time; **every tentacle burns off**, freeing the grappled party in the same breath. *"No necesitamos a Sinsong, me tienen a mí"*.
9. Eguzkilore, pulling back to safer ground, takes a *bite* on the way out — heavy damage but he stays up. Mialee threads a shot into the Roper's flank with one of her last arrows. Nuberroca shares a little of his fury with Nyx while she stands behind him, *saving her life* with a thin shield of borrowed strength.
10. The Roper *grows six new tentacles in a single moment* and rises full again. Out of the new surge it lunges, opens its jaw, and bites Amidamaru — *the shell crunches* under the bite, blood streams from the tortle's flank, *one arm hangs useless* with the pain.
11. Nyx puts her full strength into a sword-swing — the blade, seething with dark energy, bites deeper than expected and the creature reels.
12. Amidamaru throws his third *cone of fire* — the Roper cannot twist clear again, every tentacle catches once more. The room fills with the stench of burning flesh.
13. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca pushes Amidamaru away from the monster and brings the greatsword down two-handed on the column's body. The Roper *gives* — the column begins to deform under the blow, *half-digested kobold flesh* sloughs out from underneath, and the whole creature collapses on the floor in an *unpleasant* wet heap. *"¡Espera que voy a echar la pota!"* — Nyx, vomiting berries.
14. A lone *kobold* who had stayed clear of the fight breaks for the inner cave; Eguzkilore levels his bow and *takes him down* with a single shot.
15. The party patches up afterward. Amidamaru hands Nuberroca a handful of pebbles he has *tinkered* to give off dim light at 5–10 feet — torches that don't need oil.

> *¡Espera que voy a echar la pota!*
>
> --- Nyx, *vomiting berries.*

5 - The barracks

1. The party heads back inward, going again towards the explored chambers. Mialee summons **Echo** — her *bat familiar* — and sends it ahead through the corridor to see what waits.
2. Echo, hanging from the ceiling, returns the count: **five kobolds and one drake** roosting on the old barracks beds. They are *making the place their own* — settling in.
3. Nuberroca decides to charge for the surprise. The kobold at the door sees him coming as he runs in — *no real surprise* — and the goliath's opening blow misses.
4. The kobolds fall back in coordinated pairs, working together. A net flies across the corridor and catches Eguzkilore, leaving him restrained, his bow useless.
5. Mialee — too far to cut him free in person — calls up an unseen hand of force, lifts a dagger from her own belt in mid-air, and slashes at the net with it. The net is weakened and Eguzkilore tears through the rest with a pull.
6. Nuberroca rakes through the kobold line with the greatsword, swinging recklessly. He takes hits — kobold *darts* and the drake's bite-and-tail-strike — but his fury holds the worst of it back, a faint *blue glow* knitting each fresh cut closed as it opens.
7. Nyx pulls a clean shot into the drake from her cover — she has had it tracked since the start of the fight, making the shot more damaging. By then Eguzkilore drops the last kobold standing in the corridor with a precise arrow.
8. With only the drake left in the room, Mialee threads a follow-up shot into it from her flank. The drake totters but doesn't fall.
9. Nuberroca squares with the drake from a flanking angle and brings the greatsword down in a lethal arc. The drake takes the blow and dies on the floor.

6 - Down the rope

1. With the barracks clear, Nuberroca walks over to Amidamaru with his *arm bleeding and badly cut up* and asks for help. Amidamaru, deadpan — *I can help you, but that's where my help ends*. Nuberroca calls on the cleric — *"Sinsong, cúrame"* — and Sinsong weaves a powerful healing over the goliath; Nuberroca is brought back nearly whole.
2. The party walks back to Frulam's quarters. Nyx confirms her suspicion — the *bookshelf barricade* across the shaft is *broken through*, the area beyond wrecked. The Roper had to smash through the shelf to get past — it had forced its way out before dawn.
3. Nyx volunteers to scout the lower chamber first — *quiet, alone, then signal up*. She slides down the rope and lands behind cover. From her position she messages her partners: *clear*.
4. The party drops down the rope into the south-west corner of the shrine chamber, but before they can push out from the landing Nyx signals them — *kobolds, many*.

7 - The shrine

~10:30, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. As soon as the party pushes into the chamber, the kobolds — *prepared and waiting* — open with a hail of *sling-stones* from cover. Others dart in close, daggers out, less to wound than to *keep the heroes hemmed in* — and with the party hard-pressed at arm's reach, the slingers' stones find their marks almost every time.
2. Mialee, who had held still to steady her aim, finally lands a clean shot — the arrow slips past a kobold's guard; Nyx ribs her that it's her first all morning.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca hauls **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath's severed head** off his belt and *brandishes it* at the kobolds. His fury and the trophy together make the threat work; three kobolds *break and run, frightened*.
4. Nyx, badly bloodied, pulls back behind a table for cover. The remaining kobolds press into the corridor mouth.
5. With the halfling safe, the party closes the wave down — Amidamaru slays a kobold at the corridor mouth, Nuberroca *pulps* another outright, a *bolt of fire* takes a third, and Eguzkilore's bow drops one more. The last of the ambushers — those not already cut down or routed — break and flee into the dark.
6. With the first wave broken and a brief lull, Nyx points out the dragon egg the previous night had left intact. Mialee asks what to do: break it or carry it. Nuberroca, from across the chamber, settles it — *"¡Destruid el huevo!"*.

7. Mia slips through the iron gate into the **hatchery** and strikes the egg with a sharp blow — the shell holds. She then pours the last of her oil across the straw of the nest and lights it as she retreats back toward the shrine.
8. The fire is barely settling when a fresh wave of kobolds — slipped in unseen through the side tunnels while the party's eyes were on the egg — falls on them.
9. The kobold pack focuses on Eguzkilore — crowding in close so their blows land thick and fast; he **goes down** on the chamber floor, breath shallow, and the press of kobolds walls him off — none of his partners can cut through to reach him.
10. The kobolds then turn on Amidamaru — stones and a dagger driven home as the pack closes around him — and **the tortle drops to the ground**, slumping unconscious at the tunnel mouth he had been watching. His breath shallows alongside the elf's.
11. Meanwhile Nyx, half-broken behind her table and *out of options*, weaves an illusion of a kobold over herself — *as close to one of theirs as she can manage*. She steps out and orders the kobolds, in Common, *not to kill the others — the mistress wants them alive, especially the elf*. Her accent slips — Common is not the kobolds' tongue — but the survivors begin to *repeat orders back to those behind them* in Draconic that the party cannot understand.
12. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore's body lurches once more against the dark — a last shudder runs the length of the elf, his hand scrabbling weakly at the cold stone for a bow that is no longer in reach. Blood spreads black beneath him in the half-light; the breath rattles slow out of his chest and does not draw back. **Eguzkilore *dies* on the floor of the Tiamat chamber**, under the five-headed statue and the guttering flame of the candles — beyond any saving.
13. The kobolds, *not killing for sport* and now seemingly under the disguised orders, send one of their own across to attempt to *stabilise* the elf, but Eguzkilore is already gone. The kobolds begin to *drag the body out* toward the cave entrance. Amidamaru stabilises quietly in the background as the fight winds down.

8 - The bat-cave

1. While the fight in the Tiamat chamber was raging, Nuberroca had broken away down the tunnel he'd been guarding, set on learning how the kobold reinforcements were reaching them so fast. The way was *near-black*, but he could make out their tracks and **a flight of stairs they had descended**. As he cleared the stairs, *the ceiling caved in* — not on top of him, but sealing the corridor at his back.
2. Unable to see, he took out one of the *glowing pebbles* Amidamaru had given him and pressed on by its dim light. A stretch of floor *gave way* under his weight, and *poisoned needles hidden underneath* drove into his foot — he shook off the worst, but the poison left him *light-headed*, not quite drugged.
3. The cave opened around him: the floor thick with *bat guano*, scattered with small *bat corpses* drained dry — *husks, desiccated*. Far overhead, past the reach of his light, the ceiling was *alive with thousands of bats* — heard more than seen.
4. Nuberroca worked his way along, *hugging the wall* on the broken ground, hunting for anything useful — *potions, weapons*. By a *pile of old bones* in the north he caught a *glint* of something down in the refuse and moved to take it.
5. The *stench* hit him first. *Four troglodytes* — reptilian and foul — uncoiled from cracks in the wall, already almost on him; in the dark his sight reached barely ten feet. They pressed him from every side with tooth and claw; his *shield* turned most of it, but one raking blow got through. *Cornered*, the barbarian knew the fight here was not winnable in numbers.
6. Nuberroca *winks into a swirl of cloud* and re-forms thirty feet clear of the pack, the troglodytes letting him go. The way he came in is sealed by the cave-in behind him, so he strikes out by another route — and catches the *soft purple glow* of the fungi chamber the party had pushed through on its first descent into the cave. He makes for the light and works his way back toward the *entry chamber*.

9 - Mialee's gambit

1. Mialee, taking Nyx's disguise as the model, weaves an illusion of a kobold over herself — *taller than most but small enough to pass for the largest of theirs*. She steps out among the wreckage and tells the kobolds in front of her, in Common, *that there is nothing here*.
2. Mia then remembers the *trap plate* Nyx had warned the party about — the floor plate under where the chest had sat. She calls up her unseen hand of force and presses the plate from above.
3. ***[EPIC]*** The *hissing* rises in the chamber again. *Acid pours from every dragon mouth* in the walls; the spraying is followed by the *vapour cloud*. **Most of the kobolds in the chamber die**, choking in the spray or the gas; *four* survive and bolt. Mialee, caught by the spray, takes a hit of acid burn herself.
4. **Amidamaru**, unconscious on the floor, catches the spray and the gas with everyone else. The first lash of acid strips away the fragile hold that had kept him steady; the choking cloud behind it drives the next breath wrong in his chest. He is no longer merely down — he is *dying*.

10 - The long way out

1. Nyx, in her kobold disguise, walks out alongside the *kobold dragging Eguzkilore's body* — taking up the second arm to help carry the elf toward the entrance. Along the corridor she cuts the helper kobold's throat.
2. Nuberroca, returning at a dash from the bat-cave, meets a *kobold* in the corridor that calls out *"Soy Nyx"* in his face. He picks the creature up by the head, finds *the skull does not match the kobold* it should be under the illusion, and sets her down again. Together with Eguzkilore's body between them, they make for the cave entrance.
3. Mialee, *still in the kobold-illusion*, crosses the wreckage of the Tiamat chamber to **Amidamaru**, drops a *berry* into his mouth, and tells him to run — *back the way we came in, the path is clear*.
4. At the cave entrance, Sinsong receives Eguzkilore's body. He weaves a magical ward over the corpse to *halt decay* — ten days before the chance of resurrection closes. The dwarf declines to spend his remaining power on healing the others while there is still a body to keep.
5. The kobolds returning to the chamber, alerted by Mialee and Amidamaru's run, charge to intercept. Stones rain down from several angles at once; one catches Amidamaru on the run and **the tortle drops again**. Mia finds herself overtaken by the survivors closing on her position.

Session 10

2025-04-13

1 - Prayer or blood

~11:00, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. In the cave entrance the party has Eguzkilore's body laid down — Nyx, still disguised as a kobold, struggles to say it plainly: *he is gone*. Inside the temple of Tiamat, Amidamaru is sprawled out cold, barely breathing. Mialee, in kobold form, is nearby.
2. Nuberroca won't leave Eguzkilore lying there and bundles the body across his back with rope, slung like a pack.
3. The barbarian, *bleeding*, then asks Sinsong to heal him before he runs back inside. Sinsong demands prayer first: *"levanta las manos y grita 'Sinsong'"*. Nuberroca grabs him by the head and presses back — *"¿Por qué te tengo que rezar? ¿Quién eres tú? ¿Y por qué tienes esas marcas en la cabeza?"*. Sinsong's pitch: *"Soy una persona que cree que se pueden hacer las cosas bien, pero para eso necesito amigos que puedan acompañarme en este viaje"*.
4. Nyx breaks off, out of patience — *"estáis hablando mucho y no estáis haciendo nada"*. When Sinsong finally moves, he heals Nyx instead — *the one within easy reach* — leaving Nuberroca unhealed.
5. Sinsong folds an *emboldening bond* across the party. Nyx dashes into the cave to reach Amidamaru and Mialee; Sinsong sets off last and, with the others already out of sight, loses the trail in the dark.
6. Inside, Mialee slips Amidamaru a *healing potion* from his own belt-pouch; the tortle stirs, *back from the threshold*. She then turns and runs a clean blade through the kobold beside her — dropping all pretense. The wounded kobold can't square it — *a kobold striking a kobold* is *anathema* to their mentality — and the pack closes on her at once, blades finding the gaps from every side.
7. Amidamaru, on his feet again, brings his *infused* blade through the nearest kobold — *the strike kills, and green fire skips off the corpse to scorch the kobold beside it*. One down, one burning.
8. The kobold pack focuses on Amidamaru — blows landing from every angle as they close in, every swing finding home. **The tortle drops again**. Mialee, alone now against the remaining kobolds, slips behind a column to hide, but a kobold tracks her, *finds her*, and lands a clean hit. **She goes down.**

2 - Gruesome rescue

1. Nuberroca reaches the shaft that drops to the Tiamat chamber and takes the descent the fast way — he steps off the edge without doubt, twists in mid-air, and catches enough rope to soften the landing. The fall stings — rope-burns across his palms, a scrape down one shin — then *a soft blue glow flickers across his skin and the scratches close over*, and the blood-fury already roaring through him swallows the rest.
2. The goliath dissolves into *a swirl of cloud* and re-forms at Amidamaru's shoulder thirty feet across the chamber. Then he recognizes Mialee too — *choking on her own blood, gasping for breath*. He has barely a step left to reach her, but there is a kobold in his way.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca *hurls Eguzkilore's body at the kobold pressing Mialee* to clear his path — the off-balance throw goes wide and the body slams into the stone floor. *A sickening crack as an arm folds back in an unnatural way; teeth snap loose against the stone; a slow line of blood draws across the floor from the elf's slack mouth.*
4. Ignoring the kobold, the barbarian takes another step, pulls the bandages and salves from his belt-pouch and works on Mialee until her breathing steadies.
5. Nyx kneels beside Amidamaru and presses one of her *berries* into his mouth in a single quick motion. The tortle's eyes open again.
6. The last kobold breaks for the door. Nuberroca's greataxe meets it at the edge of the chamber — *the kobold's pieces tumble on the floor*. The fight is over.

3 - The lone explorer

~11:30, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Nuberroca scoops Mialee and Eguzkilore up onto his shoulders — the elves are slight against the goliath's bulk — and climbs the rope back up the shaft to **Mondath's quarters** above, his clothes still aglow from Sinsong's *light* cantrip. Eguzkilore's body dangles on his back, the broken arm jutting wrong under the rope, blood gone tacky on Nuberroca's shirt where the elf presses.
2. Nyx, still in her kobold-disguise, follows behind, slipping a *berry* into Mialee's mouth as they walk — *"en mi tribu me enseñaron que no se deja ningún hombre atrás"*. Mialee comes around against Nuberroca's shoulder.
3. Inside the room, the goliath drags one of the low shelves across the doorway as a *barricade*. Mialee calls **Echo** — her bat familiar — but the bat is dead, killed when Mialee activated the acid trap in the statue chamber.
4. Sinsong, meanwhile, had been exploring alone — the party had run too far ahead for him to follow. He descended the ramped corridor past the remains of the *purple fungi*, reached a high-ceilinged cave *alive with bats*, the floor *thick with guano*, scattered with *desiccated bat corpses*. Past it he heard heavy footfalls and a growling deeper down; he called for the others without answer and turned back the way he came.
5. Coming back towards the cave's entrance Sinsong sees a kobold — *Nyx, still in disguise, searching for him* — and lulls it into slumber, mistaking her for an enemy. As he reaches in to check the kobold's body he notices something off — *the body doesn't match what his hands are telling him*. He grapples her and shakes the slumber loose. *"Sinsong, cabrón. Que soy yo. Soy Nyx"*. *"¡Hostia, Nyx!"*. He apologises and lets her go.
6. The party settles in to catch their breath behind the barricade — an hour of quiet. **Munin**, Amidamaru's summoned owl, takes the watch. Nyx and Mia pull off their kobold-form at last and the halfling steps over to slip a *berry* into Eguzkilore's *pocket*.
7. Nyx finally reads the papers she grabbed from Mondath's desktop. *A map* of the Greenfields — *arrows from the towns the cult has hit, all bending west toward Beregost and then north*. A side note: *all goods to be freighted north to Naerytar*. The other papers: Rezmir — *the wirmspeaker* — has *permitted* them to keep some pearls and small valuables; dry camp logistics of no use to the party — *watch rotations, ration counts*; and, *a handful of bad dragon poems*.
8. After resting, Sinsong approaches Nuberroca weaving a prayer of healing through his palm, and the goliath, recovered, thanks him.

4 - The last egg

1. Sinsong wants the *third dragon egg* — the one Mialee set on fire — destroyed before they leave. *Smash the egg, then revive him*, he proposes. Nuberroca agrees on the first part.
2. The party descends back to the egg chamber. Sinsong opens with a *bolt of light* at the shell — it strikes home but the egg holds. He follows with a *fire bolt*; still no crack.
3. Nuberroca steps up and brings his *greataxe* down on the shell — a small crack opens. He follows with the *greatsword*, driving the blade through the breach. *Inside, the dragonling cries out in agony, then falls silent*. Acid washes over the blade as he draws it free — *the blade holds, but the acid scores marks into the steel*.
4. Nuberroca then takes some straw and uses the acid to *etch the rune he wears on his belt* into both the greatsword's blade and the axe-head. *There — that's my writing.*

5 - Strange offerings

1. *"¿Volvemos por la ruta pintoresca o la corta?"* — Nuberroca lays out what he knows of the cave's north end from his previous exploration. Past the bat cave is a chamber with *troglodytes*, and beside it *another chamber with drake-sound from inside*. Mialee and Nyx push to leave — they have what they came for, Eguzkilore needs the *cleric in Greenest*, the cave's western route they know is clear.
2. Nuberroca wants to check the *kobold quarters* — the burrow the reinforcements had streamed in from — and heads in ahead of the group, Eguzkilore's body left lying on the ground behind him. Nyx starts to follow for support, but the ambush comes first — *two kobolds drop from the ceiling*, surprising him, one scoring a hit as it lands. The kobolds scuttle out through a wall-gap before he can chase. Nuberroca picks his way around the empty chamber: *no traps*, and at the back, a strange offering pile.
3. *88 small piles of 8 copper coins each*, surrounded by *scattered gold and silver — that smells ritual*, Nyx says quietly. Mounded against the wall is a heap of *dragon-amulets* — most are shoddy, whittled wooden things, but one is heavier, *worked in gold*. Nuberroca takes the gold amulet and scoops the coin-piles together.

6 - The drake nursery

1. They follow Nuberroca's route — north out through the cave-in he had triggered on his way out the previous trip. Sinsong walks across first, the rocks above holding. *Then a fresh fall comes down* — most of it crashes around Nuberroca, opening a fresh gash across his shoulder and a cut over his temple; *a soft blue glow flickers across him and the wounds close* as he walks on. A chip of stone catches Mialee on the shoulder right behind him.
2. Sinsong, *impatient*, runs ahead. He slips down into the floor of *the next chamber* before the others can call him back. The room is large and *deeper than the corridor* — a pit ringed by climbing walls, with *broken humanoid mannequins* against the back wall, *bite-marks worn through them*. *Three drakes* jump on him — smaller than the others they have seen, but together they pose a serious threat.
3. Sinsong scrambles for the lip of the pit, scaling the rough side as the drakes lunge after him. One catches him as he climbs — *claw across the back*. The party closes in from the corridor mouth. Nuberroca finds the pit's edge thanks to his magic light and opens the iron gate at the top. Amidamaru runs through into the dark behind him. *Nyx climbs onto the lip from the side*, scrambling up the rough wall hand-over-foot without slowing.
4. Mialee, perched above the pit on the corridor lip, threads an arrow straight into the lead drake's *eye* — the shot lands true from above. *The beast reels*, blood streaming where the arrow stands.
5. Sinsong's body lights up with *celestial radiance*, light pouring from him to fill the pit, his bald head glowing. He calls a *prayer of healing* on himself as the drakes claw at him, his wounds emitting a soft red glow as they knit together. The drakes flinch from the radiance as it begins to *scorch them*.
6. Munin the owl drifts over the pit, perching on the dwarf's shoulder to *deliver a healing spell* — the worst of the claw-wounds seals shut. Mialee sends a second shaft into the staggering lead drake from above; Nuberroca's axe-swing at the same beast goes wide.
7. Nyx, with her last arrow, fires at the reeling drake she had been tracking; the drake falls. Her eye is on the next before her arm has lowered.
8. Sinsong steps in with a *necrotic touch* on the closest drake — the attack lands, while the radiance *scorches it*, but it stays on its feet. *"De nada, Sinsong, por curarte"* — mutters Amidamaru.
9. Nuberroca brings the greataxe down on it — the blow lands clean, shredding the drake through, and the beast falls.
10. Amidamaru, from the upper lip, snaps a *fire bolt* at the last surviving drake.
11. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx pulls two arrows from a *fallen drake's carcass*, sets one on the bow, and threads the shot into the last drake. As the arrow strikes, a single swing of Nuberroca's *greatsword* finishes the work.

7 - The cold storage

~12:00, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. A short corridor links the drake nursery to the bat cave. Crossing it, Sinsong steps on a *soft, leathery tile that gives under his weight* — a needle bites up through his sandal into his sole, leaving him a little *light-headed*. On the cave's east side, a curtain of leather strips hangs across an opening.
2. Mialee scans the floor ahead and finds more of the same — *soft, leathery tiles* in the floor beneath; the leather gives under weight and lets the needles, coated in some greenish fluid, bite up through the sole. With Nyx steadying her, she packs sand and dirt into the space beneath each tile until the leather can no longer give.
3. Past the bat cave they reach the leather-strip curtain. Several of the strips are *threaded with fishhooks dipped in some darker liquid*. Mialee calls up her *unseen hand* and lifts the strips clear from above so the party can walk through unsnagged; Amidamaru raises a second hand to mirror her.
4. The room beyond *stinks of rot* and is colder than the rest of the cave. *Chains and meat-hooks* hang between the pillars; some carry *animal carcasses, several fresh, some long past*. The cult's *cold storage*. *Nothing of use* among the tools. They go back and continue to the exit.
5. The party clears the cave's outer mouth in silence. The walk back to Greenest is *four hours by foot*; with Eguzkilore's body on Nuberroca's back the count comes to *five hours*. The road is uneventful.

8 – Briefing at the Keep

~17:00, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Inside Greenest keep, Nyx lays the *map and notes* on **Tarbaw Nighthill**'s table. He reads the *Greenfields chart* with the arrows bending west — *this is genuinely important* — and confirms they should carry the find to **Leosin** at **Elturel**, where Leosin is bound. He promises to send *the same warning* to every contact the keep can reach, especially along *Beregost*. Tarbaw counts out *50 gold pieces* from his own purse as a thank-you.
2. Mialee shows Tarbaw the *ring* she lifted from the cult cave the night before — a gold band with a worked stone. Tarbaw recognises it: *the Dolenza Zirrine* of Greenfields, *one of the richer families in town, robbed in the raid*. He arranges its return — *250 gold pieces* as the family's thanks. *"Estoy orgulloso de ti, Mialee"* — says Nuberroca, his hand on her shoulder.
3. Nuberroca asks for a final favour — *the cleric* who revived Sinsong, *can he raise their fallen?* Tarbaw writes them a letter of recommendation asking whoever reads it to *help them save their companion*. The cleric will be at the *Temple of Chauntea* if not at *the dragon's mansion* north of the keep.
4. **Escobert the Red** receives Cyanwrath's head a moment later — *Nuberroca brought it on his belt*. Escobert grins and asks if he may *mount it on the castle gate*. Nuberroca agrees, on one condition: *"me gustaría que se recordase que el último golpe se le di yo". We'll put your name on a plaque*, Escobert grins back. Later, Nyx pulls Nuberroca aside — *it was actually one of her arrows that landed the kill* — but she lets the story stand for Escobert's sake.
5. Tarbaw also presses the party for *resupply* — arrows, axes, rations, all the gear they had used up; Nyx asks for arrows above all. He lends them *nine horses* — one each for the six of them, plus **Miguel** as escort and *two guards* for local support, with Miguel and the guards to return the horses to Greenest afterward. **Leosin** has separately left fresh mounts and provisions prepaid at the stables — those are the horses the party will ride north to Elturel.

9 – The diamond

~18:00?, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The cleric — *the same one who had brought Sinsong back* — greets them at the temple. He looks at Eguzkilore's body and asks the only question that matters: *How long has it been?*. The party debates aloud — *the night's full rest at the bat cave fell before Eguzkilore died, not after* — and the count comes out to *seven hours since the death*. *Raise Dead* is on the table.
2. The cost: a *pure diamond, at least five hundred gold pieces*, burned into the rite itself; *2,500 gold pieces* for the casting, knocked down to *1,700 on Tarbaw's letter* and further to *1,500* in the final negotiation. The party has neither the diamond nor that much coin.
3. They cross the keep to the only *jeweller's* in Greenest — **Bryert**, *a smug, well-dressed man* with the bearing of money. Sinsong, who had laid *guidance* over Nyx for the bargaining, betrays the spell mid-pitch — the quiet syllables and finger-traces no jeweller's eye would miss. The pitch goes flat anyway: *If you want to buy things, this is a shop. The prices are clearly marked*.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee, watching the count, lays five *worked gems* she had been holding on the counter — *roughly five hundred gold pieces' worth* between them — and asks plainly to trade them straight across for one of his diamonds. The pitch lands cleaner than Sinsong's ever did — *Bryert agrees: the gems for one of his diamonds*. Mialee also picks up *a small 75-gp diamond for Amidamaru* before they leave.

10 – Eguzkilore restored

~19:00?, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Back at the temple the party pools every coin they carry. The total stops at *1,334 gold* — still short. *Cero*, Nuberroca says of his own purse. He turns Eguzkilore over and tips out the elf's coin too. *If money's what brings him back — damn the cost, take it*.
2. The cleric calls the rite over the diamond. *Eguzkilore comes back barely conscious, unable to speak*. The party gathers in close. *At last, at last, brother* — Nuberroca, taking the elf in his arms. Sinsong follows up with a *healing* to lift him further from the edge.
3. The cleric warns Eguzkilore that he will move *slower than usual* for the next several days — his every effort dulled until the resurrection settles. The party walks the elf the short way back to the keep.
4. Inside, they share a quiet dinner together and, wrung out from the day, retire to their rooms — the night carries them.

Session 11

2025-04-27

1 - The path to Elturel

~10:00, 27 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The night's long rest at the keep runs late — the party is wrung out enough that they only rise mid-morning. Down in the common room of the keep the party finds it thick with the garrison and with villagers from the nearby settlements come in to help with the reconstruction, materials moving in and out at pace. They pick at the cold food left over from breakfast.
2. **Tarbaw Nighthill** greets them warmly — glad they are back and in better shape than the last time. He can't share their morning — the reconstruction has him stretched — but he reminds them that **Leosin** is expecting them at Elturel.
3. Tarbaw lays out the road. **Leosin** left them fresh horses and provisions prepaid at the stables — the Greenest mounts and Miguel's escort go back with Tarbaw, and at Nyx's suggestion a small cart is worked into the loadout for the heavier gear. The route runs northeast to the Trade Way, following the river through Berdusk and Scornubel, then west to Elturel — safer, though a small detour. The alternative, cross-country, cuts the distance but there are no patrols, and the horses will suffer.
   Amidamaru votes for the safer road — he is tired of monsters, and tired of fighting. Eguzkilore agrees, Nyx concurs, and Mialee falls in. Six days by road.
4. Amidamaru asks after a courier for a letter to *Westgate*, his home city. Tarbaw's guidance: no local messenger reaches that far — the letter is best carried by the party themselves as far as **Berdusk**, where east-bound merchants will pick it up.
5. Before leaving, Eguzkilore restocks arrows at the keep. Mialee buys twenty pieces of incense at a gold piece each — the ritual components she will need to summon a new familiar. Eguzkilore also exchanges his coin at the keep.

2 - Open countryside

~14:00, 27 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Once on the road the day passes quietly — no soul crossed all day, despite the good weather. To the south, grain-plains and vineyards; to the north, cattle-pastures dotted with small groves, where herds of cows and sheep graze.
2. On the ride, Sinsong pulls Amidamaru aside and starts telling him stories from his cave days — a rambling account of a colleague named Juan who fell into a hole and had to be pulled out by the leg. Amidamaru, only half-listening, works a small tinker-craft over his hood so it starts emitting a constant sound of sea-waves and wind, and leaves the trick running. The rest of the party, further along the line, can hear the sound of the sea over Sinsong's voice, gulls and all, even though the river is closer than the sea.
3. By dusk the party has covered a good stretch of country but the Chionthar is still far ahead — they pull off the road into the shelter of one of the small groves and make camp for the night: horses picketed at the tree-line, saddles pulled and stacked, a low fire kept small against the autumn chill, and watches shared out around it. Beside the fire Mialee performs the ritual to summon a new familiar — she calls up **Echo** the bat again, then folds it back into rest to travel with her come morning.

3 - The Chionthar ford

~09:00, 28 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. In the morning the party breaks camp and continues northeast, reaching the Chionthar at noon — a broad, slow river; they take the horses through the ford in file. The road picks up on the far bank and holds the same quiet countryside as before.
2. The crossing takes the rest of the afternoon, and by the time all six are on the far bank the light is already thinning. Rather than push on, they pitch camp shortly past the ford on open ground beside the Trade Way — broader and better graded than the Greenest track they'd come in on — no grove in reach. Horses picketed close, saddles for pillows, a smaller fire than the night before against a colder wind out of the north; watches shared in shorter turns and no one straying far from the light.

4 – Reaching Berdusk

~09:00, 29 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Dawn breaks over the camp; the party is back on the Trade Way by first light. Four hours of steady march, then an hour's rest at midday to eat and let the horses breathe. Five more hours in the saddle after — the last of them a forced march as the light thins, riders and mounts alike beginning to labour, to gain Berdusk before dusk.
2. Approaching the walls, Amidamaru shifts his shape — the tortle vanishes into the appearance of a heavy-built, muscled elf so that the party's shape does not catch the town's eye. Once inside, the crowd looks Nuberroca over, but between his size and the disguised tortle beside him, no one presses.
3. Amidamaru asks around the trade-quarter for a merchant heading east and settles on one whose feeling is right; the courier fee comes to five gold, and Amidamaru pays six to speed the letter on.
4. Sinsong asks after the wounded — anyone missing an arm or a leg from the recent raids. The town has plenty of maimed folk still living — but Sinsong has no means to restore lost limbs, and lets it lie.
5. The party takes the night at a tavern for two gold per head — dinner, the room, and next morning's breakfast included.

5 – Sinsong's confessions

~09:00?, 30 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. On the road again, Sinsong turns his stories on Nyx. He explains — in the language of *warlocks*, which he thinks apply to him now — the fate of his tribe: a black stone found by his master; whoever touched it began petrifying over the course of about fourteen days; the chief touched it, then most of the tribe, half of them ended in stone. Sinsong is the only one still whole, and searches for a cure — that is why he left the cave. Nyx presses on where the stone is now: *"You're not carrying it on you, are you?"*. Sinsong dodges the answer; Nyx spurs her horse and puts a little distance between them.
2. Amidamaru moves alongside Nuberroca and offers to touch the goliath's talisman and make it glow — he had promised as much. Nuberroca thanks him and asks whether the same trick could also serve on *another* object he wears: a tribal piece the size of a bracelet, worn at the base of the pelvis since his coming of age — the goblin-sized belt he keeps under his clothing. Amidamaru misreads Nuberroca's request for a small illumination and lays an *invisibility* on him instead.
3. Nuberroca, invisible, keeps riding — his horse plodding on with no rider on view. The rest of the party sees the horse of Nuberroca advancing alongside Amidamaru's with no one atop it, and cannot tell where the goliath has gone. Nyx guesses Nuberroca has fallen off.
4. Nyx, watching Sinsong's rambling from a distance, quietly pulls a bottle of vodka from her pack — *"por si quiero beber después de la conversación que he escuchado"*.
5. Eventually Nuberroca finds Amidamaru, taps his shoulder, and asks him to fix the spell that came out wrong — offering the bracelet itself into his hand to try again. Amidamaru reminds Nuberroca that the talisman is already glowing — he'd made that first. For the second piece — Sinsong will need to help; a ruby of fifty gold in dust would let him mend it properly. Nuberroca pockets the talisman inside his neckerchief and rides on.

6 - The light of Elturel

~19:00?, 30 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Forcing the horses again, the party pushes to reach Scornubel that same day rather than camp on the road again. As they close on the city and the sun starts to set in the west, a strange thing happens — the sun's usual red fade holds, but the light beyond it does not go out. Where twilight should have taken over, a white light lingers from the west, brighter than lamplight.
2. Inside the walls, Mialee stops the first townsman she finds and asks about the light. He picks them for southerners — they must be new here. It is *the light of Elturel*, he tells them; it protects the city and the whole region. He knows nothing more of how it works — he has never been to Elturel; the light has always been there. Sinsong presses: it has been shining twenty-five years and the man has never walked up to look at it — who set it there? The townsman only shrugs.
3. Scornubel itself is a walled town but not a serious fortification — a low stone wall, the river running straight through with no grille to stop the passage of boats, arches only. The main street cuts north from the southern entry across the river; the road west toward Elturel that the party will take next is a poorer, less-travelled trade route by comparison.

7 - Scornubel

1. The party takes rooms at a tavern for the night — Amidamaru pays half the going rate to share the room with Sinsong. Amidamaru re-casts his *disguise* before going down to gather information; Sinsong lays a *silver-tongue* blessing on him, quickening his tongue for the questions to come.
2. Amidamaru works the merchants for word of dragons across the region. Most talk of the raids near Greenfields — the same beat that came through Greenest. But one man's account carries weight: a village to the north was hit alongside the bandits by a red dragon. Nyx notes what the party already knows — the dragon they met was blue. Amidamaru returns to the tavern chilled by the two colours.
3. Mialee, meanwhile, questions merchants about a large caravan with carts drawn by giant lizards or draconids. None have crossed one — they know the giant lizards are used by lizardfolk in the northern marshes, but no honest trader has ever seen them working the Trade Way. *Not around here, that's for sure*.
4. Sinsong, back at the tavern, presses Eguzkilore for detail on the family arms he searches for — a dagger, a sword, and a bow, lost across generations. Eguzkilore has never seen them and has no lead — *he knows they exist*.
5. Sinsong fashions small trinkets — painted stones with a single eye on each, tokens of friendship for the party. He offers one to Nyx and one to Nuberroca and starts crafting more for the others. Nyx accepts hers, mildly amused.
6. As they turn in for the night the party discusses their sleeping arrangements — light armour off, heavy armour off, Amidamaru locked in his shell with a chair braced against the door, Eguzkilore keeping his mail and only four hours of trance.

8 – Four figures

~11:30, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party leaves Scornubel late in the morning and rides out onto a poorer, less-travelled road that runs through an old, dry valley, mountains rising on one side, the river paralleling on the other. The Light of Elturel stays with them from the west — a small sun above the city — and with the morning sun in the east, the party cast no shadows.
2. Amidamaru and Mialee send their familiars up to scout the road ahead — **Munin** the owl on the wing above, **Echo** the bat flitting between the rocks — the party rides on behind them.
3. About fifty or sixty feet ahead, four figures stand across the road, one larger than the others. Nyx asks if she can spot anyone hidden further on; too far to tell from where they sit. The river cuts them off to the left; the valley walls to the right could be climbed but not by horse without risk.
4. Nuberroca dismisses the pause — worse than four men have failed to stop them; on they ride. *"¿Quién dijo miedo?"*. He advances alone on horseback, then dismounts and takes up the pike and shield.

9 – The ambush turned

~17:30, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The leader — an older man, calm, moving with the ease of someone who has done this many times — hails them and offers the party his group's protection in exchange for a modest fee, warning of the road's monsters and stray bandits. Nuberroca answers in the language he understands: *"Perfecto, ¿dónde hay bandidos? Tengo nuevas armas que quiero probar"*. He steps another pace closer.
2. From behind, Amidamaru shapes a small illusion that places a whispered voice at Nuberroca's ear — *enemies on the left*. Nuberroca glances left, then turns back to the older man: *"Insecto, si no quieres perder tu vida ni la de los que tienes escondidos alrededor, déjanos pasar y pasaremos esta afrenta de largo. Es tu última oportunidad"*. He squares up, ready to loose the blood-fury the moment steel comes out.
3. The old man's face changes — not fear, only a small note of resignation: *if not the easy way, then the hard one*. In one fluid, practised motion he draws his crossbow and steps backward; the three companions with him ready weapons of their own and the fight is on.
4. The first bolt sails wide of Nuberroca; the shooter fumbles his crossbow to the ground with the recoil. Nyx, holding her shot for the leader, releases in the same breath — the arrow threads clean into him where he stands.
5. Nuberroca, furious, answers with the pike, splitting the bandit nearest him and lifting the body clean off the polearm's tip; the follow-up haft-strike cracks the second bandit down to reeling.
6. Mialee's arrow slips out of her hand as she draws with nerves; she picks it up, moves, and casts a bank of white fog across the middle of the field, heavily obscuring the ledges' line of fire. The bandits shift to cover — one bolt lands wide between Eguzkilore and Sinsong, and another finds Amidamaru with savage force.
7. Sinsong, riding into the middle, calls a blessing over Nuberroca, Amidamaru and Eguzkilore and then — for one still moment — asks the leader across the battle to stop: *"please, we can end this slaughter. No one has to suffer"*. Amidamaru remarks aloud, half in wonder, that this is the first time Sinsong has not opened combat with an attack.
8. Amidamaru, dismounting against the valley wall, calls up a *shadow blade* — he grips the hilt at his belt and a black-edged blade seems to grow from it — and lands a first cut on the captain.
9. Eguzkilore catches his breath, takes a first shot at the leader, then looses a second in the same instant — the two arrows together open the man deep, more damage in that one turn than anyone else has landed on him.
10. Sinsong folds an *emboldening bond* across the party, then picks one of the two bandits crouched atop the cliff and threads a *fire bolt* up at him — the strike catches and the man falls from the ledge.

10 - The last runner

1. With the leader bleeding out on the ground, Nuberroca closes on him and pins him under his weight — the captain cannot break free and is bound where he lies. Amidamaru finishes it: pommel-strikes from the *shadow blade*'s hilt to the nape and the captain slumps unconscious. Between the arrows Eguzkilore left in him and the beating, he is a hair from death.
2. One bandit is still standing on the ledge above the road; he turns and runs, scrambling up the rocks toward the ridge line. Sinsong rides up beneath him and casts a spell of slumber onto the climbing man — the spell takes, and the bandit crashes down the rocks, badly battered by the fall.
3. Sinsong calls after the sleeping man — *wait, we can still be friends*. Nuberroca will have none of it and urges Nyx to shoot.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx lowers her bow: *"no le voy a disparar. Se va a contar la historia de cómo hemos aniquilado a una banda de bandidos"*. She stays her hand, and turns instead to recovering the arrows she'd fired.
5. Nuberroca draws his crossbow and shoots the man cleanly. *"Cuando entras en la batalla, no puedes huir como un cobarde"*.
6. Amidamaru searches the captain for cult iconography or a talisman — nothing along those lines, but he does find a small stash of precious stones. He passes them to Nuberroca for his collection; Nuberroca thanks him warmly — *"Muchas gracias, hombre-tortuga"*.
7. Sinsong asks Nuberroca to borrow the small whistle Nyx had given him; Nuberroca agrees but complains his wounds hurt, and Amidamaru quietly casts a healing touch on him from behind. Sinsong claims the credit, but the goliath doesn't buy it and turns to thank Amidamaru.

11 - Taifoz's story

~18:00, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party ropes the captain into the cart and rides on; an hour of the road passes before he stirs. When he finally tries to move against the ropes, his wounds pull sharp and he goes still with a low pained sound. He speaks — *up until a few hours ago he worked for himself; he is unemployed now. If they need a guard, or a guide, he is good at both*.
2. He calls the whole encounter a terrible misunderstanding — his party had been offering their trade in escort along the caravan road, and Nuberroca had come in charging with a spear. Nuberroca answers — *they are bandits, and they had tried to rob the party of their goods*. Nyx cuts in: *"te empezamos a entender mal cuando sacaste la ballesta y nos apuntaste"*.
3. The man offers, without shame, to serve them — twenty gold, then eighteen — as guide and guard as far north as Waterdeep. Nyx sees him for what he is; Mialee wants him delivered to Elturel's authorities; Sinsong finds him convincing; Nuberroca wants a duel once he has healed. Amidamaru and Nyx both read him closely — he is *convinced of what he is saying*, which is not the same thing as telling the truth.
4. He gives his name — **Taifoz** — and names three sons, two at Elturel, one at Baldur's Gate. On the light of Elturel he speaks with confidence: an ancestral device the town's rulers set in the sky to keep the hordes of the dead away from the region. He mentions **Ontharr Frume** of the Order of the Gauntlet as *a great friend of his*. The party recognises the name from Leosin's briefing.
5. The party settles: they will take him to the gates of Elturel and let the guards handle him — Mialee rides in the cart with him, ready to move if he tries anything; Nyx trails behind with her eyes fixed on him; Sinsong rides alongside to keep him talking.

12 - Push to Elturel

~19:00, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Rather than camping on the road, the party decides to force the pace to make Elturel that same night — an extra three hours of hard riding beyond the day's march.
2. The ride wears them down — horses labour, riders go sore, the party hollows out hour by hour; only Eguzkilore's soldier's discipline keeps him steady. When four of the six horses are spent, Nuberroca and Nyx give up their mounts to Sinsong and Mialee; Nuberroca takes over the exhausted horse to lead, and Nyx dismounts to walk.
3. In the changeover Mialee misjudges her fresh mount, slips out of the saddle and thumps to the ground — the fall knocks the wind and the last of her strength out at once, to a laughing groan from the party. She crawls into the cart and sleeps the rest of the ride.
4. Sinsong, spent and out of patience with Taifoz's constant pitching for release, takes a swing at his head to shut him up — *and misses, exhausted as he is*. As the walls of Elturel come clear ahead, Taifoz tries one more pitch from the cart-bed: *you should seriously consider letting me go*.

13 - The escape

~22:00, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. About two or three hundred metres from the gate, the walls of Elturel visible ahead and the guards atop them, Nyx, Nuberroca and Eguzkilore scan the surrounding — no one sees anything odd.
2. Then, in one motion, **Taifoz is up from the cart** — Mialee's scimitar in his hand: *you should have hired me*. He slashes at Nuberroca as he leaps free and turns to run for the woods.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca kicks his horse into a gallop and runs the escaping man down before he can clear the road. He drops off the horse on top of Taifoz in a wrestling tackle, wrapping him under his weight. He holds back the killing blow this time — the goliath knocks Taifoz unconscious with the impact and the fists that follow.
4. The guards on the wall watched it all and had crossbows ready — but they let it play out, seeing the direction of it. Nuberroca hoists the unconscious captain across his back and calls up to the gatehouse: *"Perdonad, buenos señores — traemos un bandido y hemos tenido un pequeño incidente"*.

14 - The Black Antler

1. One of the wall-guards comes down to meet them; when he sees Taifoz's face, he starts to laugh, calls his companion over — *look who's here* — and asks whether they have come to collect the bounty. He counts out **fifty gold pieces** into the party's cart and takes the body away. Taifoz had been raiding the region for months, always slipping the patrols — by morning his head will likely be on the gate.
2. Nuberroca tells the tale of the ambush to the guard, spinning it a touch in the party's favour; the guard takes it happily — *always good to have warriors who put an end to bandits*.
3. The guard points them to a tavern for the night — the **A Pair of Black Antlers**, a stag's head with both antlers painted black hung above the door, on the main street from the gate.
4. He tells them the place is the favoured hangout of the **Order of the Gauntlet** — a military order that supports the city guard, better-equipped than most because they have money behind them; noisy people, fond of tournaments of strength and skill, but good guys. Their local leader is **Ontharr Frume**, a paladin the guard names as one of the best warriors alive.
5. Amidamaru asks about other outstanding bounties on the road. The guard: no, most bandit trouble is on the main Trade Way and belongs to the trails further out; most travellers arrive by boat down the Chionthar because it is much faster and safer than the road.
6. Wrung out to the last — legs heavy in the stirrups, hands slack on the reins, more than one of them half-asleep in the saddle — the party turns at last toward the Antler for the night.

Session 12

2025-05-25

1 - Under the second sun

~22:30, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. It is late in the autumn evening when the party rides up to the walls of Elturel. Full night should be on them, but the Light of Elturel hangs over the city like a small sun of its own — Nyx notes it sits directly above them, catching them from overhead the way the true sun would at noon, and the party remarks that it must be miserable to actually live under a light that never dims.
2. Inside the walls Elturel shows itself as civilised in a way the party has not seen for weeks — wide, well-guarded, clean streets kept lit by the constant sun overhead. The river Chionthar runs straight through the city, busy in both directions — barges downstream with the current, mule-teams towing barges back upstream along tow-paths on either bank.
3. Amidamaru and Nuberroca ride in still fresh, Nyx and Eguzkilore a shade footsore. They make straight for the tavern the Elturel gate-guard had named — **A Pair of Black Antlers** — with no complication reaching it.

2 - The paladin of Torm

1. At the back of the common room the party spots **Leosin** at once — laughing and talking with a big, plate-armoured human whose breastplate carries the golden hand of **Torm**, and one gauntlet of his armour painted blue as a personal token of his faith. Around them a knot of other armoured folk are arm-wrestling, throwing an odd gauntlet-wrestling match, generally cutting loose.
2. Nyx orders a cup of wine, Nuberroca a full gallon of beer, Eguzkilore his own jar, Amidamaru waves off drink for now. The tavern's two-gold rate covers a room, dinner and next morning's breakfast — a shared board of bread, cheese and small plates is a silver a head on the side, and Nyx pays for it.
3. Nyx walks up to Leosin's table with the ease of a lifelong friend and drops into a seat. **Ontharr Frume** — the plate-armoured man — sizes her up but lets her stay; then Leosin calls them *"the heroes of Greenest,"* granting that thanks to them he made it out of the cultists' hands alive, though he adds a wry qualifier that they hadn't done all that much for the escape itself.
4. Their briefers ask whether they gathered any intelligence at the cultists' lair. Nyx spreads Mondath's papers on the table — the map of the Greenfields region, the notes ordering everything the raiders steal to be carried north to **Naerytar**, **Rezmir's** allowance of some of the pearls, and a sheaf of dragon-poems the two men wave off as uninteresting.
5. Ontharr and Leosin trace the route on the map with the party — from Greenfields the cult marches west, then north up the Trade Way through Baldur's Gate and on toward a place they call *Naerytar*, which no one recognises. Between them the party sizes the cult's lead at about six days; Ontharr reckons the cultists on foot are about a week from Baldur's Gate at that pace.
6. Ontharr adds a grim wrinkle — the order's scouts have been watching the whole Sword Coast and see no sign of them, no army-movement, nothing hostile, *"as if they had vanished."* The party suggests the cult may be moving as many small parties rather than one column; Ontharr agrees that fits the silence.
7. Ontharr sees the party is running on nothing, notes Sinsong and Mialee already nodding into the table, and offers to save the substance of it for the morning — first hour after sun-up, in the tavern's private room. Meanwhile, if any of them want a game, his companions will oblige.

3 – Ontharr's duel

1. Nuberroca walks up to Ontharr, looks him over, and tells him he looks strong. Ontharr reads it right — is this a challenge? Nuberroca, with a small shrug, allows that if Ontharr will have it he came only to say so, but *"nos podemos pegar unas hostias si quieres"*. Ontharr's people take him at his word and the whole common room opens a ring around them.
2. Nyx clambers onto a table to open the pool — two gold on the goliath. One of the civilians edges forward to take her bet against his boss; Nuberroca stops the pool with a soldier's line — this isn't right, this is just a warmup between warriors.
3. Ontharr strips down slowly — his plates take a helper to unlace — then a padded gambeson comes off to reveal a builder's mass of muscle. Without armour or weapons he sets himself and waves Nuberroca in. With Nuberroca's kill-joy line still in the air, Nyx starts to pocket the money — until Leosin arrives at her elbow and lays five gold on Ontharr; Nyx takes the bet, five gold on Nuberroca. Nuberroca starts his pec-flexing routine for the crowd.
4. Reading the pec-flexing as readiness, Ontharr opens first — and catches only air, as Nuberroca ducks low to remove his pants. Ontharr calls him off at once: pants stay on, as he has kept his own.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca comes back all-in, no guard, and his first punch lands so hard Ontharr coughs up a smear of blood — the room reads it: the paladin is stronger but slow, and the goliath has more than a puncher's chance. Two rounds later Nuberroca sees Ontharr fighting confident and open, hits him again with the same full commitment; the paladin's answering swing goes past him miserably, badly out of practice fighting without steel around him. The room erupts and starts clapping the goliath; Leosin hands Nyx her five gold, well-earned.
6. Ontharr accepts the loss cleanly. He gathers Nuberroca into a wide grin and allows that if all the goliath's companions are half as good, tearing down the cult of the dragon will be a walk in the park, then starts strapping his plates back on with a wry note that he is out of practice fighting bare. Nuberroca puts out a hand, calls him a knight of honour, and slides the barrel of beer over for him to share; Nyx offers him her wine too.

4 – Rooms and rest

1. Before turning in, Amidamaru asks the tavern-keeper about couriers to **Westgate** and hands over a sealed letter. Two gold buys it first-caravan carriage east in the morning — around forty to fifty days on the road.
2. The party takes six individual rooms at two gold apiece — no need to share this time. Amidamaru asks for breakfast brought to his door for five copper; Nyx laughs and undercuts the tavern-keeper by a piece, offering to bring it up herself for four. Amidamaru pays the tavern-keeper anyway.
3. Amidamaru announces his plan for the night's off-hours before heading up — some tinkering with his equipment — refining the small enchanted focuses he uses to shape spells. Nyx, deadpan, observes that the whole thing sounds suspiciously like a euphemism.

5 – Late to the meeting

~08:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Morning arrives with a knock — eight in the morning. Amidamaru asks for the tray to be left at the door, opens a crack, hooks it in, and shuts himself back up. The night's rest bleeds the worst of the exhaustion off the party.
2. Amidamaru stays upstairs. Nuberroca, Nyx, and Eguzkilore drag themselves down to the common room — and find Ontharr openly angry. They are nearly two hours late; the sun came up at half past six and they were supposed to meet in the private room then. Nuberroca apologises with a grin: they came in dead-tired, and the beating Ontharr gave him didn't help him rise. Ontharr breaks into a smile.
3. Eguzkilore heads back up to knock on Amidamaru's door — for the turtle... well, for the elf — he corrects himself mid-word, mindful the disguise is on. Amidamaru pulls himself together in ten minutes and comes down. Mialee and Sinsong are left to sleep.
4. The private room is small — a table, four chairs, no windows, some of the order's storage stacked against the walls, and one of the Gauntlet on guard at the door. Nyx settles on the floor rather than press one of the standing party to the wall.

6 - Several dragons

1. Ontharr opens flat: the situation is complicated — the cult of the dragon is organising something large and they don't yet know what. What the party's own intelligence has confirmed is that they are hoarding treasure and moving it. The order has agents trying to trace the destination and no answer yet.
2. From the papers the party brought they now know the caravan is bound for Baldur's Gate along the trade route — that is the point to intercept and infiltrate, and the order is counting on the party to be the ones who do it.
3. Ontharr names the wider alliance for them: he speaks for the **Order of the Gauntlet**, Leosin for the **Harpers**; also with them are the **Lords' Alliance** and the **Emerald Enclave**, all working to break the cult.
4. Ontharr closes the pitch on why the party is needed — the future of the civilised world hangs on understanding what *the dragon* is doing. Amidamaru raises a hand tentatively — Ontharr said *the* dragon, singular, but there is more than one. Yes, Ontharr answers — many.
5. Amidamaru presses on with his voice starting to tremble — *how many, and what does the order know of them?*. Ontharr answers first with the name: the cult calls itself for THE dragon — **Tiamat**, goddess of chromatic dragons. *And that is bad*, Amidamaru offers back; yes, quite bad, Ontharr answers. Cells of the cult have historically turned dragons into dracoliches, one at a time — never before now a coordinated operation at this scale.
6. Amidamaru asks the count. At least five confirmed, Ontharr answers: the blue the party saw at Greenest; a red that has worked with it in the north, plus either that same red also striking other cities, or two more reds beyond it; and a white.
7. Nuberroca asks whether such creatures can be beaten. Individually, Ontharr allows, even without joining forces it should not be too hard; the problem is not the single dragon — it is *why they are gathering together at all*. That has no precedent Ontharr knows.
8. Asked for their help, the party assents — Nuberroca first, plainly. Eguzkilore nods behind him. Amidamaru rounds it out: *within our means, and trying to fight as little as possible, infiltration sounds a good plan*.
9. Nuberroca sets the table with a second thread of his own — far to the north his tribe is holding back a slow tide of undead they cannot trace, and his elders sent him south for allies. Ontharr cannot spare force now, but he vows the order will help once the cult is put down. Leosin, more concretely, offers to put a few Harpers agents on the trail and to try to trace the source. Ontharr adds his own guess — if Nuberroca's home is near the border with **Thay**, the **Red Wizards** are stirring again, and undead would fit their pattern.

7 - Factions and gear

1. Amidamaru brings the meeting back to logistics — the party needs healing potions and coin, and asks Leosin for any work in town in the meantime. Leosin waves it off: time is not on their side. The order will get them a boat downriver — four or five days with the current, no fee. They keep the horses to Baldur's Gate, then hand them to the Harpers waiting there — mounts can't cross the city. The order can spare twenty gold and a healing potion each — no more.
2. Leosin turns the offer over — would either of them care to join? Nyx asks for more first. The Harpers work to end tyranny and keep no single group too powerful; they were nearly wiped out once for being too open, and now work in secret, cell-by-cell, gathering intelligence for the general good.
3. Ontharr makes a buzz-kill wave behind Leosin's back — cowards, he calls them; the Gauntlet does the same work but marches out openly and puts the enemy down. Sign with the Gauntlet and they'll have equipment, backing, and quarters.
4. Nuberroca answers Ontharr on the spot. Nyx, more careful, asks whether joining is for life; there's a probationary period as a rule, though given the circumstances they'd waive it. Leosin, plainly, has been eyeing Nyx; Ontharr, Nuberroca.
5. Ontharr takes Nuberroca first. The goliath boasts of noble blood — a descendant of the titans — and tosses a gold piece to the table for effect: they may prize the metal, but where he comes from this is worth nothing. Ontharr asks his rank and steers toward the order's principles: what he wants of Nuberroca back north is that he be a bulwark of them — *"el orden, la ley y el bien, defender a los inocentes y perseguir a los culpables"*. Nuberroca says his people already do that. Then it is done — he signs to the Gauntlet.
6. Nyx works Leosin quietly: she has a family to return to eventually. No problem — the Harpers work in independent cells, called in only when needed. She signs. Leosin gives her a Harpers pendant — a leather cord with a harp pierced by a sword, matching his own.
7. Ontharr equips Nuberroca at once — scale mail with the sigil of Torm on the breast (a step up from bare, at the cost of moving less quietly), a shield with the order's mark, and a halberd. No helmet on offer.
8. Amidamaru asks after some order that traffics in gems and diamonds — pearls and diamonds specifically, to be of more use to the party. The nearest fit is the Lords' Alliance, but the alliance takes nobles or a city's representative; the party's claim as *saviours of Greenest* falls short because Greenest is a village, not a city. Amidamaru shrugs it off.

8 - The last errands

1. The party sits to the porridge left out for them from the morning — cold enough by now to have set like a cast. The tavern-keeper offers to warm it; Nuberroca waves him off — cold is fine, let's eat — and a jug of beer helps it down.
2. Before they leave, Amidamaru circles back to the tavern-keeper to ask after his first letter — sent that morning with the eastbound caravan, he's told. He hands over a second sealed letter for the same destination; the tavern-keeper warns this one will take longer to get through.
3. When asked about a jeweller, the tavern-keeper points them toward the merchants' quarter down by the river — the shop is close. Amidamaru heads out; Nyx asks the tavern-keeper's leave to bring her breakfast plate along, promising to return it, then follows; Nuberroca shovels his own porridge down whole and comes along; Eguzkilore falls in.

9 - Merchants' quarter

~09:30, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party walks along the Chionthar to the merchants' quarter — a busy river-port with warehouses, dockhands, and heavy guards. The first thing to catch the eye is the crowd of ragged street-children working the crowd for pockets.
2. Nuberroca pockets his gold and slings the pouch on a cord around his neck like a pendant. Amidamaru ensures that anything worth stealing on him is inside his shell. Nyx just rests a hand on her pouch.
3. Within minutes Amidamaru is brushed by a small child — the child breaks off and runs, and Nyx spots the attempt. Amidamaru pats himself down; nothing missing. Nyx guesses the shell rebuffed the child — and adds that the child now knows there is something strange about him.
4. Nuberroca warns the party he'll slap away anything that gets within reach.
5. Soon after, the same child steps back out of a side-alley and points Amidamaru out to six men following him — armed, though the weapons are poorly hidden under long coats. As the men close, the street-crowd around them peels back without needing to be told.
6. Nuberroca does not want to be surrounded in a crowd; he tells the party to get into the shop — *"vámonos, o me pongo violento"*. Amidamaru plays it flat and walks on to the jeweller's door.

10 - The gnome's shop

1. Inside the shop Amidamaru shifts his shape again — the elf gives way to a semi-orc. The jeweller — a gnome — goes pale, unsettled by the magic in his own shop and beginning to press something under the counter with one hand.
2. Amidamaru tells the jeweller that bandits outside mean to rob them all, then drops fifty gold on the counter and asks for a diamond, urgently. Nuberroca arrives a beat later, half-inside and half-planted in the doorframe as a wall so the bandits cannot follow him in, and repeats the word — urgently!. The jeweller doesn't move on it, and Amidamaru quietly pockets the fifty gold again.
3. The jeweller's answer is flat — he doesn't like his clients changing appearance, it raises suspicions, and suspicions aren't good for business. Nyx presses him — they are being followed, they wanted the change so as to lose them; he answers that the party's trouble is theirs to keep out of his shop. Nuberroca sharpens the pressure — he'll have that trouble either way if he refuses to help. Nyx asks after the city guard; on the way, the jeweller replies. He then reads the whole exchange as a threat.
4. The jeweller pulls a lever. In the blink of an eye, iron plates come down from the ceiling and slam the shop shut — the counter is cut off, the displays are cut off, only the outer door still stands. Then mechanical sounds start above their heads — something is moving in the ceiling; Nuberroca smells a trap. Amidamaru glances up: from each corner, tubes are lowering, widening at their ends, and after a beat's swing they pivot as if to aim.
5. Amidamaru shouts to run and the party bolts back out through the door, closing it behind them as something *whooshes* against it from the inside and the door starts running warm.

11 - The street fight

1. The bandits are waiting where the party left them, and the leader looks them over, asking where the elf is. Amidamaru answers first: he stayed inside, the fire got him. Nyx echoes the story. The leader is not buying — the cover falls flat.
2. The leader closes on the party and reads them one by one — he's seen Nuberroca before, he's seen the halfling before too, and Nyx eases back to keep the distance; but the semi-orc who wasn't with them coming in is the one he wants to talk to, alone.
3. Amidamaru takes the singling-out as his cue — he calmly sneaks out of the leader's field; the moment he's clear he slips a spell of *invisibility* onto himself.
4. Rage takes Nuberroca and he closes the gap in a single stride, lunging for the grapple, demanding *"¿a quién coño te estás acercando tú?"*. The leader slips clean out of it and warns him back — *"las manitas quietas"* — it's not in the party's interest to get involved with them.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca doesn't stand down — he drives the halberd in once, a punishing cut, and the killer's touch in him sinks it deeper still. Nuberroca stays swinging in the same motion — the polearm's butt-end comes over onto the adjacent bandit, cracking his head and leaving him dead on the stones.
6. The two bandits furthest back break — they turn on their heels and vanish into the crowd; the wounded leader flees alongside them. The remaining two draw and charge Nuberroca.
7. Nuberroca meets the nearest with a swing as he comes into reach; the bandit's answering strike catches him too, but a moment later a blue glow rises over the cut and the flesh knits back closed.
8. Nyx strikes with the pommel of her weapon and drops the bandit facing her unconscious. Eguzkilore swings his own scimitar and fumbles it. Amidamaru, still invisible, uses the moment to slip further away, walking with as much stealth as he can manage.
9. The last bandit still on his feet sees his fellow put down alive rather than killed, throws his weapons to the ground, and flattens himself onto the stones.
10. Nuberroca wants the wounded leader — badly hurt and bleeding hard from the halberd cut — and tears off down the crowded street to run him down, banking on the visible blood-trail. The crowd swallows the man before Nuberroca can pick him up; he comes back empty-handed.
11. Nyx and Nuberroca question the bandit on his knees: what did he want with the elf? He doesn't know — Arthax told them to interrogate the elf and they came. Nuberroca grapples him and ropes his arms to march him off with them.

12 - The guards arrive

1. Barely ten seconds pass between the fight ending and the whistles — the crowd has already circled up around the dead man in the street, and the party has been seen.
2. Eguzkilore refuses to run this time; he wants to explain. He sheathes his weapons and waits. Nyx follows him: sword back into scabbard, hands up in plain sight.
3. The guards arrive at pace. They fix on Nuberroca first — he is the tallest man there, the crowd is pointing him out, and the armour with the sigil of Torm is easily recognisable. They ask what happened.
4. Nyx and Eguzkilore speak first — the party was attacked, they defended themselves; but the guards answer that the crowd is telling them the party attacked without provocation. Nuberroca ropes the tied bandit closer and prompts him to repeat what he'd told them on their walk over — that Arthax had sent his group after the elf.
5. Instead the tied man, terrified, rewrites the story to save his own skin: they were minding their business trying to walk on with the elf; the giant animal turned on his companion for no reason, killed one of them who never even had his weapons out — and the guards search the dead man and confirm his dagger and scimitar are still sheathed.
6. Nuberroca cracks the bandit at his side with an intimidation, and the confession comes out through the fear: Arthax had told them to kidnap the elf, they couldn't find him, and then a semi-orc appeared who wasn't there before — some magic mixed up in it. Amidamaru, still invisible, drops the spell and steps in from behind, calling to the guards that the bandits wanted to rob him, he had to hide, and asking what's going on. The bandit stares at him — that, that's the elf.
7. The guard-sergeant gives the party a chance to sway the crowd — they all try in turn; nothing lands. The crowd testifies against them — the bandits were bad people, everyone knows, but they weren't hurting anyone now, and the party had attacked them cold.
8. Nuberroca protests — the man just confessed a kidnap plan. Attempted kidnap, the guard answers, is not the same crime as kidnap; the party is not walking away from a dead man in the street this easily. Nuberroca, Nyx, and Eguzkilore are led off in custody — a fast hearing rather than a full trial. Amidamaru is not taken. Mialee and Sinsong sleep through the whole thing at the tavern.

Session 13

2025-06-01

1 - The diamond, at last

~10:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Amidamaru comes back to the gnome's jeweller's shop wearing a fresh elf face — a different one from the last encounter. The shop is spotless: no scorch marks, no sign that anything trapped or fired at all — the gnome tells him someone tried to rob him earlier and things had gotten worrying, but he heard noise while he was locked up and doesn't know what happened.
2. Amidamaru asks for a fifty-gold diamond, specifically for a spell. The gnome checks his stock — his price ledger wasn't laid out for every value, but a fifty-gold diamond can be produced.
3. Amidamaru pockets the diamond and heads back to the tavern.

2 - In the cells

~10:30, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Nuberroca, Nyx and Eguzkilore are held in adjacent, poorly-lit cells; their weapons and armour have been taken and only their clothes are left on them. In one nearby cell the tied-up bandit from the street fight lies silent — unconscious, asleep or simply mute, they can't tell. From another cell, someone else is present without speaking, only making small sounds.
2. Nuberroca calls across to Nyx to check on her, then asks whether they should be here at all, offering to leave. Nyx pushes back — this is his first city and cities have rules; you can't roam killing people on the street. Nuberroca insists he *has* adapted: bandits came with knives and weapons, so he adapted; the sergeant who took their weapons was not killed, was he? Nyx concedes he has restraint, and thanks him for not killing the guard.
3. Nuberroca says he's beginning to grow impatient; he doesn't like being shut in without a way out.
4. Nuberroca goes back to first principles for Nyx: his tribe's mandate is to help the weak and stamp out evil, and there was evil in this city — he cannot simply ignore it because the party would prefer he did. Nyx concedes the mandate but reframes it — evil can also be cleared from a place by pulling it off the streets and locking it up, not only by killing it. Yes, Nuberroca allows, with a rifle-butt to the head; Nyx sighs and asks him for a softer one next time.
5. From the cell opposite, a cracked old voice half-laughs at the two of them talking about clearing evil from the streets. Nuberroca calls across — who dares laugh?. The old man answers that *he* is here for denouncing exactly that — that the evil was never eradicated from the city, and the man who thinks he knows evil doesn't know what evil is in *this* city. Elturel, he says, was plagued and ruled by vampires until the second sun appeared — the gift of **Amaunator**, the sun-god, to be rid of them. He has been in this cell for years for saying that aloud.
6. Nyx pushes for detail: how long ago? Forty-seven years since **the Companion** appeared, five since he was jailed. Nuberroca asks who put him here — the Order of the Companion, together with the Order of the Hellriders, who have run the city since a few years after the Companion arose. The old man's charge is *religious heresy*: it is illegal to attribute the Companion — the light of Elturel — to any specific god, and he has been saying aloud that it was **Amaunator** who made it.
7. A guard appears at the bars, raps the metal for silence, tells them to keep the noise down, and walks off. The old voice fades to a quiet mutter; Nuberroca gives up on him and starts pacing.
8. Nyx checks on the bandit next door; Nuberroca reminds her it's the one who was still conscious and had confessed the kidnap plan on the walk over — the other, more badly wounded one, has since died of his wounds. The confessed bandit responds barely — *yes* — that the dead man was his friend; when Nyx offers condolence with a note about her friend being pressed to fight, he answers he owes them nothing. Nuberroca growls across at him — calling him a vile rat, he can start earning their way out of here — and the bandit refuses.
9. Hours later Nyx tells Nuberroca to be patient — they'll be judged or told what's happening, and no one is going to leave them here forever.

3 – The tavern reunion

~12:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Around midday Amidamaru walks into the common room of *A Pair of Black Antlers* wearing the elf face and greets Mialee and Sinsong as if nothing were different. Neither recognises him at first: Mialee reaches out with a small casting of her own and reads illusion-school magic layered over him.
2. Mialee runs the check she trusts most: reaches around behind him — under the elf outline — and taps shell. Amidamaru drops the disguise-check act; the party accepts he is Amidamaru.
3. Amidamaru delivers the news: Nuberroca lost his temper in the market, killed one bandit and knocked another unconscious, and the guards took him and the others away. Sinsong groans that he can't even get three days' rest — he can't sit through a cup of milk without it turning into another mess.
4. Amidamaru waves Sinsong off — let the grown-ups talk — and turns to Mialee: they will need her to get the others out.
5. Mialee corners Amidamaru with the practical question: where were the others taken? Amidamaru says he doesn't know, because he kept his distance so he could get back and tell them.

4 – Ontharr intercedes

~13:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The three cross to **Ontharr** at the back of the tavern. He is already unhappy that they are still in Elturel and hears the news with visible irritation — the party's own comrade has killed a man in the market. He tells them plainly that killing here is not looked on well; multiple killings warrant execution, and single ones are answered with fines, jails and exile. He walks off at once to speak with the tavern-keeper — every word audible across the room, no attempt to whisper — to arrange another river-barge out of the city for the following midday, because time is the party's real enemy.
2. Amidamaru slips to the privy first, refreshes the elf disguise so he stays the same face people saw on the street, and rejoins the others; he can stand witness for the hour the spell lasts. Ontharr has already told them the prisoners will be at the fortress of the Order of the Companion — that's where the city holds criminals.
3. Twenty minutes later they walk to a heavily fortified compound. Its banner carries a circle with a smaller sun-and-rays at the upper-left — the same emblem worn by the city watch and by a good number of knights across the streets, in two different sets of livery: two orders sharing one sigil.
4. At the gate Ontharr kneels to the door-guards in a gesture of respect and asks — in a level, almost honeyed voice — for audience over a killing committed that morning. The guards' faces are enough of an answer: they know exactly which killing he means, they discuss it briefly among themselves, and one steps inside.
5. Four or five minutes later a large armoured captain in the same two-suns emblem on his breastplate comes out and introduces himself as **Recaredo**. He recognises Ontharr from an earlier occasion and greets him with a small barb — *the murderer is one of yours, isn't he — I thought your order had better standards*. Ontharr only nods and hands the meeting over to the party. Sinsong takes the moment to sweep the captain for aberrations, celestials, elementals, fey, fiends and undead — nothing of those shows; the only magical thing he catches is Amidamaru's own illusion, which he already knew.
6. Amidamaru speaks first and at length. He tells the captain there were nearly ten bandits circling a small group of shoppers; they showed weapons on their belts and pressed in aggressively. Nuberroca, unused to a city's manners, reacted from fear — one bandit died, the second was captured — and no one was killed for killing's sake. When the captain replies that the witnesses have described the party striking first, Amidamaru pivots to a *psychological attack* — that fear of visible weapons and being circled by eight men is the true first blow. He closes with an appeal to necessity: the party is heading west to hunt dragons and needs Nuberroca back for that fight — take his return to the road as the goliath's penance.
7. The captain looks over at Ontharr, who gives a small honest nod that the story is true. He says he understands, turns without another word, and goes back inside.

5 - Recaredo's lesson

1. Deep in the cell block the same captain who had come out to Ontharr descends with a torch and two guards. The torchlight catches the old man's face — a small, thin, obviously old man — and he shrinks back into a corner and curls up on the ground.
2. Recaredo steps up to Nuberroca's cell: your companions have come to intercede, you're being released shortly. Before that, he says, a lesson.
3. Nyx shakes the bars and shouts, *what are you doing?*, uselessly. The three of them — Recaredo and the two guards — set on Nuberroca all at once with bare fists and pommels. There is no metal in the beating; the blows do not draw blood; they simply do not stop.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Recaredo draws his own greatsword last and lands a blow on Nuberroca, the goliath goes down, but remains with a thread of life. The knights hand him to his feet, and give him a pair of slaps for good measure. The captain's line as he pulls Nuberroca upright is that there are ways to bring an enemy down without killing him — learn non-lethal damage.
5. He then opens Nyx's cell and Eguzkilore's; on the bandits, he says, they will stand judgement, but the penalty for theft is not death — stealing does not justify killing.
6. Nyx crosses to Nuberroca and props him up so he can move his legs; she takes a hard look at all three of the men who beat him, wanting to keep the faces.

6 - Release

1. The party is walked to a storage room to collect their gear. Nuberroca re-armours himself as he goes and turns back to the captain — *I will not forget this lesson. What is your name?*.
2. The captain answers: **Recaredo**, Captain of the Order of the Companion. Nyx notes the name mentally.
3. At the entrance, Ontharr looks at Nuberroca with plain disappointment — he expected better — turns and starts to leave, telling them the barge for tomorrow midday is arranged.
4. Nuberroca catches him on the way out. He wipes blood from himself, drops it deliberately on the stones between them and says: is this not brutality *to you*? — it's clear I need to calibrate mine better. Ontharr answers that there is no place in the world with worse brutalities than the remotest villages; Nuberroca allows he has restrained himself, and Ontharr knows it. Ontharr walks away.
5. Sinsong comes up to Nuberroca and lays a hand on his shoulder, murmuring *no killing, no killing, remember?*. As the touch lands, Nuberroca sees the dwarf's bald head glow, feels the wound knit, and lifts Sinsong bodily off his feet with a grin: *those were the words I needed*.
6. Nuberroca announces that this repulsive city does not deserve any more of their time, but he is curious about the sun — evil does not rest. Amidamaru, Mialee and Sinsong argue for finding a boat before losing the day.
7. Before they go, Nuberroca presses Amidamaru — are you sure no one is chasing you?. Amidamaru insists he doesn't know why the bandits singled him out; if the appearance is not his own, it wasn't the elf face they were after. Nyx presses: the child touched him and looked startled — that was what marked him. Amidamaru allows there was rough living in **Westgate** but says no law and no bandit is on his trail there. Nyx accepts the answer for now; Sinsong mutters he doesn't believe a word of it.

7 – The wrong boat

~14:30, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. At the port they find a merchant barge finishing its load. About halfway across the docks Amidamaru turns and heads back to the inn; he is done with the day and needs sleep to have his magic back.
2. Nyx walks up first and asks whether the barge is taking travellers — the answer is yes, a hundred silver per hundred miles of route, so twelve gold each for the six of them, rounded to seventy-five gold in the captain's favour.
3. Nyx offers services in exchange: Sinsong as a healer, Nuberroca for guard-work and cargo, herself for the galley. The captain shrugs off the medic — a quiet run — but under Nyx's hard bargaining knocks the fare to sixty gold, then to fifty. They pool the money — Nyx roughs the split at eight-and-change each and drops her share; Nuberroca and Mialee both pay in.
4. During the wait for the barge, Nuberroca hunts down a wise old man in the town — the type of elder who sits in a circle of grey-haired locals and knows the city's stories — and asks about the sun.
5. The elder gives him the version that isn't officially heresy: the second sun appeared when the city was near-lost to a plague of vampires and undead; the Hellriders alone were fighting them and losing ground. When the sun rose in the middle of the night, most of the vampires still in the streets — including the old governor — burned on the spot. The Hellriders finished the rest, the pilgrims flooded in from across the region, and the Order of the Companion was founded around the light.
6. Attributing the sun to any single god is illegal, the elder adds — a rule made after mass pilgrimage arrivals to keep the city off a civil war over gods. Popular tradition ties the sun's coming to **Thavius Kreeg**, the current mayor, because the sun appeared as he was rising in power; officially, though, the sun is called *the gift of Amaunator*, and Amaunator is who most people quietly believe made it.
7. Also during the wait, Nyx buys a fresh quiver of arrows and an off-hand quiver, at about a gold each. Mialee stops to buy sticks of incense for her familiar rituals — ten pieces of gold.
8. When it comes to boarding, the horses Ontharr had told them to keep through to Baldur's Gate become a problem — the barge is loaded past the gunwales and the captain never agreed to horses on the run. Nuberroca offers two of the animals as extra fare; the captain declines. Mialee cuts through it: why do they need horses at all if the boat is supposed to drop them at Baldur's Gate? The party agrees to leave them behind — Mialee proposes handing them back to Leosin — and boards without them.
9. The barge unmoors, the mule-teams brace along the tow-paths, and it begins to move. Within a minute or two the party notices that the direction is wrong — the barge is heading *upstream*, away from Baldur's Gate.
10. *You seriously hired a boat that doesn't go to Baldur's Gate?*, Mialee groans, and Sinsong is already talking about jumping into the water. Sinsong half-proposes hijacking — have him order the captain overboard and take the barge — Amidamaru shuts him down: enough, his ideas never work. They ask for their fare back; the captain won't return it, the cabins are held.
11. They walk off the barge with no refund. The barge, they will learn afterwards, was bound for Scornubel — a hundred miles upstream — while Baldur's Gate is a hundred and fifty and downstream.
12. Mialee walks straight back to Ontharr and asks him — plainly — for the *name* of the barge he had arranged, so they cannot make the same mistake again. Ontharr gives it: **La Sirena de agua dulce**, departing tomorrow around midday.

8 – At the town hall

~17:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Mialee finds the barge at the dock, tells the captain she is one of the passengers due to board tomorrow, and asks to move into her cabin now — she is tired. The captain will not hand over the cabins early, but for five silver a head he will let them sleep on board overnight. Mialee pays; Sinsong and Nyx take the same deal.
2. Nuberroca then plants himself at the town hall door. Two guards in the two-suns emblem — one Companion, one Hellrider — stand at the gate. Nuberroca asks for audience with the mayor to talk about the sun and about the undead plague he faces at home. The guards ask who he is; he lists his credentials — one of the party from Greenest that faced the dragon, an envoy from the far north, and recently admitted to the Order of the Gauntlet, its emblem on his chest. That name gets him a check inside — the mayor is not in.
3. The goliath leaves a message that Nuberroca Quebrantacielos was here inquiring about the sun and a possible alliance against the northern plague. The Hellrider at the gate offers his order's sincere apologies for the party's cause but is plain that the Hellriders' operations reach only the highlands around Elturel; he cannot promise force at long range. The order's method against the undead is faith — no single god required — and Nuberroca strikes him as a man of action, not meditation. Nuberroca thanks him and walks off to the tavern.
4. For the rest of the afternoon, Nuberroca settles at the tavern, pays a couple of copper for a beer, and waits out the hours.

9 – Sirena de agua dulce

~08:00, 3 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Morning of the following day. Nuberroca wakes at eight and walks to the dock; the barge is there, its name matches — *La Sirena de agua dulce*. The tavern kept no breakfast that morning, so the party arrives at the barge on empty stomachs; Nyx pulls out a handful of the berries she prepared the day before and hands them round.
2. Around the midday hour, the barge is loaded to the gunwales; there is barely room to walk on deck, though a passenger can step out for air. The captain sets expectations: two to three days downriver, no intermediate stops, and the autumn rains should carry them fast. The barge unmoors.
3. Amidamaru does not come up on deck — hidden away in his cabin, coming out only for meals, then in an elf's shape. Their contact in Baldur's Gate, per Ontharr, is a merchant named **Ackyn Selebon**, who works in the north of the city — the party will need to make their own approach to him after landing.
4. The barge slips into the current; the mule-teams take the tow-paths on both banks. A full day of travel passes without event.
5. The mid-river country reads back to them as the day wears on: the south bank is greener, the north bank drier and browner; when the light thins, distant large figures can be sighted moving inland — trolls, in a stretch famously more dangerous than the rest of the river — and occasional mounted patrols pass on the roads to keep the routes secure.

10 – The hippo raid

~14:00, 4 Uktar 1489 DR

1. About six hours into the second day of the trip, they hear a hard knock in the hull. The barge is heavy enough that it does not roll, but a solid thump comes through the boards; a second one follows.
2. On deck the crew are trying to fend off animals — four large forms in the water, coming in on both sides of the barge. Hippopotamuses. Aggressive enough that the hull is already losing wood on one side.
3. The party opens fast. Nyx puts an arrow into the nearest one over the low gunwale; Sinsong lays a drowsing hum across the water and puts another under. Mialee brings up a tiny illusion between the two on the far side — a short, piercing squeal placed right between them — and both wheel around at the sound and swim off. Sinsong then turns to the sleeping one, points, and orders it to run; the word takes and the animal wakes into a flight upstream.
4. Nuberroca picks up his lance and moves down to the barge's rail. A thrust lands on the animal hitting the hull, and the shaft's force puts it onto its back in the water.
5. Before that one can right itself, another hippo climbs the gunwale and charges Nuberroca; he catches it hard as it comes in, but the beast's rush takes a chunk out of him on the way through — and then a soft blue glow rises over the wound and the flesh knits back closed.
6. ***[EPIC]*** With a yell, the barbarian drives a thrust clean through the hippo — no guard, all commitment; the beast falls beaten at the barge's side and rolls once as it dies, tearing off a piece of the plank it had been smashing.
7. Sinsong turns to the deck-climber and orders it to flee; the word takes and it runs, at least for the moment. But another hippo climbs up in short order and clamps its bite on Nyx, almost tearing her apart. Nuberroca answers with the same all-in commitment — the lance goes clean through, and the follow-up puts the hippo flat on the deck.
8. Nuberroca crows: tonight they dine on hippo.
9. Even as the fight runs, the barge is already holed and shipping water in more than one place; Mialee slips a small-repair charm across the worst of the damage as the crew frantically bails around her. Once the last hippo is off, Sinsong turns his own repair magic to the planks and together with Mialee they finish piece by piece; the captain accepts it as good enough to finish the run.

11 – Baldur's Gate

~12:00, 5 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The rest of the second day passes without incident. The following morning the mountain that sits above **Baldur's Gate** rises in the distance; by midday the barge is at the docks.
2. The city is bigger than any of them — save Amidamaru — has seen: a proper port, packed and noisy.
3. Their Baldur's Gate contact, per Ontharr's brief, is at the northern gate — the **Black Dragon Gate**.
4. The captain gives the party a warm hand off the boat, thanks them for the help with the hippos and the repairs, and promises to send word back to both Leosin and Ontharr.
5. Nuberroca stays on the dock to help the crew unload — they are hard-pressed to make time and money back, and his strength is worth a couple of hours — and tells the others to go ahead.

Session 14

2025-06-22

1 - Baldur's Gate

~12:30, 5 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The barge ties up at the Baldur's Gate docks on the third day out from Elturel. The captain thanks the party for the hippo defence and river repairs, then walks the hull to a shipwright — she holds water but will not do another run without work. The city rules are clear at the pier: no draught animals, no carts inside the walls; cargo moves on porters' backs.
2. The scale of the port lands hard on those who have never seen a real city — stone quays, four-storey slate-roofed houses along the wharf, crowd noise thick enough to swallow a shouted conversation ten feet away. Amidamaru, veteran of Westgate, is the only one not startled by it.
3. The tortle pulls on a fresh elf-face illusion twice over — one casting for the meal, a second for the walk into the city.
4. Nyx warns him this is going to be the biggest city they will ever pass through: if he cannot walk this one, he cannot walk any. Amidamaru answers that big cities do not treat *different* kindly, and until a fight forces him out he will stay hidden.
5. After the meal on the docks the party spends the afternoon working the streets on foot — Amidamaru quietly taking the measure of the crowd; the rest learning the shape of the city.
6. By dusk they pick out a nearby tavern by its sign — a mermaid raising a jug — and head over: the *Blushing Mermaid*.

2 - Blushing Mermaid

~18:00, 5 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Inside, the room is packed and loud; each pays three gold for a room and full board — Amidamaru is nearly out of coin and Nyx covers his share. Nyx drops onto an open couch between two sailors on shore-leave; the loudest is a veteran whaler who introduces himself as **Hipocampus**.
2. The whalers invite her into dice at a silver a hand — five dice, highest sum wins. Nyx puts in a silver, rolls low, steps away — not enough coin to keep playing.
3. Nyx starts fishing for news: has anyone unusual moved through, anyone in strange robes? Hipocampus only knows what any sailor knows — trade from the south is thick, rumours of attacks in the green fields including a place called *Greenest*, and *"nobody has ever seen a dragon around here"*.
4. Mialee shows the whaler the cult's dragonclaw insignia — has he seen it? A pause; no. Amidamaru quietly confirms he was not lying.
5. Nyx presses him — a merchant contact, north gate, a name they were half-forgetting. Hipocampus knows it: **Ackyn Selebon**, a northern-gate merchant who outfits caravans; his shop is about an hour's walk north. The party parks the errand for the morning.

3 - Stranger at the back

1. Amidamaru has been noting the man alone at the back from the moment they walked in — hooded, huge, armoured under the cloak, taking up a whole table for one glass of wine. The party drifts over.
2. Only sharp eyes catch it at first, in candle-light and at close range: under the hood, more snout than face, and red. Eguzkilore offers a jug of beer as a peace-offering; Nyx raises her wine and toasts him.
3. Amidamaru sees a dragon face and pulls his sword back, drops into guard. *A dragon* — the party comes half up out of the seat with him. Nyx tries to hold the room: yes, he looks like Langdedrosa, but this one seems peaceful.
4. The tavern's two bouncers step in with steel out. Nyx intercepts — *sorry, misunderstanding, my friend was just showing his sword to a friend* — while Nuberroca slides behind the nearer bouncer and murmurs that this is a private conversation. The bouncer, half fear and half duty: *calm down, don't get so close, please behave*. Amidamaru sheathes; the bouncers step back, one lingering to watch.
5. Amidamaru pulls out the dragonclaw amulet and drops it on the table between them, watching for the reaction. Kaelthar looks up: *You are wearing a symbol that hangs like a sentence. Do you tell me you are guilty, or you are a martyr? Do you dare display that insignia, or do you seek provocation?*.
6. Amidamaru asks him to speak plainly, in a language everyone at the table can follow. The stranger names himself: *Kaelthar, warrior, paladin, more lethal than I look*. Kaelthar then names his hunt: anyone bearing that insignia.

4 - Fists in the street

1. Nuberroca puts a proposition on the table: no shields, no weapons, fists only. Kaelthar takes it; the pair walk out onto the port-side avenue rather than break the tavern. Nyx catches the bouncer on the way past: *they are only playing*.
2. Kaelthar draws a small ward of protection onto himself before the first exchange. Nuberroca throws the first punch with no guard up — it goes wide. Kaelthar's return lands solid to the ribs; Nuberroca tips into the roaring open-throated fury he keeps for the worst moments.
3. Kaelthar returns fire through the opening Nuberroca leaves him — a clean crack across the jaw; as the fist connects a small light flares along his knuckles, a divine burn folded into the strike, and Nuberroca spits blood. Nyx: *look, his fist is glowing*.
4. Two more exchanges. Nuberroca goes back reckless — one punch entering, one answered under a second flare of divine light — and by the third round he is bloodied and wobbling, a state none at the table have ever seen him in.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Kaelthar drops one last divine-burning strike and Nuberroca finally loses a fistfight for the first time in memory: still on his feet but battered, holding on rather than winning. Nuberroca concedes outright — *you have beaten me. My whole body hurts. How do you make your fists glow?*. Kaelthar answers that he swore an oath — a vengeance oath, against the very insignia the party had shown him at the table.
6. Amidamaru lays a hand on each and closes the worst of the cuts with a small casting — Nuberroca's wounds knit under a soft blue glow, Kaelthar's under a red one; the blood stays on the skin. Nyx offers Kaelthar her wine. Both men are still tender walking back in, and the bouncers watch them come in with a very different look than they had going out.

5 – The private room

1. The party pays a gold to close off the tavern's private back room for the evening; Amidamaru sweeps it for concealed listeners on principle. Walls thick enough that the tavern noise drops to a murmur; no windows.
2. Nyx asks the direct question: *how did you come to hate these people?*. Kaelthar answers as a paladin of the vengeance oath — a soldier of a clan of red dragonborn. In his own telling: a prophecy at his birth named him *the edge of the final fire*; a ceremony was arranged to unite his red clan and a white glacial clan against the cult of Tiamat; during the rite the glacial queen — a secret Tiamat priestess — killed the red-clan leaders and consumed their souls into a fragment of the goddess-dragon; Kaelthar survived three days buried under the sanctuary's rubble and cinders and eventually crawled out; he stood alone, marked by fury, and swore that no temple of Tiamat would stand, no traitor would go without judgement, no captive soul without redemption or destruction.
3. The party pays the story back with a compressed version — Greenest sacked by dragons, Langdedrosa Cyanwrath the half-dragon general beheaded (his head still hanging in Greenest); trouble in Elturel that ended in friendship with the Order of the Gauntlet and the Harpers; a contact they were sent to find north of Baldur's Gate.
4. Kaelthar names his own faction — *the Order of the Gauntlet*. Nuberroca peels back the skin over his coat, shows the matching insignia, and Kaelthar returns the sign in kind. Then, because it is *him*, Nuberroca tries to lift the paladin off his feet in a grip-hug to see how heavy he is. He passes on the reference to Ontharr — *the captain of the order. I beat him with my fists, you should fight him too*.
5. Kaelthar names his own errand: he is here to wait for a group of adventurers, escort them north to **Ackyn Selebon**, and infiltrate with them to uncover the plans of the Cult of the Dragon. Nuberroca, halfway out the door, doubles back — *that's the name I couldn't remember*.
6. Nuberroca announces Kaelthar is in as far as he is concerned, tells the others they can confirm in the morning, and takes himself off to bed. Amidamaru stays behind to press Kaelthar for anything more on their business — has he heard of a tortoise in his travels? — and the paladin admits he has not been looking for that. The rest drift out to eat, taking supper up to the room; before Nyx sleeps she readies a fresh set of Goodberries for the next day.

6 – Under the hood

~08:00, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party is down at eight for breakfast: cold meat, hard bread, toasted pieces, beer — Mialee asks for a cup of milk and gets one more curd than milk, dairy does not travel well.
2. Amidamaru, having drawn the wrong eyes yesterday even with the elf-face, tries a different tack: a walking cloak deep over the shell so nothing of his shape reads clearly. The attempt goes badly — the hood makes him more conspicuous, and by the time the party is on the street heads are turning, guards are looking longer, the crowd is stepping around him. Kaelthar picks it out at once — a heavily burdened person under a very odd cloak, something moving underneath — and asks him plainly, *who are you?*.
3. Amidamaru drops the cloak just enough for Kaelthar to see: *this is my real form — the same problem you have, hard to show in public. I don't usually show it in big cities. I'm taking a risk, and I don't like it*. Kaelthar answers as one outsider to another: *that is what it feels to be a stranger among many*.

7 – Black Dragon Gate

1. Following the flow of porters through the crowded street is enough to reach the north gate without directions. Amidamaru and Nuberroca are the first to catch what the others miss — several faces among the porters at the gate register from a past encounter, back at Greenest or the cult's camp or on the raiders' road.
2. Amidamaru summons his owl. **Munin** wheels down onto the rooftops and settles into a long circle overhead — birds common enough here that no one looks up. Amidamaru watches through Munin's eyes and his own at once.
3. Nuberroca picks a porter he half-remembers — *hello, what are you doing here?* — the porter tries to shake him off. Nuberroca sidles closer and, on the excuse of helping with the bundle, hooks a finger under and lifts it. Something metallic clinks inside the sack the porter has just insisted is grain. Nuberroca, quieter: *this does not sound like grain — if you want to keep talking straight, talk.*
4. Mialee slips an invisible magic hand in beside the covered palanquin the same group is escorting, and — as if a small gust had caught it — lifts a corner of the cover. Amidamaru, at oblique distance, sees under and turns away without a word: inside sits a black dragonborn. He and Nuberroca pull back into the group.
5. Nyx pings each of the others with a short mind-to-mind whisper — *come back, distance, we do not want them tying you to the rest of us*. Nuberroca lets the porter go and pulls back; half a dozen furtive glances follow him.
6. At a middle distance, they compare notes: black dragonborn in the palanquin, cultists' faces among the porters, ten or twelve moving as a unit. Nyx puts the question — infiltrate as planned, but Nuberroca has already been marked — how do we play this?. The party keep their spacing and follow the palanquin to a warehouse-inn used by merchants waiting for a caravan; it shuts behind them. Munin passes overhead but finds nothing to perch on that isn't a giveaway.

8 – Ackyn Selebon's shop

1. The party enter the shop across from the gate; Nuberroca uncovered, the rest in travel gear. The merchant recognises the emblem on Nuberroca's tabard — *are you the Ontharr ones?* — and slots into helping them at once. He is worried they cut it close: the group they came for arrived a few days ago, are refusing to hire guards or carts locally — *which is peculiar if not impossible* — and have been packing for two days. Best guess: they roll out today or tomorrow, from an inn at the end of the street on the left — where the party has just seen the palanquin disappear.
2. The merchant does not go out on the road himself, but offers his name as reference to the caravan's other merchants and can supply gear and horses. The caravan is bound north to **Waterdeep**. The frame: several merchants pool for a run, each with 3-8 guards, total 30-40 for the group. Two roads north: the direct route through *The Trollclaws*, or a longer detour east via *The Fields of the Dead*, then back north through the Trade Way.
3. Nuberroca cashes in a greataxe, a scimitar and a broadsword at half-price; Amidamaru sells a crossbow and its bolts, keeping the quiver. Amidamaru asks the merchant to arrange a letter to Westgate — direct messenger would be almost three hundred gold, a hand-off across trade caravans four or five with no guarantees. He takes the caravan option, four gold, and marks the letter sent.

9 - Contracting on

1. Outside, the party spread out to shop themselves in. Nyx counts five merchants working the crowd: **Lai Angesstun**, a dwarf — oil-and-perfume merchant from Amn, short-handed and agitated, wanted to be on the road already; **Edhelri Lewel**, an elf-woman trading in exotic woods; and **Noohar Serelim**, a second elf — standing quiet next to a wagon of carved wood, travelling with his mute brother **Selvek**.
2. Each hire lands on a demonstration. **Kaelthar** carries a flexing demonstration for Lai. **Nuberroca** opens Edhelri with a polite bow (*good afternoon, dear elf, we come to offer ourselves as soldiers of fortune*), and **Amidamaru** drives a stagecraft display alongside — shadow-blade in his hands and a wizard's blade-song through the air, Nuberroca hopping in as stage-hand. **Mialee** arrives at the tail of the negotiation and puts an arrow clean through an illusion-target thirty feet out for Noohar.
3. When the dust settles, Lai has hired the largest slice of the party — Kaelthar as bodyguard at 10 gold a week, Nyx as sergeant at 8, and Eguzkilore as guard at 5. Edhelri contracts Mialee as her bodyguard at 10 and Nuberroca as her sergeant at 8. Noohar takes Amidamaru as his bodyguard at 10, with the standing condition that Amidamaru protects him *and his brother*.
4. Wages per-week, paid week-in-arrears, plus food and shelter on the road and paid nights when the caravan stops in a village with a bed. **Sinsong** travels as a paying passenger rather than on contract.

10 - Trail preparation

~11:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The larger caravan carts are almost finished loading; the suspected cultist has three carts readied but their palanquin is nowhere to be seen. Even so, the cultists stay apart from the rest of the caravan — their porters stay attached to their own group rather than joining the shared pool, walk-in guards looking for work are turned away, and no one from their contingent mixes with the other merchants.
2. When the wheels turn: ten carts on the road — five with merchants, two with travellers riding along, three with the suspected cultist contingent — protected by 30-35 warriors between guards, sergeants and bodyguards.
3. On the merchant's warning — no re-supply on the road, no smith to re-shaft a broken blade — the party lay in trail-stock. Nyx picks up a fresh longbow-string, Mialee a handful of arrows and a couple of spare strings, Eguzkilore nine long-shaft arrows. Kaelthar takes a spare longsword against the day this one takes damage. Prices per usual — one gold per twenty arrows, fifteen gold per longsword.
4. Nyx breaks out ten Goodberries as lunch — one each, enough to hold hunger through the afternoon so no one has to walk back across the city.
5. With most of an hour still to fill, the party breaks for a short rest and a quiet meal — most already at full strength, but all settle in for the road ahead.
6. At around half-past one the carts begin to move. Sinsong is nowhere to be seen; the caravan heads north without him.

Session 15

2025-06-29

1 - Before the road

~13:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Before the wheels turn, Amidamaru begs a loan around the party for spell-scribing supplies: three platinum from Eguzkilore, a scatter of coin from Nyx, ten gold from Mialee — enough for a scroll's worth of paper and ink at twenty-five gold the sheet.
2. He goes hunting the supplies through Baldur's Gate on his own and hits a wall — no shop within reach carries the mage-grade paper he needs. After a while he cuts his losses and returns to the group without the goods.
3. Nuberroca sets out for a small healing potion — the only strength his budget stretches to at fifty gold, when a medium bottle would run him two hundred. Amidamaru quietly buys one on his behalf and lodges the tab — when the trip is done, he will collect the coin.
4. The party takes a beat to think about disguise — this is an infiltration, the sensible ones should change something about how they look. Nyx picks up a spare cloak and a hood off the merchant's supply; Mialee takes a small cape. Amidamaru already keeps his elf-face illusion. Nuberroca goes the other way — chest out, the Order of the Gauntlet emblem on plain view, watching every face for the flinch of recognition he saw at the north gate.
5. Amidamaru shares that half an hour ago Munin, his owl familiar, caught a hooded figure and eight riders leaving the cultist inn on horseback, taking the north road at speed. He sends Munin up to trail them, watching through the owl's eyes as far as the bond carries; once the owl outruns his reach no new order will follow. The last command he leaves is *watch*. By roll-out the owl is back with him.

2 - Caravan assembly

1. Ten carts assemble in the yard by the Black Dragon Gate. Five carry the merchants — the three who hired the party plus the ale-seller who did not; two are traveller carts riding along; the last three sit at the front of the line, the group the party suspects for cultists.
2. **Lai Angesstun**'s cart is first up front, the gold-dwarf and his caravan-veteran guard **Eldkin** paired to it; behind them ride Nyx as his sergeant and Eguzkilore under her, with Eldkin's own remark that the road-experience should have made her the sergeant instead.
3. **Edhelri Lewel**'s two wagons of wood take Mialee at the bodyguard's spot and Nuberroca as her sergeant.
4. **Noohar Serelim** and his brother **Selvek** ride the third wagon with Amidamaru minding both of them.
5. The last of the four is **Beyd** the half-elf, his cart stacked entire with barrels of ale for the road; he travels with one guard, **Sulesdeg**, close to seven and a half feet tall — shorter than the goliath but taller than any other man on the road.
6. Nuberroca and Amidamaru, nearest the cultist wagons in the yard, take the closest look; neither can match a face from the cave to any of the guards or drivers.
7. The party gets shown the road on a Sword Coast map — Baldur's Gate up the Trade Way through the Trollclaws to Waterdeep, the direct line rather than the longer detour. Fifteen miles a day, six days of travel and one of rest — two months in all.
   Nuberroca sees the catch plain enough — there is a stretch full of troll caverns and the merchants think the sensible thing is to walk the road straight through the middle of it. The merchants have counted their coin: the detour would add nearly a month, and guards are cheaper than lost weeks.

3 – On the road

~14:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The ten carts roll out of Baldur's Gate a couple of hours past midday, well later than the merchants had wanted. The formation settles by itself — the three cultist wagons at the head with their own drivers and guards, the three party-merchant carts in the middle, the ale wagon and the two traveller carts trailing. The sun is up strong for the season; it is autumn but the afternoon is hot, and the land opens out into flat country with sparse woodland — good sightlines and almost no shade.
2. Nuberroca makes for the traveller cart — a family, three children and their parents, moving north because Baldur's Gate has soured for them — a bad run of luck in the city, corruption thick enough to drive them out, and Waterdeep is where they mean to start again. He stands full-height alongside the seated father, puts his chest on show and rolls the pecs one at a time, pushing a muscle-tensing sound through his teeth — his name is Nuberroca, and if they need help on the road he is here to serve them. The family's two mounted guards ride up beside the cart without drawing steel; the father thanks him and, in the same breath, hopes not to need him on the road.
3. The family's story does not quite settle Nuberroca — a run of bad luck reads to him like a cover, and he wants to know what a supposedly-civilian family is really hauling. He fakes a stumble into the cartside and listens: for the ring of metal in the wood, for anything shifting inside. Nothing metallic, only voices asking whether he is alright. Mialee walks over and pulls him back to their own line.
4. Nyx puts the question in a lull of the ride — has anyone here fought trolls before? — and gets nothing useful; her own knowledge is rumour only, that they are big and ugly. Amidamaru suggests Mialee try her charm on the other bodyguards, on the reasoning that they will have seen more of the road than the party has.
5. Nyx murmurs a small blessing over her own eyes as she pushes forward through the caravan, then studies each of the three cultist wagons in turn from a middling distance — she is looking for a face she remembers from the cave. Nothing lands; the wagons are all tarpaulined tight, and Lai's own oil-and-perfume cart looks no different from the outside. She moves on to the head of the caravan and keeps her watch there.
6. Mialee walks over to Beyd's cart to work him for information alongside a deal on the beer. A full barrel — the man carries barrels, not small kegs — runs fifty jars of ale; Beyd would sell her one for forty-seven silver, three under market. Mialee closes the deal, then keeps him talking: he runs this road often, there is always a bandit or a monster somewhere, but a torch usually settles the trolls quickly enough. Then she puts the question about his guard, so tall — the man's real name is **Sulesdeg**, but everyone on the road calls him *The Pole* because he stands tall as a lodge pole.
7. Sometime in the ride the wages come clear from the merchants — sixty gold for a bodyguard at journey's end, forty-eight for a sergeant, thirty for a guard: six tendays' rate on a two-month trip, and only if the job is done clean.
8. Riding on Noohar's cart, Amidamaru asks the brothers whether either of them knows a merchant on the road who might carry magic-grade paper and ink. Selvek meets the question with hand gestures Amidamaru cannot follow. Noohar answers plain for his brother, catching himself mid-sentence — his brother is mute, he cannot speak — then reaches for the answer proper: the caravan people he knows carry stranger cargo than paper, and he cannot help. He does know Beyd from other trips, and knows Eldkin too — has seen her fight bandits, and once a troll.
9. Amidamaru calls Munin down onto his shoulder for the brothers to see and pledges the owl to them as a second pair of eyes on the road — in a fight the bird will come to them and watch over them as he would. To Selvek and Noohar he lays it out — with the owl beside him, he stands as two.
10. Amidamaru walks a slow *detect magic* through the caravan as a ritual, standing off close to each cart in turn — no arcane user among the guards or the merchants. He drops the plan out loud: at each halt he will walk the caravan again, twice a day if the stops hold long enough.

4 – First halt

~17:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. After three hours on the road the carts start braking to a stop for the first short rest. The three groups pull apart at the halt the way they had on the road — the three cultist merchants form up alone to the front, Lai, Edhelri and Noohar together in the middle, and Beyd walks a barrel over to the family and the second traveller cart to work the fire for a sale.
2. The meals divide by employer. Lai serves rice and beans to Kaelthar, Nyx and Eguzkilore — the same food he takes himself, and Eldkin knows him well enough for a skinflint to sneak dried meat from her own bag into the pot for a bit of flavour. Edhelri feeds Mialee and Nuberroca better — puffed wheat, cured meat, some vegetables, meal worth serving to a guest. Around the fires the party watches for anything out of order and comes up empty.
3. Beyd rolls his barrel through the party's fire before the halt breaks up — ten copper the jar, though the same beer runs two coppers back in the city. Nuberroca turns him down flat — beer dulls the senses; maybe when the watch is done — and gets up to walk it off — a refusal that surprises Mialee at the fire. Amidamaru takes a jar, on a two-copper deposit for the mug, and hands it to one of the brothers when he comes back to the cart.

5 – Night camp

~18:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan pushes another two hours after the halt, aiming to close out the day early — eight in the evening by the time the light goes soft and the guards start lighting the wagon lamps. Amidamaru keeps Munin low overhead through the dusk — high in daylight, low in the dark. Two riders cross the road going the other way at a trot; brief nods around; Amidamaru shouts after them asking for paper and ink, and they ride on giving him strange looks.
2. The wheels stop for the night off the road. This stretch of the Trade Way has no villages or inns; tonight, they sleep in the open. Carts settle into the three groups they had held all day; harness comes off, and Eldkin walks the horses down for the day's sweat, rubbing them clean. Nyx and Nuberroca are told to keep eyes on the animals; Nyx passes the job on to Eguzkilore and Eldkin and slips into the trees to hunt a rabbit for Eldkin's fire, angling for a little goodwill. No game to be had in the dark.
3. Eguzkilore, needing only half a night's trance, offers to take the last four hours of the watch straight through — a shift worth a lot of gratitude from the rest of the guards.

6 – Spear and pebble

~21:00, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. With the camp settled and the guards patrolling, Nuberroca crosses to the cultist carts spear in hand — pauses ten feet off the first, brings the point up to the tarp; a guard rises off the ground and shouts him back — away from the merchandise. He moves on to the second cart and repeats the pass; the guard tracks him with his eyes and does not intervene, but the message is clear enough.
2. Amidamaru, watching Nuberroca work cart to cart, drops ten copper into a passing guard's hand with a pebble in the other — carry this to the goliath. The guard takes the coin and the errand. The pebble reads unremarkable in the palm; touched to the ear, a whispered voice comes out of it — an artificer's small craft. To Nuberroca the whisper carries Amidamaru's warning: the front of the caravan already knows him, stop drawing attention.
3. Nuberroca hears it and walks back to his post — then shouts *Look out! Defend yourselves!* across the camp to test the caravan. Every guard down the line comes up with blades or crossbows out; the front carts move exactly the same as the rest. Nuberroca declares it a false alarm — a flash of light in the sky — and waves off the half that keeps staring with a small regal flick of the wrist, all swagger and grin.
4. Over dinner Amidamaru works his way around the rest of the party in turn — a hand on a shoulder, a pebble pressed to a pocket, an ear leaned in for the whisper: they are all being watched, everyone should keep their distance from Nuberroca specifically. Nuberroca's own pendant — a glow Amidamaru had strung on it — quietly goes dark on his chest.

7 – The night watch

1. Amidamaru drops a spell of *invisibility* on Munin and sends the owl out to skim the cultist carts at eavesdropping range — whatever the owl's fine hearing catches, Amidamaru will catch too. Half an hour of listening turns up nothing worth carrying back.
2. Nyx sets a silent *alarm* over the far end of the middle cultist cart — a twenty-foot square, mental rather than audible, meant to catch anyone stepping in or out of it in the night. She lays it from over thirty feet off, so the cultists cannot see the working, and folds her whispered casting into what looks like a conversation with a nearby ally.
3. She wakes about an hour or two into her sleep to the alarm — mental, silent to the camp. When she lifts her head to look, it is only one of the caravan's own guards leaning on the cart mid-patrol. She lies back down.
4. The rest of the night passes without further incident — a first uneventful night of what is to be a two-month road.

Session 16

2025-07-13

1 - A quiet day

~08:00, 7 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan rolls out under a clear sky and travels a full day on the road: open plains, sparse copses of trees, no travellers on the road and no trouble in sight.
2. The rest of the day passes without incident. Nightfall camp goes down at another of the road's stopping points; **Eguzkilore** volunteers for the last four hours of the watch on the strength of his elven trance, banking a little more goodwill with the caravan's guards, and the second night on the road ends as quietly as the first.
3. At breakfast the next morning each merchant serves his own guards from his own stores: **Lai**'s porridge is cheap and hot; **Edhelri** serves better porridge with fruit; **Noohar** tops his with a little honey for flavour.
4. The caravan is two days out of Baldur's Gate; the country is open plains, sparse copses of trees, and the low tumulus-shaped hills on the horizon that mark the outer edge of the Trollclaws — five days off at their pace.
5. Over porridge the caravan guards make small talk with the party: everyone shares the same wish for a quiet two months of road, because when something happens they have to work, and none of them like working when it means risking their necks.

2 - Amidamaru's boar

~11:00, 8 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Amidamaru keeps Munin overhead all morning, careful to stay within a hundred feet of the owl — beyond that tether the telepathic contact and the sight through his eyes both drop. He keeps the bird close.
2. Four hours out from camp, Munin catches a boar off the road, roughly five hundred feet away. Amidamaru relays it to Nuberroca low, not to the whole group, so the caravan does not tie the message to the bird.
3. Nuberroca announces to Edhelri that he is going to fetch food, gets waved off without protest, and sprints out with a crossbow. A twenty-minute chase brings him inside a hundred and fifty feet; he snaps off a long shot he does not expect to land, and instead sinks a bolt into the boar's haunch.
4. The boar turns rather than flees. Nuberroca is already laughing as it charges; he plants the spear butt into the ground and the boar drives itself onto the shaft. He lifts the carcass clear on the shaft over his head.
5. He smears himself in the boar's blood on the walk back — no river within a day and a half — and rejoins the caravan half an hour later, still dripping, shouting to anyone who will listen that lunch is on him.
6. Told the Chionthar is two days and a half behind and the Winding Water still five days off — and that no one recommends bathing in the second one — Nuberroca cleans the blood off with wet grass and bark instead. A man of the outdoors, the group agrees.

3 - The midday halt

~14:00, 8 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Two in the afternoon, the caravan pulls off the road to eat. It is forty in all — thirty-odd guards, the merchants, the family, the two travelling carts — and the fires collapse into a single circle around the boar.
2. **Beyd** volunteers to cook the roast, claiming a caravaneer's practice with spits. Nuberroca donates one of his four spears — puts it through the carcass end to end and hands it over, drawing a mild rebuke about gutting the boar first.
3. The spit is jury-rigged between two forked sticks. Beyd asks Nuberroca to turn it — the goliath has the strength, Beyd does not — and while Nuberroca turns, Beyd bastes the roast with a splash of his own beer.
4. While the boar cooks Amidamaru slips onto his own cart with Munin on his shoulder, casts *invisibility* on the owl, and sends him through the tarps of the three cultist wagons in turn. Every one holds the same nailed-shut crates and no one inside.
5. Meals divide by employer at the plates as they did before. Beyd works his fire, selling beer at a silver a jar; he gives Nuberroca two jars free on the boar and Nuberroca drinks both on the spot.
6. The travelling family comes to the fire. Nuberroca waves them in warmly. Mialee joins them to make conversation. A gnome — travelling separately from the family though he shares their cart — sits apart, working the guards for a dice game.
7. The cultists come to the fire last. Their guard — the same one who had turned Nuberroca off the cultist wagons at an earlier camp — draws his knife to cut a slice without a word. Nuberroca catches the wrist, lifts the man near clear of the ground, and tells him he needs to ask permission first.
8. The cultist folds — they are merchants bound for Waterdeep, their guards had assumed the roast was for sharing — and Nuberroca steps back with a warning: the soldiers had best be well fed for whatever lies ahead. They take a slice and go.
9. The gnome, **Radecere Perethun**, asks Mialee's group for a game. She sits down opposite him. Five dice each, highest scores; the gnome opens with four fives and a six, exceptional, and Mialee comes over the top with four sixes and a five.
10. He asks for double-or-nothing and loses again. He asks for one more, four silver in the pot; he throws three sixes, a five and a four, near-unbeatable, and Mialee still lands one point over him. Radecere pays out seven silver total, retreats to his cart, and eats his slice of boar alone.
11. Mialee remarks afterwards that she had planned to cheat and never needed to. Amidamaru — watching from the far side — assumed she had cheated the whole time regardless.

4 - The evening ride

~19:00, 8 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Four hours further, well into the evening, the caravan is closing on the small tumulus-like hills that mark the outer edge of troll country — still five days out. Beyd's horses stay poorly kept as before, freed to graze only when he remembers, mostly ignored while he sells beer.
2. Munin's cover slips along the ride: he is a night bird flying under a hard sun, and one of the caravan guards asks Amidamaru how he keeps the owl awake. Amidamaru admits it openly — the owl is his familiar, he hides him only when he is working.
3. What the guards do talk about, over and over, is the trolls: not every caravan on this road makes it out, and the fear runs the full length of the line.
4. Camp goes down for the night in one of the pre-established stopping points that dot the road — a cleared and reused spot with good sightlines. Eguzkilore offers a full four-hour shift on the strength of his elven trance; Nuberroca takes another.
5. The party debates whether to move on the cultists tonight. Amidamaru presses for information — they still know almost nothing. Nuberroca offers to grab one and beat it out of him. Mialee counters that a missing man means questions the next morning. Eguzkilore's proposal wins the room — wait for troll country, when a disappearance can be blamed on the road — and Nuberroca stands down, agreeing to turn in.
6. The night passes without incident.

5 – The men in the road

~08:00, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Wake, breakfast — no boar left, back to the standard fare. Mialee slips a small illusion into Nuberroca's plate, a smiley worked into the porridge. Nuberroca spots the trick, grins the same grin back at her, and tells her she is a good one.
2. Beyd works his fire again and pitches beer as morning hydration under a hard sun. No takers today — the only regular wine-drinker in the party, Nyx, is not thirsty.
3. About three and a half hours down the road, closing on the day's usual break, Munin from overhead catches a knot of figures standing across the road ahead — perhaps four hundred feet off, in a small stand of trees.
4. Amidamaru signals the caravan to halt. The lead driver pulls up on a single guard's word, and murmurs run down the line asking why.
5. The tortle advances up the road with two guards behind him. Nuberroca peels off into the tree line to the west without any pretence at stealth — a nine-foot blue giant, in his own words, invisible only to the willing.
6. Eguzkilore falls in behind Amidamaru. Mialee stays with Edhelri on the wagon. Kaelthar, arriving late to the scene, joins Mialee at the rear.
7. At speaking distance the party makes out five men. The one in the middle wears richer clothes and carries himself as the leader; at his belt hangs a strange cylinder of metal with a wooden butt, the like of which none of them have ever seen.
8. The leader greets them and asks who speaks for the caravan. Amidamaru steps forward: no formal spokesperson, but they can help. The leader turns it around — the caravan will enter the fields of the dead in three or four days, and it will need protection.

6 – The negotiation

~11:30, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Amidamaru points to the caravan guards behind him — this caravan has hired protection already. Ignoring that, the leader names the price: two hundred gold across the caravan, until the Trollclaws. Nuberroca, still sitting on a tree stump like a king on his throne, laughs at the word *trolls* — he has faced a dragon and been unimpressed.
2. Amidamaru sends a guard back to the merchants with a counter-offer at fifty gold, and reads the situation quietly to him — fifty-fifty these are bandits, closer to eighty-twenty. On the strength of Nuberroca's dragon boast, the leader drops his own price to a hundred and fifty.
3. Amidamaru sends Munin toward the sound of muffled laughter he keeps hearing in the trees on the far side of the meeting. The leader spots the owl instantly — *why is an owl flying by day?* — and his four crossbowmen come up with weapons on Munin.
4. Amidamaru makes Munin vanish in the instant before the first bolt looses; the bolt whistles through the empty air where the owl had been, and the four crossbowmen stand there gaping and reloading. The leader takes it for wizardry: *"¿qué te crees, que nunca hemos visto un mago?"*.
5. Eguzkilore's eyes on the trees find the shape of a bandit behind every trunk for thirty yards — six or seven of them crouched in the trees to the north and west, more figures than the five in the road. He readies a shot for the first hostile move.
6. Nuberroca stays on the stump, hears the crossbows around him cocking one after another, and calls it out loud and clear: the crossbows are aimed — let the fight begin. He sets himself ready to answer any strike on him with a killing fury.
7. Kaelthar takes hold of his sword-hilt but keeps it sheathed. The leader ups the price back to two hundred on the party's posture, and gives them a moment to accept the offer or turn around — hand never leaving the cylinder at his belt.
8. Amidamaru offers the last number the merchants would carry — fifty gold, one small stipend, take it or leave it. The leader calls fifty pieces an insult. Nuberroca stands, shouts back to have it their way, and steps behind the cover of a tree with Eguzkilore, roaring into a full fury as the fight opens.

7 - The ambush

1. The leader gives the word to his crew — at them. The first bolt from the tree line comes for Nuberroca, chips bark off the trunk, misses.
2. Nuberroca's readied crossbow answers before the shooter's next breath — bolt through the neck, the bandit falls out of the tree dead. Eguzkilore, who had readied his own shot on the same man, sees him drop and holds his arrow for the leader instead.
3. Eleven more bolts arc at Nuberroca from the treeline in the next volley. Four bite, but between his rage and the cover of the trunk barely a scratch bleeds through — a blue glow settles over him and the scratches close as they open.
4. One of Amidamaru's two escort guards takes a bolt at the first volley, foams blood at the mouth and falls dead in seconds — the caravan's first loss.
5. A second volley cracks against Amidamaru — twelve bolts, most turned in mid-flight by a curtain of blue light around the tortoise's shell. Two get through: one lodges at the base of his neck, another sinks in at the temple. He is left on his feet, bleeding badly from the throat and the skull, and drops flat behind his cover.
6. Two of the mercenary captains bring up the strange metal cylinders — a thunder-crack cuts through the trees, and Nuberroca catches one of the shots square: a piece of metal buried under his collarbone.
7. A blue glow settles over Nuberroca — the flesh closes around the metal ball where it stays lodged.
8. Mialee, still hidden with the wagons, casts a cloud of fog across the eastern half of the field — the archers on the far right are blinded to the caravan and vice versa, and Mialee slips into her own fog invisible to the shooters.
9. Amidamaru, prone under his cover, calls up a *chromatic orb* of acid from a diamond in his palm and hurls it at one of the mercenary captains. The orb splashes hard: the captain's clothes begin to melt off him, and he claws at himself and screams.
10. Nuberroca steps out of a wisp of cloud on the far side of the battlefield and puts himself behind the screen of bandits guarding the leader, driving a spear thrust through one who staggers but holds.
11. Kaelthar runs from the caravan into the fight and catches a bolt in one shoulder on the way in. He tries breathing fire through the fog toward the left-flank archers; the cone catches three of them but they shake off most of it, and the sheltering tree behind them catches fire.
12. Amidamaru, prone in his cover, casts a slumber spell across the tight cluster of bandits around the leader. Two go down where they stood — a bandit and the leader himself, the same man who had opened the negotiation.
13. Eguzkilore drops one of the exposed archers with an arrow — a clean shot; the bandit falls dead.
14. Nuberroca leaps at another of the mercenary captains through the fog's edge — a lance strike opens the man up, then the polearm's butt hammers into his neck and the captain crumples to the ground barely alive. Nuberroca shouts Amidamaru's name and legs it back to cover, dropping flat behind his tree; a blue glow settles over him and his wounds close.
15. Mialee moves through her own fog unseen — the bandits on the left cannot find her. She reaches one of them on their flank and cuts him down with a scimitar in the back.
16. Amidamaru calls another *chromatic orb* out of his diamond — this one fire — and it splashes on a bandit further up the tree line. The bandit ignites and collapses into a pile of ash; Kaelthar and the two bandits beside him are left staring at what remains.
17. The dragonborn, isolated on the fog's edge, is ringed by four bandits — heavy strikes bite through his guard and he holds only briefly before two more blows put him unconscious.
18. Eguzkilore fires at the enemies fighting Kaelthar despite the odds of hitting his friend, the shot lands clean and a bandit drops dead.
19. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca closes on the ring around the paladin, drops his spear for the halberd, and swings — a reckless cut that takes the first bandit at the ribs, drives clean through his spine and buries in the second. The first falls in two pieces; the second sinks to his knees and dies. Nuberroca calls back to the party to regroup — the ambushers are running — and what is left of them breaks and scatters into the woods.

8 - After the ambush

~12:00, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Kaelthar is bleeding out on his back. Eguzkilore pulls a healing potion from his own pack, tips it into Kaelthar's mouth, and Kaelthar opens his eyes barely alive — Eguzkilore over him, Amidamaru behind, Nuberroca off to his left; and behind them the caravan guards standing over two of their own dead on the ground beside a fallen bandit.
2. Two caravan guards have fallen in the fight; the party accounted for most of the ambushers themselves, with the guards' bolts contributing at range once they closed on the fight.
3. Nuberroca goes to the captain he had knocked out with his polearm butt — the man is dying on the ground — and stabilises him with his own healer's kit, then binds his wrists with cord out of his pack.
4. Amidamaru ties off the two men still asleep from the same spell — one captain, one common bandit — and the party ends the fight with three prisoners: the leader, a captain and one bandit.

Session 17

2025-07-20

1 - Looting the dead

~12:30, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party works through the dead alongside the caravan guards while the merchants dig two graves in the road — the bandits to a shared shallow pit, the two fallen guards to their own deeper mound with piled stones against the wolves. The plentiful crossbow bolts scattered around are gathered back into the quivers.
2. The two captains and the lead bandit are stripped first: pooled coin and a scimitar. The strange metal cylinders are claimed by Amidamaru, one broken, one whole, along with a horn of black powder and a bag of small iron pellets.
3. The rest of the bandit dead yield some more coins, one of them foreign, some weapons and two bottles of hard drink. Coin gets divided among the party, and Eguzkilore pockets one of the rum bottles for Nuberroca.
4. Mialee tries to repair the crushed pistol with her magic. She manages to straighten the tube and glue the wood but not re-assemble a mechanism she does not understand. She also rounds a lead ball back to shape, giving Amidamaru one usable round.
5. **Edhelri** waits at the head of the line and the merchants are visibly tired of the wait: an hour is turning into two.

2 - The lodged bullet

1. Nyx focuses on Nuberroca's collarbone wound — it isn't magic, it's a projectile, and something is still lodged inside.
2. Amidamaru wakes the leader of the bandits and presses the intact pistol against his eyes, finger on the trigger, asking how it works. The captain, calm at first, tries to lie — he tells Amidamaru to grip it by the metal part and aim with the wood, the wooden butt sold as the barrel. Amidamaru, an artificer who has spent the better part of an hour on the weapon, calls the bluff and brings the muzzle closer to the captain's head.
3. Pressed on the road ahead, the captain names the Fields of the Dead — an old massive battlefield north of Baldur's Gate. Do not make fire at night, do not call attention: the dead there do not rest as well as they should. Amidamaru's read on the man matches: terrified, straight-answering, telling truth.
4. Asked for the weapons, the leader spurts lies. Amidamaru pulls the trigger, but the pistol is unloaded and nothing happens; the captain breathes back into himself, the pistol is no longer a threat.
5. Nyx steps up at Amidamaru's shoulder with an arrow nocked, and the pressure changes hands. The captain says they were hired months ago by merchants from a city he cannot name, paid in these curious weapons; the powder is for winter fires, he offers — the lie a giveaway of how little he intends to explain, and Amidamaru's own time of study is not enough to reconstruct the loading from combat memory alone. Their camp is west along a bearing he points out, and empty of anything worth taking — they sleep in the woods and only take rooms at taverns when the coin is fresh.
6. Nuberroca crosses to the captain who shot him and asks him plainly *"¿cómo se saca esta bola demoníaca que me has tirado?"* — the man answers honestly: they've dug bullets out a few times, and the men mostly die of fevers in the days after. Nuberroca tells him back, low and level, that if he dies of it the captain dies first — the man goes white.
7. ***[EPIC]*** Nyx pours vodka along the dagger to clean it; Kaelthar leans in and talks her through it, enough to guide her hand but not to steady the cut. Nuberroca drops into a full rage to ride out the pain. Nyx digs, does not sever an artery, and finally levers the pellet out; blood is sheeting out of the shoulder by the time she has it in her palm.
8. Mialee wraps the wound with strips torn from the dead bandits' clothing while a blue glow staunches the bleeding. Kaelthar uses a measure of his healing touch, but the wound itself is still open when they are done.

3 - The prisoners

1. Amidamaru opens the argument to the group: leave the three bound to a tree and let the road settle them. Nuberroca refuses and takes them for himself — properly fed they can pull their weight, and he has already promised the wounded captain a matched death if he tries anything. He walks them to Edhelri and posts them; she will not have three bandits riding on a wagon and says so, and they walk beside, tied.
2. Before the caravan re-forms, Mialee crosses to Edhelri and asks the names of the two guards who fell in the ambush — **Rand** from her own group and **Lews** from Noohar's. She then hands over five gold pieces, for their families alongside the salaries they were owed. The coin passes down the line hand-to-hand between the guards, in a way that tells the party they look after their own.
3. Later on the ride, Mialee presses a separate case with Edhelri: two guards lost, the surviving bandits could be persuaded to fill the gaps. Edhelri warms to the idea on the strength of the pitch, but Nuberroca — pulled into the conversation as the merchant's sergeant — stonewalls: the men wanted to rob them, not join them.
4. Nuberroca settles the argument with a truce: one week bound, and if they are still with the caravan out of troll country they can walk with pay. Mialee accepts — the point in her head was persuading Nuberroca, and she got it.

4 - The forced march

~14:00, 9 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party lays the dead in the ground and forms up — an hour and a half lost between the interrogation and the burials — and forces the march to make the next camping place before nightfall. Meals are eaten cold on the wagons, dry rations. When the wounded captain begins to fall behind, Nuberroca lifts him onto his own shoulder rather than let him drop.
2. Amidamaru works Munin at height over the road for the afternoon and evening. Among the guards Eguzkilore is now openly welcome for taking full four-hour watches on his elven trance. Meanwhile they find quiet ways to make the prisoners' walk unpleasant — a stumble here, a polearm haft as if by accident there.
3. At camp the wagons wheel into the usual circle; **Sulesdeg** *"the Pole"*, Beyd's bodyguard, comes across without ceremony, sets a jar of beer in front of each of the party members, quietly thanks them, and reminds them the jars are returned in the morning. Mialee hands hers to Nuberroca.
4. Nyx sets a warding rite on **Noohar**'s cart — the perfumes on his wagon make it the sweetest-smelling of the round. The night passes without incident.

5 - Fever

~08:00, 10 Uktar 1489 DR

1. At breakfast Amidamaru sends Munin over to Nuberroca — he does not want the suspected cultists to see him tending the goliath himself — and reads the wound through the owl's eyes. The bandage is soaked, and though a healing spell closes the skin the pus is welling under the seam. The flesh is red and hot, and the fever is coming in.
2. Four hours of road later Nuberroca is sweating hard and staggering; Edhelri, gentle about it, asks him to walk apart from the line in case the fever is catching.
3. The party rides on and passes into the **Fields of the Dead**. Munin brings back the picture of a country of grass and low tumuli, no trees to speak of, and — more troubling — the occasional carcass of a boar or a stag long dead and untouched by carrion birds.
4. Over lunch Amidamaru pours a stronger healing spell into the shoulder — the pain and the redness ease, but the fever holds; magic has closed the wound and the infection is inside the seam. Kaelthar readies the paladin's sense for the undead and holds it prepared for when the need arises.
5. Amidamaru rides forward to the head of the caravan and pulls the guards of the two cultist wagons into conversation. They admit — with more assessment than warmth — that the party carries the fighting, and one of them notes with mild fascination that the blue giant looks in rough shape.
6. Behind him a small commotion on the caravan — a stumble and a landing — and when Amidamaru turns he sees Nuberroca on the road, unconscious under the fever. Delirious, the goliath prays aloud through his teeth: *"Madre Árbol, mi carne está podrida por la sombra, pero mi espíritu no cederá. Enséñame qué raíz debo arrancar para expulsar esta enfermedad"*. **Beyd** rides across from his own wagon and presses a small cup into Nuberroca's mouth: a sweet, warm wine from his homeland, used for the fevers there. It takes some of the pain off, and the goliath is helped into the wagon under a blanket for the last leg of the day.

6 - Lights in the tumuli

~19:30, 10 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan pulls off the road for supper at the day's stopping-place — inside the Fields now, the road serpentines around the mounds and visibility off the shoulder is poor. Nuberroca is fed inside his wagon; the party eats around the fire.
2. Nyx catches a smear of light between two mounds off to the west — nine points, moving low and erratic, sometimes crossing under the ground and out again. She leaves the fire and works out to a rock at half-distance, hidden. Nyx's mental message reaches Amidamaru with the count and confirmation; he calls Munin back onto his shoulder to see through the owl's eyes too.
3. Kaelthar activates the paladin's sense for the undead and moves closer; a moment later his sense flickers on and off — between four and ten undead, moving beneath the earth.
4. Amidamaru calls out to the merchants, asking what the lights are. **Eldkin** answers in their stead — a caravan guard who has run this route many times — and admits the fault: distracted by the bandits and Nuberroca's collapse, the caravan forgot to keep fires down. Her stories: few travellers survive the lights, and none if they are already noticed.
5. Amidamaru turns himself invisible and walks west past Nyx, dropping a small orb of fire into a stand of dead branches at range — two of the nine lights peel out of formation and drift toward the burn. Four pebbles lit by artificer's magic and thrown further west draw off two more — four wisps drawn off in all, five left to fight.
6. Kaelthar puts a ward against the wicked on himself as a precaution, standing at the end of the party's line — the last thing he sees on the way in is a wisp materialising at his own side.
7. ***[EPIC]*** A crack of light against Kaelthar's flank drops him to one knee, his teeth close on his own scream and it comes out as a bellow. The other lights, all of them, wheel to the noise. Combat is on.

7 - The will-o-wisps

1. Nyx puts an arrow through the closest wisp at long range — the shaft passes through and drops to the ground but the light flickers; they're solid enough, just hard to hurt. Mialee mirrors the shot at a second and marks a hit — Echo, her bat familiar, can use its echolocation to find the invisible ones.
2. Amidamaru drops his shield in the dirt, hums his wizard's war-song to steady the blade, and closes with the rapier — a thunder-charm left ringing on the edge for any wisp that moves once the strike lands.
3. Kaelthar, surrounded and unable to see his attackers, pulls out of the ring with careful footing, spends his healing touch to close his own wounds, and falls back as far as his feet allow. The wisps' pattern reads: appear at the shoulder, strike, blink out. Each landed hit cracks hard with electricity; each miss unspools into the earth. All of them concentrate on Kaelthar — his first scream told them where the living were.
4. Nuberroca — watching from the wagon — remembers older wars: his tribe fought these heralds of the undead armies before, and the shamans used things that emitted light to end them, sometimes blessing the warriors' weapons for more damage. He pours holy water along the edge of his halberd, saved for a real cut. Nyx and Eguzkilore hold their arrows for the moment a wisp materialises, striking as it appears, and Eguzkilore steadies his aim, each shot a little surer. Mialee stays hidden, striking from the shadows.
5. Kaelthar goes down on a critical hit — one strike does it. The wisps, sensing the unconscious body, gather over him to feed. Amidamaru closes on the fallen paladin and pours a healing spell into him, hauling him back to his feet. Nuberroca lays a warband's vigour on Amidamaru so the mage can hold his ground at Kaelthar's shoulder.
6. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca lines the halberd against a wisp harrying Kaelthar and swings; the strike lands, one drop of holy water dripping down the shaft finds the wisp, and it moans out — a low keening like a soul in torment. A later swing puts the water more squarely, and this second wisp shrieks in pain, the light of it flaring before dimming. Nuberroca has found the weapon.
7. Kaelthar drops again — a glancing hit finding him barely healed. Nuberroca reaches him with the crook of the halberd, drags him back into range, and Amidamaru's second healing spell goes into the paladin as he passes.
8. Kaelthar drops a third time under another critical strike from an invisible wisp — Amidamaru has nothing left to cast. Mialee, hidden and reading the field through Echo, uses an unseen hand to feed one of her potions into the paladin's mouth; Kaelthar comes back to consciousness on the ground. Nuberroca lays a warband's vigour on him this time for extra vitality, and a red glow comes across his wounds, partially closing them.
9. Amidamaru is knocked flat by a critical strike from an invisible wisp.
10. ***[EPIC]*** As the wisp turns to feed on the tortle's body, Munin dives from above and takes the blast that would have killed him — the owl throws itself between the wisp and its master and dissolves under the light. A moment later, Nuberroca uses one of Amidamaru's own healing potions to bring him back.
11. The last wisps drop in short succession. Mialee's sneak-strike from the shadows catches one and its light begins to dim; Nyx sinks the last of her Dread Ambusher psychic bite into an arrow, and the final wisp winks out with a moan across the tumuli. Eguzkilore lifts a follow-up shot on the final wisp but the target is already dead. The party stands in the silent dark, most of them wounded and one — Kaelthar — unconscious on the ground again, stabilised only by Nuberroca's healer's hands.

8 - After the wisps

1. Nuberroca lifts Kaelthar onto his shoulder and carries him back into the light of the wagons. The guards close on the party with torches; Amidamaru waves them back and asks them to douse the light — don't attract any more of them — the party can see in the dark well enough to bring Kaelthar in.
2. Nuberroca has faced these things before with his tribe, and he can now tell the others: the lights feed on the unconscious. That is why they crowded around Kaelthar; that is why Munin's death bought Amidamaru his life — the familiar would have interposed itself.
3. By the fire that night the ordeal settles into them — the wisps' cold light burned into memory, the appear-strike-blink cadence learned in bone and hand. Footwork sharpens, strikes fall cleaner, an enemy's next move comes faster in the read. What the tumuli tried to take from them, they carry out the other side as strength.

Session 18

2025-08-10

1 - Silent darkness

~20:00, 10 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The lights have not come back. Kaelthar is stable on the ground, unconscious with the field dressing just barely holding him, and Nyx puts one of her berries into his mouth — the paladin stirs awake, still groggy. The camp fires are out and so is the mood, merchants and guards on cold dry rations, the caravan subdued around the ring.
2. Amidamaru crosses to the suspected cultist carts to speak with the guard who had come to the wisp fight and finds he is in fact a driver. Bloodied, he sits near them, and another driver presses a handkerchief into his hands for his wounds.
3. When Amidamaru asks what he would rather see done with the captured bandits — dead or free — the driver answers it is none of his business while they are not with the caravan, and he would not condone killing unarmed men; Amidamaru and Nyx read him as lying to keep up a civil front — the driver would rather see them dead.
4. Having whispered the plan to Nuberroca earlier, Amidamaru summons a small illusion of a wisp near the goliath. Nuberroca sells the panic, and **Sulesdeg** comes tearing in with a sword nearly the size of the goliath's — the blade cuts through the fake wisp and buries itself in the ground, and the guards raise their crossbows around the ring.
5. As the dust settles, Amidamaru overhears one of the cultists mutters that they should not trust the blue giant — the muttering guard's face registers as faintly familiar. Claws out, he rounds on them: how could they speak that way of the people saving their skins day after day? They had not fought the bandits or the wisps; when the trolls came, they would beg on their knees to be saved, and then they would see who saved them. He throws the handkerchief back in the guard's face.
6. Nuberroca steps up aggressively, and some cultist aim their crossbows at him. Amidamaru holds the goliath back — only uncultured and intolerant people — and when he presses that they had not even fought the bandits, one guard admits he had been there, pinning the familiarity.
7. The party settles for sleep; Eguzkilore takes the first four hours on his elven trance, which lets the rest of the party sleep uninterrupted and earns him some goodwill with the caravan's watch.

2 - Exotic feathers

~08:30, 11 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The night passes without incident. Nuberroca's fever lifts on the long rest. Amidamaru wakes earlier than the rest to burn incense and re-cast the ritual that calls **Munin** — the owl the wisps killed the night before. The caravan drivers keep well clear of what may or may not be hallucinogenic. Party sets out shortly after.
2. Perhaps an hour on the road, a bird crosses the sky against their line of march — long tail, red chest, blue and yellow wings, nothing anyone at the caravan has seen before and plainly the most beautiful bird any of them have ever seen in their lives. Sulesdeg raises his crossbow and takes the bird down with two bolts. The exotic bird is lugged into his wagon in a bloody heap.
3. A second bird — this one green — crosses at greater range some time later. Sulesdeg tries again but the shot is too long; the bolt goes wide. A third time, a flock of small birds boils up from behind a rise ahead and streams away over the wagons. Nyx takes it as a warning — when things fall out of the ordinary in this world, there is always a reason, and the reason is rarely a good one. She asks **Lai** whether the caravan can spare the time to check; he warns that stopping costs them their next camping-place. She goes forward alone anyway, and Amidamaru sends Munin overhead to shadow her.

3 - The bird merchant

~11:00, 11 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Cresting the rise, Nyx sees an overturned wagon defended by a handful of guards and one man in richer clothing — arrows still coming from a scatter of goblinoids around them, and a bugbear closing in to hammer the wagon between crossbow volleys. She hides and reads the field; there are several of them, and the shapes are hobgoblins, bugbears, and goblins in mixed cover. Amidamaru and Eguzkilore catch up on her steps and drop into cover.
2. Nyx opens with a shot to distract the pressure on the wagon — the arrow lands, and she calls out for the goblinoids to stop attacking and run, because a serious contingent is on its way and they are in trouble. The answer the goblinoids give is to turn on the party; a bugbear closes on Amidamaru, grabs him and drags him toward the rest without apparent effort.
3. Amidamaru sings up the shadow-blade and takes the bugbear on the spot — the strike lands, leaving a thunder reverberation waiting to crack on the creature. Nyx swaps her focus from a dying hobgoblin to a fresh target across the field, and the arrows keep finding shoulders and throats. From deeper in the goblinoid line, a heavier hobgoblin barks orders.
4. The party allies come up over the rise — a few of the caravan guards and the suspected cultists put arrows across the field at the bugbear nearest to Amidamaru, drawing blood but not dropping it.
5. Nyx takes a poisoned bolt to the shoulder and holds it — she can feel the poison burning across her skin — keeping the mark on her target through the pain. Kaelthar manages to join the fight; still too far for a javelin, so he uses his crossbow while closing in.
6. ***[EPIC]*** When the hobgoblin captain finally turns to run, Eguzkilore drives through a second volley of shots and puts three arrows into his running back — the fourth catches him as he falls. The rest of the hobgoblins fall back in disciplined formation, covering each other in leapfrog — a trained, heavily-militarised line, nothing like the goblins' panic — and the party holds fire as they clear.

4 - Oyn Evenmor

1. Three battered guards and the man in the fine coat come out from under the wagon: **Oyn Evenmor**, an exotic-bird merchant bound for Waterdeep, who bows and thanks the party for his life. Nyx introduces the party by name; Nuberroca and the rest catch up. Oyn admits he should have hired the Company of the Boar when they offered at the last tavern and did not, and he has lost most of his cargo — the cages sit open with dead birds inside or empty on the road.
2. Amidamaru magically mends some cages and casts a healing spell into each of the three guards, one after another. Oyn presses three coins of gold into Nyx's hand and closes her fingers over them — she reads it as light payment for the man's obvious wealth, but does not press.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Oyn thinks to ask after his birds. Nuberroca answers, straight-faced, that one of their own caravan has already caught one, and points at Sulesdeg. Sulesdeg produces the plucked, bloodied bird from the wagon on demand. Oyn's face goes rabid, then collapses; he sinks halfway to the ground before recovering, and rises telling the guard he is the worst person he has ever met, with the most twisted humour he has ever seen, undeserving of the air he breathes — that was the most valuable bird he carried. He turns his back and tells his own guards to hurry the repair.
4. Amidamaru buys two broken metal birdcages off Oyn — filigree wire, good for tinkering. He also asks a guard whether they have crossed anything strange on the road behind them: no, only the usual traffic, no cloaked strangers, and about four or five groups making toward Waterdeep.
5. Eguzkilore searches the hobgoblin captain — a longbow and a half-plate that the heroes mend and keep. The party recovers some arrows and lifts several poisoned shafts from the hobgoblins, then search the bodies for valuables, retrieving some silver coins.

5 - The wayside tavern

~20:00, 11 Uktar 1489 DR

1. As evening comes on, the caravan reaches a wayside inn on the road — *El Reposo en el Camino*, an undefended roadhouse with one tavern-keeper, **Olver**, who greets the party and offers rooms, food, and repair. Nyx pays a gold for a shared upstairs room with Mialee, then buys a round of beer for the six. The others share rooms, except Amidamaru who will sleep outside in his shell against the autumn cold.
2. A second party is already at the tavern — a table of four humans, warily eating: a barbarian in furs, a rogue in finer dress, a paladin with the trappings of a religious order, and a warlock at the back. Their leader climbs up on his own table and announces the company to the assembled merchants as **Jorath Vexundar**, famed leader of the *Company of the Boar* and slayer of villains without number; the paladin **Kaldan Voss**, who felled the lich of the Fields of Death; the warlock **Thorvin Caldorath**, who alone brought down a mountain giant with his magic; and the barbarian **Khorvalis**, the strongest of all time — a hire-on-the-spot pitch.
3. Nyx climbs onto Nuberroca's shoulders and answers back with her own, naming herself **Nyx Tukog** and the party the *Company of the Roe deer*, listing the wisps and the bandits and adding, small, that she had not even wet herself over the trolls — and gets no applause, since everyone already knew her.
4. At a separate table sit three wealthy travelers: a knight in armour, a mage in strange robes, and a nobleman. Kaelthar asks after the blazon he saw on their wagon; the noble brushes him off and, once Kaelthar is far enough away, whispers something in the knight's ear that the paladin cannot catch.
5. Nyx presses Jorath on the trolls — the Company of the Boar is credited with a good count of them — and Jorath prices the answer at one piece of gold. Nyx pays; Jorath draws her close and whispers the trick, then reveals a pendant against his chest with a very large tusk.
6. Nuberroca wanders across to the Company of the Boar's table and challenges Khorvalis to a pre-dinner brawl — *"¿te gustaría que nos pegáramos unas hostias?"*. Khorvalis declines — he reserves his strength for real enemies. When the trolls come up in Nyx's question and Khorvalis reckons them bigger than Nuberroca, the goliath invokes his people's gift and enlarges himself in answer. Khorvalis stays where he is — he does not use dirty tricks like magic to look stronger or to frighten his companions. Sulesdeg's beer falls over from the shock of the size-shift.

6 - The chest in the cart

~22:00, 11 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Mialee has been laying a plan through the dinner: she casts a silent image of herself at her table, and Amidamaru turns the elf invisible over the copy. The double stays at the table doing the small motions of a conversation while the rogue, unseen, slips out to the yard where the wagons are parked. Olver, at the door, sees the door open and close and mutters about the strong winds.
2. Nyx catches enough of the nobles' conversation at the other table to know they are in a hurry to Waterdeep — their cargo is beginning to spoil. The nobles rise and climb to their private room upstairs; Nuberroca, back in his normal size, follows and is pushed out at the door by the knight — through the closed door he catches talk of plebeians who could never amount to much, and the words *cursed mutants*.
3. Mialee reaches the cultist wagon and works her lockpicks on a chest inside, taking long enough that the illusory copy of herself at the table blinks out, causing a stir in the room, though she is still invisible on the way back and returns to her chair without being seen. What she found she keeps to herself, simply saying that there are people around and this is no safe place to talk.
4. As the party turns in for the night, a sudden heavy rain breaks over the roof and does not let up — Amidamaru keeps to his shell outside through the full of it.

Session 19

2025-08-19

1 - The chalice revealed

~08:00, 12 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Morning in **Olver**'s *El Reposo en el Camino*. The heavy rain that broke over the roof the night before is still coming down. The party gather in the privacy of their upstairs room and Mialee shows what she lifted the previous night. A **golden chalice**, its interior crusted with old blood, from the chest she had picked aboard the cultist wagon. Along with it a bundle of other valuables of the same cut — plate, buckle-work, a short knife with chased hilt — read by the party as loot that could as easily have come out of **Greenest** weeks before.
2. The chalice is treated as confirmation of what the party has long suspected about the three merchant wagons at the front of the caravan: cultists in the convoy, from the same operation that burned Greenest. The question in the room shifts from *are they* to *how do we move on it before Waterdeep*.

2 - A matter of horses

1. By mid-morning the common room has thinned, and **Lord Eldrin Kaldur** crosses it to the long table where the lead merchants are working through their own accounts. His knight **Jaxen Korrith**, who doubles as the cart's driver, stands a pace behind him in half-armour; his wizard **Thalor Cheston** keeps apart at the hearth, warming his hands.
2. The nobleman's pitch is brief: he and his are bound for Waterdeep, their cargo cannot wait on an escort of their own, and he would travel in company to the city rather than risk the open road alone. The merchants weigh it and agree. A travel-share is settled and a handshake is given.
3. The business of his horses is the longer conversation. Lord Kaldur does not conceal his contempt for the beasts — useless, hollow-flanked, half-dead on the yoke, and sure to founder before Waterdeep without a change. He will buy fresh horses from any merchant at the table who will sell, and he will not haggle over the price.
4. The merchants exchange looks and refuse: they need every animal they have for the days ahead. Lord Kaldur receives the refusal with ill grace and blames the gods for his luck.
5. From their own corner of the room the party watch the display over the dregs of breakfast. Nuberroca, who still carries the murmured *cursed mutants* that came through the closed door at him the night before, leans back on his bench and remarks loud enough to carry that between him and the lord, he is still working out which of them is the mutant.

3 - Fired at the inn

1. At the common-room tables, the **Company of the Boar** — **Jorath Vexundar**, **Kaldan Voss**, **Thorvin Caldorath**, and **Khorvalis** — close a hire with the merchants. The pitch wins out: four seasoned sellswords with trolls on the road not many days ahead. The rate the Company names is near the top of what the caravan's purse can bear; the merchants cannot stretch it to cover two guard contingents at once.
2. The merchants trim the roll on the spot. Amidamaru, Mialee, Nuberroca, and Kaelthar are paid out what they are owed to the day and let go; Nyx and Eguzkilore are kept on. The four released are welcome to keep travelling with the caravan — safer in company than alone, and the merchants are not above the trade — but without pay from that point.
3. The party take the decision badly and say so to the merchants' faces: this is a mistake, the Company of the Boar will not do the work that the party have done, and the merchants will come to see it before Waterdeep. The warning is heard and the merchants do not change their minds.
4. Nuberroca carries the point across to the Company's table and presses Khorvalis again for the duel he had tried for the night before — if the merchants mean to pay the Company's four over the party's six, then let the two companies' strongest settle on the common-room floor what the merchants have not settled in coin. Khorvalis declines the same way he had the night before: he reserves his strength for real enemies, and he will not brawl in a tavern for the amusement of merchants.
5. Lord Kaldur picks Kaelthar up on the spot as his own personal guard the moment the paladin is cut loose. The arrangement is private and settled by a short exchange at the noble's table.
6. Nuberroca, unwilling to walk the road for nothing, makes his own arrangement before the caravan sets out — a modest family travelling farther back in the line, **Darla** and her husband **Gus the humble** and their quiet friend **Anton**, take him on as guard for the price of a share of their food. He will ride by their wagon from that point.
7. Amidamaru finds Thorvin Caldorath at a corner table and closes a transaction long in the making: a flask of magical ink from the warlock's own supply, for a hefty sum of gold. **Munin** rides on his shoulder through the exchange, dry and preening after a long night under the rain. The ink is standard-priced for its kind. The scribing work that has waited on it since the first days of the caravan can now begin.

4 – North in the rain

~12:00, 12 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan rolls out of the inn into the rain later on 12 Uktar. The Company of the Boar ride at the merchants' flanks under their new contract; Lord Kaldur's cart rolls with them under the travel-share settled that morning, Kaelthar walking close by the noble's wagon as his hired guard. The three bound captives still walk tied at the back of the line.
2. Mialee works the gaps between the carts unseen through the day, listening in where the cultist drivers think themselves alone. She catches a line among them that will not leave her head — the cargo must reach **Naerytar** — spoken as a place rather than a person. She brings it back to the party at the next halt.
3. The name reaches Nyx, who, pressed on it, strains to place it and comes up with the barest flicker: she has read it somewhere in Greenest, perhaps a castle, nothing more. The party set it aside as something to ask after on the road to Waterdeep.
4. The ride out from the inn gives the party the full measure of why the beasts are in the state they are in. From his wagon-seat Lord Kaldur drives the pace from the back, calling the lash down on the horses' flanks through Jaxen Korrith's hand whenever they slow in the mud; no slackening at the climbs, no stop at the verges for grass, no breath at the water-crossings. Within hours the yoke-sores on both animals are weeping fresh under the harness, and the near horse is dragging its off-side hoof. The party watch it from down the line and keep their peace.
5. By the first halt Lord Kaldur is at the merchants' side again with the same offer and the same complaint he aired at the inn; the answer is the same. Amidamaru walks over to the noble's team while the argument carries, lays hands on each animal in turn and draws the worst of the wounds closed, then gathers grass by the handful from the verge and feeds them where their driver has not, and takes a few long minutes to comb the mud and tangles out of their manes. He will come back to them more than once on the road ahead.
6. The rest of the day carries on in the same ordinary flow of caravan travel in autumn rain: wheel-ruts filling, the midday meal on the wagons, watches cycled, the four unpaid keeping their own counsel at the back of the line. The caravan makes camp when the light begins to go, and the rain has not stopped once since the inn.

5 – A soaked day

~07:00, 13 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Camp strikes with everything already heavy — bedding, cloaks, boots, saddlebags soaked through the night under rain that has not slackened. Nothing dried, nothing warm, no fire to be had on the open road.
2. The ride is worse than yesterday's. Wheel-ruts have gone to channels of running water, the horses blow muddy clouds at every step, the carts slip sideways on the climbs and come near-lost at two of the water-crossings. Cloaks hang like lead on shoulders by midday; boots fill at every patch of flooded road; and the rain is still falling.
3. Amidamaru moves up the line to tend Lord Kaldur's team again at each halt — healing, feeding, combing out their coats as he can; the noble's demands on the horses have not softened, and without the artificer's hands the near beast would have gone down by now.

6 – Stones for bedding

~21:00, 13 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan reaches the night's camping place as the last of the light goes — the Trade Way has brought them to the northern edge of the **Fields of the Dead**, with the **Trollclaws** ahead. The rain is still falling. The ground is a pond.
2. Nyx hits on the idea that will save them a night on the saturated earth: she gathers a pile of flat stones and lays them under her sleeping mat as a dry platform. The others copy the trick for their own beds along the roadside. The camp is in small clusters on both sides of the road: the party together on one verge, the Company of the Boar and the three suspected cultist wagons on the other.
3. Kaelthar sleeps apart on the far side, close by Lord Kaldur's cart — the paladin keeps his watch where his new sworn duty lies. Nuberroca sleeps nearer the back, by the family's wagon.
4. Watches are set and the party go down one by one. The rain is still falling as the last of them finds sleep.

Session 20

2025-08-24

1 - Waking in the fungus

~06:00, 14 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Dawn comes thin behind a dense fog and the party wakes to the *pop, pop, pop* of caps still bursting out of the ground. The stone layer Nyx proposed the night before has kept their immediate radius clear; beyond that, everyone else in the caravan sits pinned in whatever small patch they overnighted in, wolves audible somewhere in the fog.
2. Each cap shrieks when it is touched or set swinging and vents a small cloud of black spores; the spores force anyone caught in the cloud to feel the fungus's own agony. No merchant will set a foot into the field.
3. Amidamaru, arms crossed, mutters that this is what the **Company of the Boar** are being paid for and can handle themselves — he is essentially paying to be on this caravan, not the other way around. Eguzkilore joins Nyx by the wagon and stays close; one of them asks **Eldkin**, the dwarven caravan veteran, for a shovel — she leans out of her wagon-bed with great care not to touch anything and tosses one across.
4. Amidamaru whispers a magical message across the road to **Thorvin** of the Company — *"¿Qué vais a hacer con los hongos? ¿necesitais ayuda?"* — and waits for the reply, but none comes. After a quick study of the fungus, he sends a second message: *"El fuego podría limpiarlas más rápido"*, and turns to the rest to say the caps are venomous but passable if the skin is protected.

2 - Clearing the road

1. Amidamaru sends Munin out to the far edge of his telepathic tether — a hundred feet of road — and from the air the owl can see what the fog has been hiding: the field of caps runs on another considerable stretch past that point, up to a small rise where the fog itself breaks and the caps appear to run out.
2. From there Munin starts burning a cart-wide corridor outward, breathing out a cone of flame with every wing-beat; the fire kills the caps cleanly and each burst quiets a shriek, but the dying caps release their spores all the same and Munin catches hundreds of little pulses of pain through the clouds; Amidamaru feels the owl's small chest tighten through the bond.
3. Nyx, meanwhile — a spare cloth from her kit tied over her nose and mouth against the spores — walks the road from the caravan side out toward the clearing's near edge, a hundred feet of careful, measured steps that thread between caps, with only a spore-puff or two set off along the way. When she reaches the cleared part of the road she turns and starts hammering back with the shovel toward the caravan, letting the spores settle before continuing.
4. **Mialee** pulls a torch from the wagon, dips it in a smear of the oil she keeps, and pushes it forward with her invisible mage-hand along the mid-line of the road, burning a narrow path ten feet wide back toward the party.
5. Amidamaru sends Munin on a second pass — finish the far end, then clean what he can out of the middle on the way back. The owl manages the far end, but on the return flight he can go no further; a few strides from where Nyx is working, he picks her out instead of flying on to Amidamaru and lands on her shoulder — an owl who had never let her touch him before, now clinging to her as a little ball, utterly wretched.
6. The caravan's own start trying it and mostly break. **Eldkin** picks up a torch, gets a few paces in, and curls into a ball on the ground, weeping — the spore-pain overwhelms her — and several others do the same. The Company of the Boar clear their whole side without a break, and their leader **Jorath** crosses the road to check on the party, kneels by Eldkin and gives her a swallow from a small canteen that steadies her.
7. **Lai**, seeing Eldkin starting to come around, picks the torch up himself, turns to Eguzkilore with a pointed look — *are you going to help or what?* — and Eguzkilore takes the torch and goes forward into the clearing to work it alongside Mialee's mage-hand for the final stretch.
8. When the two groups meet in the middle and the fog lifts, the applause runs mostly to the Company of the Boar. Amidamaru calls out over it — *he* had set the first fire. But the caravan's eyes stay where they were: the Company had worked their whole patch in plain sight, start to finish. Of the party, only Nyx had been visibly in it — shovel in hand at the far edge of the clearing — while the rest stood idle, until Eguzkilore picked up a torch at the very end.

3 – The dropped amulet

~19:00, 14 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The road holds no more surprises. That evening, at supper, Amidamaru signals Mialee that it is time to act, sits close to the first of the men they believe rides for the cult, and spreads his papers, diary sheets, and the dragon-shaped amulet in plain view before getting up to fetch a fresh pencil from a wagon.
2. Mialee, at prudent distance, flicks her invisible mage-hand and blows the papers up into the air across the cultist's group as if a gust had lifted them. The suspected men gather the sheets, glance at them but do not read, and one picks up the amulet — which speaks in a small careful voice: *"Amidamaru, tú eres el elegido, nos veremos pronto"*.
3. When Amidamaru returns the men are all watching him. One states carefully that his papers had fallen and his dragon amulet had spoken a message aloud. Amidamaru fakes a startle and asks what it said; the man simply looks away — the read is guarded, not quite hostile. He and Mialee compare notes by silent message: everyone reacted the same, no one broke, the plan had done nothing.
4. Watches split as usual: Eguzkilore takes the first, the Company of the Boar take the second and third — the caravan's regard for them keeps climbing.

4 – The Trollclaws

~08:00, 15 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The day passes without event. The caravan runs its usual rhythm: wake-up and breakfast on the roadside, three hours march, a long midday halt for lunch, three more hours of road in the afternoon, another halt, and the final two hours push before camping for the night. At each stop Amidamaru works his way down the line to **Lord Kaldur**'s cart — the noble's horses are limping and raw again from his ill treatment — and lays hands on them one at a time; by now it has settled into the routine.
2. The next morning the landscape thins, the burial mounds run out, and the party can begin to smell the marshes ahead — where the road climbs into low hills. Eldkin comes up alongside Nyx and, in a low voice, tells her they are entering troll country; similar warnings ripple through the other groups. The Company of the Boar loosen weapons in their sheaths for easier draw. Nyx asks Eldkin how often the trolls attack — almost never, only once worth mentioning across all her trips, plus one lone creature met by accident — and tells her she will scout ahead.
3. Amidamaru sends Munin high to watch the woods — from the air the vegetation here is visibly lusher than anything the caravan has crossed since the Fields of the Dead — and tells **Nuberroca** it is game country: if he wants meat for the caravan, this is the place.

5 - Ordning

~11:00, 16 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Nuberroca peels off to hunt. Munin drifts near him; both spot the same thing at once — a troll sat in a marsh almost two hundred feet off, happily eating a fish. Nuberroca rages — a mix of excitement and caution after so many days of boredom — and starts his approach, trying for stealth despite his size and his almost total inexperience at it. Munin returns to Amidamaru fluttering and pecking at his clothes, unable to explain through their bond what he has seen.
2. He closes to a rock about a hundred feet out from the troll's back. At that distance the troll catches his scent on the marsh wind, finishes its fish, and comes for him at a run, shouting the giant word for *food*.
3. Nuberroca throws a ration underhand, grows to match the troll's height and slightly overtake it, and calls out in giant: *"Creature, friend or foe?"*. The troll pulls up, takes the ration in a single bite, and replies a single word: *"Ordning?"* — something that translates roughly as *hierarchy*.
4. Nuberroca answers *"Me, king. Me, chief."* and gives it another ration. The troll pushes him experimentally; Nuberroca holds ground, calls out *"strong, strong, friends, we want to pass, no fight"* and tosses more rations. He flexes and puts a hand on the troll's shoulder — *"strong"* — the troll pushes his hand off without effort. He asks about the troll's chief; the troll only echoes *"chief"*.
5. ***[EPIC]*** By the time the rest of the party arrives at a prudent distance in cover, Amidamaru has reached out magically to ask what is going on, and Nuberroca whispers a reply back: *"todo controlado, estoy haciendo amigos"*. Nuberroca offers a final ration, says *"goodbye, friend"*; the troll takes it, gives him a puzzled look, and mutters *"Ordning"* before walking away. Nuberroca — running low on rations — returns to the caravan grinning, still giant-sized, and scares half the wagons stiff.

6 - Jorath's offer

1. On the march after, Jorath comes up alongside Nuberroca — the story travelled the moment he arrived doubled in size — and offers him a place in the Company of the Boar: they are always ready to take on another hand.
2. Nuberroca declines — he is already in another company, riding with this caravan only for the journey, and only for pay. Jorath drops the pitch and pulls back to the head of his group, a little embarrassed at the rebuff.

7 - Dinner and the cult

~20:00, 16 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Before turning in, Amidamaru pulls Nyx and Mialee aside — the plan on the table is to snatch, torture, and squeeze information out, with Nuberroca as the interrogator. Mialee approves, she is not going to oppose the plan. Amidamaru is careful about which specific cultist to target, he has grown fond of Paco.
2. Options are canvassed. Mialee proposes false troll-tracks to frame a snatch; Amidamaru worries about the audience Jorath's group now provides — that *company of the golden-fish* of theirs means more witnesses if the party is seen. The window is Eguzkilore's watch, though for some odd reason the caravan does not adore Eguzkilore the way they adore the Company of the Boar for burning a few caps.
3. Mialee turns to Nyx and asks whether she has an alternative plan. Nyx puts a floor on the risk: snatching someone roughly and interrogating them aggressively could mark a before-and-after in the party's standing with the caravan, and set off a hell of a mess right where they stood. The party's history of interrogation is bad — only the dwarf of Greenest ever got a cultist to talk, and never gently. They settle on waiting for a distraction — a troll attack, if it comes — to move under cover of chaos.
4. Nyx works the geography backwards: if the suspected cultists are riding this caravan all the way to Waterdeep, then **Naerytar** must sit near Waterdeep itself. Mialee adds that it is probably the stop just before the city, or a short detour off the road a day short of it.
5. Amidamaru walks over to **Selvek** the mute brother and, under the cover of small talk, sends him a magical whisper asking whether he knows where Naerytar is. Selvek's reply comes back as a thought: no, he does not.
6. Watches split as before: first Eguzkilore, then two and three for the Company of the Boar.

8 - The trolls come

~06:00, 17 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Screaming from a guard next to Nuberroca wakes the camp: a troll has yanked him from his bedroll and, in one bite, tears off half his neck, blood spattering the couple Nuberroca had been sleeping beside.
2. Nuberroca scans the camp — the Company of the Boar is nowhere to be seen. The party stands alongside the merchants and whichever guards are still awake.
3. Nuberroca is on the troll before it can release the guard. He moves to shield the couple, lets the fury take him, and drives his polearm into it, calling out *"Ordning"* on the strike. He swings recklessly, and again on the next beat; the troll goes down under him, wounded but still moving.
4. The goliath yells for the rest of the camp to fall back — these things are fast and strong. He demands aloud where the merchants who fired them and the Company who took the contract have gone. *"Que se los coman vivos"*, he says when told they must all be on the other side of the camp.
5. Amidamaru opens the party's magical answer, summoning a blade of shadow at his hand and closing on the troll Nuberroca has just dropped, striking with a resonant blow that hums after the swing. A camp sergeant follows up with a lance-thrust while the troll is sprawled, finishing it off in a chorus of pain.
6. Behind the party, the first troll — thought dead on the ground — hauls itself back up on half-regenerated limbs, grabs the sergeant by the back, and bites deep into his neck.
7. Fresh trolls come in from the woods. On the pack's first charge, Nuberroca sweeps his polearm into a charging troll at full stride and knocks it flat before it can close.
8. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore drops back a step, pours a flask of oil over the arrows in his quiver, sinks his torch upright in the ground, and starts firing arrows through the flame so each shaft carries a small tongue of fire into the oncoming pack.
9. Mialee — knowing trolls burn but not much else — throws up a phantom bonfire near the incoming trolls, betting on their brute wit to route them around it; two of the trolls take it as real and hesitate around the illusion, one shrugs it off.
10. Amidamaru weaves the sword-song into his movement and hurls a chromatic orb of fire into a wounded troll — the ball bursts in its chest and starts melting the slime off it. Munin, high overhead, breathes out another cone of fire over three of the trolls together, dropping one and burning the rest badly.
11. Kaelthar joins the fight — a pale light wrapping him, a dead run at the nearest troll on the ground — and strikes down into it hard, then again on the backswing. Between swings he lets loose his fire breath — one troll drops, the other stays up but hurt. A moment later a bite tears into him, a troll's claw slips past his guard and the pale light around him winks out.
12. Nyx picks target after target with the longbow, settling into a rhythm — one shot, step, pick again — and chews through the badly-wounded trolls one by one; early in the fight she puts one on the ground with a particularly devastating opening shot. Nuberroca lays a hand on Amidamaru's shoulder; something fierce passes between them and Amidamaru steadies. Mialee slips an arrow in from the flank where the troll cannot see her. Eguzkilore follows up with a shot straight into a downed troll to make sure it does not get up.
13. With most of the pack down, Nuberroca grows huge again mid-swing and roars *"ORDNING"* at the last standing trolls. The last troll to reach Amidamaru chips pieces off his shell with claws but breaks nothing he cannot heal. When the last of them is down, Munin lands and torches one with a final cone of fire; Amidamaru salutes — *he plays like a dragon*.

9 - Aftermath

1. Four of the defenders lie dead and three are wounded — a battered sergeant, another guard bleeding badly, and **Paco**, mostly untouched. Two of the fallen are guards the party had marked as cultists. The merchants and civilians are all alive — the guards took the bill.
2. The Company of the Boar is confirmed gone — not among the dead, not anywhere in the camp — and four of the caravan's horses are missing with them.
3. Amidamaru lays a healing on the wounded; Paco politely refuses, telling him he is holding up. Meanwhile Mialee moves to search the bodies of the guards they had marked as cultists, finding some spare coin but nothing useful.
4. By the fire, Amidamaru and Nuberroca argue over the credit — Amidamaru claims every troll kill; Nuberroca insists he speared each one and never saw them get back up.

Session 21

2025-09-07

1 - Lost horses

~06:30, 17 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The fight is barely over and Amidamaru opens with the one thought that will drive the morning — making the *"company of the golden fish"* pay for abandoning them. Nyx, half an eye still on the camp, slips off to read the ground for horse-tracks while the rest keep arguing. Eguzkilore reasons through it: the Company of the Boar had only two directions open to them, forward or back; had they taken the road north, they would already be ahead of the caravan and bound to be caught sooner or later — so they must have fled south, back the way everyone came.
2. The count is laid out — four horses missing: two guard mounts, two draft animals, one from a cultist-suspected merchant's wagon and another from **Beyd** the beer-trader's cart. Amidamaru checks after **Noohar** — the merchant who initially hired him — only to find out he has no escort.
3. Amidamaru turns the merchant-group himself — pulls them into a loose half-circle and makes his case: with four horses short, someone will have to drop a cart; the ones who promised to protect them have run; those still here fought and bled without a plate of food between them. Nuberroca draws his lance behind Amidamaru and declares that they will be ready if things come to it.
4. The merchants chew on it and settle: nobody drops a cart. Beyd's cart ties onto another cart and pulls with one horse; the three suspected-cultist merchants will do the same with their own cart. **Eldkin** is asked how far the troll country runs — three more days to leave it, roughly ten to the main Trade Way. Nobody is willing to peel off six horses to go hunt the four stolen ones; priority is Waterdeep.
5. Nyx returns to say the tracks go north, no older than four hours; running them down would need horses they don't have and leave the caravan unguarded. The decision stands: continue north together.

2 - New wages

1. **Lai** opens with promotions. Nyx moves from sergeant to bodyguard and Eguzkilore to sergeant; **Edhelri** takes Mialee back as bodyguard with a hefty raise, after the slight the merchant had done her. **Noohar** hires Amidamaru as bodyguard again.
2. Nuberroca stands apart. He turns to the merchant group and demands gold, flat-out, as the price for the lives he has already saved — making clear the commoner family he had been camping beside stays protected either way. The merchants mutter, pool a coin each, and come up with four pieces together; Nuberroca pockets them, says *"he hablado"*, and walks off.
3. Camp strikes — graves for the four dead soldiers, pyres for the trolls, two hours before the wagons move again.

3 - Shapes in the sky

~16:00, 17 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Afternoon on the road, Amidamaru keeps **Munin** circling high and gets back a report of four shapes a long way off, wheeling in a circle like vultures but wrong for the size. He pings Nyx with a magical whisper in her ear and sends her forward with Munin flying ahead.
2. Nyx and Munin close to the brush edge; Nyx fails to recognize the shapes, but Amidamaru is sure they are not vultures. The shapes have already spotted them and are turning in. Munin tucks into a bush ready to vanish if danger closes in; Nuberroca lets the fury take him and rushes forward through the brush.

4 - The perytons dive

1. The lead bird comes down the sky like a peregrine falcon — talons first, beak after — and takes Nyx on the way through. Only up close does the shape resolve: a parasitic predator Nyx has heard of in a dark story, something that feeds on hearts.
2. Kaelthar slips to a tree, draws a shortbow, and lays an arrow through the first bird's feathers from a long distance off. The arrow lands but the plumage soaks most of the damage.
3. Nyx pins her hunter's mark on the diving bird, using her powers to put a black-glowing arrow through its chest, leaving it staggered. Amidamaru shrugs the shield off his arm so he can weave his sword-song, draws a **Shadow Blade** out of thin air, and chops with it and his off-hand dagger. Mialee throws up a bank of fog behind Nuberroca and ducks out of sight.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca runs headlong into the fog as if fleeing, pivots inside it, and vanishes into a jaunt that sets him well up in the air, polearm first, to spear the lead bird. He misses, drops the lance in the air and throws everything into a grapple instead, wrestling the bird mid-air by the wings as it falls. The two of them hit the bushes together — the bird takes the worst of it, Nuberroca dulls the pain through his rage. He drags it still-grappled into the fog where it can only fight blind.
5. A second peryton dives in on Nyx: beak and claws tearing at her. Amidamaru casts a spell to distract the creature, but the hit lands anyway and Nyx goes down unconscious. Her last shout to the field is that these things *need hearts*; nobody knows what for. A beat later Amidamaru throws himself bodily onto her, shell up, as cover.
6. Mialee ducks and darts to Nuberroca's shoulder in the fog, guided by sound and his own call-out. She appears to see where he can only hear and cuts the grappled bird twice with her twin scimitars. The bird is a mess of plumage but still breathing. Eguzkilore stays at range, puts two arrows into the peryton on Kaelthar's side of the field, then catches his breath and shifts into position behind the fog before the birds can retaliate.
7. Amidamaru, almost on instinct, pops one of his share of Nyx's berries between her lips — she comes around dizzy and weak. On the next swing he puts the Shadow Blade through the nearest bird with a deafening boom of thunder.

5 - A rogue griffin

1. Above the fight, over the camp's own shouting, a far larger pair of wings rolls in from the south — a gigantic griffin, muzzled and with mittens on its claws, coming down on the lead peryton in a stooping dive. The griffin can hook the bird but the muzzle keeps it from doing damage; a flurry of plumes rises off the pair.
2. ***[EPIC]*** As the griffin pulls up, a figure comes off its back — Sinsong, choosing the moment to let go — and falls through the air gracefully. A dozen feet from the ground angelic wings sprout from his shoulders and a ring of pale celestial figures spreads out around him, attacking anything within a few paces. He glides low so the ring sweeps the three birds together.
3. The celestial guardians wound two of the perytons; the three of them turn and bolt straight up, avoiding the magical creatures. Nuberroca pulls a rope from his pack and ties his grappled bird at beak and wings — down and out of the fight — then tries to grow huge again, but he is too exhausted to manage it.
4. Two of the fleeing birds catch Nyx by the shoulders and lift her into the air, bound for the sky; she twists and shakes but fails to escape.
5. Kaelthar's draconic wings beat open and he magically teleports up to reach the two carrying birds in the air — he lets fly a cone of dragon-fire that takes both perytons and the unconscious Nyx in the same arc; both birds are severely hurt but hold on.
6. ***[EPIC]*** Amidamaru pulls a diamond chip from his belt and arcs a small sphere of fire upward: it bursts on the first fleeing bird and consumes it on the spot, then jumps onto the second turning it into a ball of burning feathers. Nyx falls limp from the dying bird's grasp as the sphere bursts across her face.
7. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore has one chance and throws everything into the catch — he vaults into the trajectory, getting his arms under Nyx just before she hits the ground.
8. Sinsong quickly summons a bond of magical aid on the three of them and Nyx is on her feet with an open chest but her heart untouched, the open wound partly closing under a soft red glow.
9. Nuberroca walks over to the bird he had tied, draws his lance, and puts it through the heart; then coils the rope, picks up the lance, and he is done.

6 – An unwanted pendant

1. The griffin is loose now — it works the muzzle off its beak and then tears the mittens off its claws, and once free it is nervous and will not stay still. Sinsong moves to introduce it as **Targutai**, a gift from a merchant he met on his detour; the griffin can be handled if nobody startles it.
2. With the griffin loose and nervous and Nuberroca walking straight toward it — fresh from boasting that lethal damage is necessary — Sinsong fears for the beast and speaks a word of command on him: *flee*. The barbarian dashes a long way north before his own protest can land.
3. Nuberroca turns back moments later; on the way in he sees Sinsong gesturing a second cast and holds himself ready. The cleric whispers a sleep-spell to pin him before he can retaliate; Nuberroca teleports clear of its area before the words land.
4. From that safe distance Nuberroca throws the stone Sinsong had once given him back at the dwarf's face and walks away.
5. Sinsong fills the gap of the lost days over the quiet that follows: he drifted away from the party in Baldur's Gate and didn't find them afterwards. He was lost in the city for three days, then bartered a griffin from a merchant he befriended in order to reach them again. Along the way he passed a lone cart with an unusual bird on the merchant's shoulder, a group of trolls, and some burial-mound pyres. Amidamaru reads him as hiding something but no more than Sinsong always does.

7 – A wolf called Fenrir

~21:00, 17 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan beds down early. Sinsong fits the mittens and muzzle back onto Targutai, with Nuberroca helping gently when asked; they tie the griffin at a tree well away from the camp horses. Nyx, badly cut across the chest, rests for the whole time.
2. Kaelthar summons his bonded mount out of nothing in the shape of a giant wolf — **Fenrir**, wits no sharper than a regular wolf's, but fine for pulling a cart or startling anyone who comes close. Amidamaru takes first watch with Eguzkilore; Nuberroca and Mialee take second.
3. Amidamaru explains the pair of new animals to the caravan when the questions come — the griffin will be kept far from the horses and Fenrir is indeed a very docile wolf.

8 – Moving north

~08:00, 18 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan rolls out at dawn. Sinsong holds the griffin under control with effort and a word of command ready if the bond slips, feeding him one of Nyx's berries to steady him before departing.
2. Along the way, Nyx finds prints that are at least a couple days old. Sinsong mounts the griffin and strikes north to scout for the stolen horses while the caravan rolls on. The road through the end of troll country is light on sign.
3. Night falls with Sinsong still in the field. He casts a *sending* spell over to Nyx — tracks of two or three horses heading north, it is dark and there is no fire. The next day he searches on and finds nothing more, then turns back; it takes him until the following night to reach the caravan.
4. At the camp reunion, Sinsong admits that the *command* and the *sleep* spells had been to keep Nuberroca off a griffin he was sure the goliath meant to kill; when he presses on Nuberroca's loyalty, Nuberroca tells him he has no more talismans worshipping any false god. Sinsong tries to return the stone as if dropped by accident; Nuberroca refuses to even look at it.
5. The remaining days run quiet — Targutai pulling with the carts, Fenrir alongside, with the caravan edging out of troll country.

9 - Broken crates

~16:30, 23 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Mid-column, Targutai turns on the draft horse harnessed next to him and takes a bite out of its neck; the horse screams, tears the harness, and bolts. The griffin snaps the lines on his side and goes after it at low altitude.
2. Sinsong, with the chaos exploding around him, throws a sleep-spell at Targutai to stop the rampage, but the griffin twists free of the weave even after Amidamaru's attempt to distract the beast. Sinsong uses his magic on Targutai again — a command of *come to me* — and the griffin only just gives in, halting in mid-chase. Nyx and Eguzkilore break off to run down the fleeing horse.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca jaunts into the air above the suspected-cultist cart that Targutai had torn loose from, and lets himself fall into its cargo bed. Amidamaru starts coaxing the split harness back together with a word of mending as the shouting goes up around them. Before the guards wrestle Nuberroca off the wagon, he cracks one of the crates with a slam of his shoulder; the wood splits enough to show a glint of something metallic within. He plays the whole thing off with a thin apology for how clumsy he is, but no-one is convinced.
4. The suspected merchants' guards draw crossbows on him in seconds; Nuberroca stands up and tells them to fire if they have the stones. **Paco** — the one Amidamaru has always said is likeable — is the first to lower his crossbow and ask Nuberroca to keep away from their carts, promising no quarrel if the barbarian does the same. Amidamaru and Mialee together, playing to the merchants' nerves, talk the standoff down.
5. Nyx and Eguzkilore come back with the wounded horse and a bloody scrap of cloth cut from the brush where they caught it; by the time they arrive the cart is together again under Amidamaru's hands. The tortle studies the cloth and recognises it as **Khorvalis**'s; Nyx tells them that she also saw dried blood and a torn horse-hoof in the brush, and thinks the trolls got at least one of the stragglers.
6. Sinsong flies Nyx up on the griffin to search west of the road for signs of the stragglers. Meanwhile, Amidamaru uses his magical whisper to ask Nuberroca, and the barbarian replies along the same magical thread — jewels and coin in the crates. Overhead, Nyx finds Khorvalis's severed hand and his axe at a wider patch of churned ground; Sinsong *sends* the find back to Amidamaru — the pattern reads *trolls*.
7. Flying back towards the caravan, Sinsong floats breaking the carts open now. Nyx cuts him off: better to let the carts reach their stop so the party can find **Naerytar** at the end of the trail.

10 - The painted stone

~12:00, 27 Uktar 1489 DR

1. After four quiet days, during which Sinsong keeps Targutai in hand with constant supervision and the command of return held in reserve, they are finally approaching the main Trade Way road.
2. When they glimpse the intersection, they notice a large piece of stone sitting in the middle of it, painted with something they cannot make out — and they are sure it is moving.